

Marriage in Ministry

*Protecting the Covenant When the Church Demands
Everything*

JAMES BELL

Marriage in Ministry

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Unless otherwise noted, Scripture quotations are from the English Standard Version (ESV).

*Therefore a man shall leave his father and his mother
and hold fast to his wife, and they shall become one flesh.*

GENESIS 2, VERSE 24

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INTRODUCTION

The Marriage That Ministry Nearly Cost Me

I ALMOST LOST HER to the church.

Not to another man. Not to bitterness she nursed in private until it hardened into a wall I could not climb. Not to any of the failures that get named from pulpits when pastors talk about marriage, the failures we are comfortable confessing because they belong to other men. I almost lost Susanna to the very thing I had given my life to serve. I almost lost my wife to the work of God. And for years I could not see it, because the thing taking her from me wore the face of obedience, and a man does not easily suspect his obedience of theft.

There is a particular cruelty in the marriages that fail inside ministry, and the cruelty is this. The thing pulling the husband away from the wife is not shameful. It is praised. When a businessman neglects his wife for his career, the church has language for that. We call it idolatry, we call it misplaced priorities, we say he loved his work more than his family and we are right to say it. But when a pastor neglects

his wife for his congregation, the church has no such language ready, because the congregation is the work of God, and who will stand up in a deacon meeting and say the pastor loves God too much. The pressure that takes the pastor's marriage is sanctified pressure. It comes dressed for Sunday. And a man can spend fifteen years giving his wife the leftovers of his attention and call it sacrifice, call it laying down his life, call it the cost of the call, and never once suspect that the cost was being charged to an account that was never his to spend.

I want to tell you about a Tuesday afternoon, because Tuesdays are where marriages actually live or die, not Sundays. It was early in my time at First Baptist Church of Fenton. Susanna had asked me, not for the first time, to be home by six. There was nothing dramatic in the request. A child needed help with something. She had been alone with the boys all day and she was at the end of what one body can carry. She did not want a date. She did not want romance. She wanted my presence in the house at the hour I had promised it. And I was not home by six. I was at the church, in a meeting that mattered, with people who needed me, doing work that was real and good and necessary, and when I finally came through the door at half past eight I did not even feel guilty, because I had been about the Lord's business. That was the line I used. The Lord's business. As though the Lord had business that required me to break my word to my wife. As though the God who instituted the covenant of marriage in the garden, before there was a temple, before there was a single congregation to pastor, would be honored by a man who tended the gathered people of God while letting the first congregation of his own house go hungry.

I have come to believe that the marriages of pastors are

under a pressure that no ordinary marriage manual names, and that this pressure is so woven into the texture of the call that most of us cannot see it any more than a fish can see water. We have shelves of books on marriage. Good books, many of them. Tim and Kathy Keller wrote one in 2011 called *The Meaning of Marriage* that I have given to a hundred couples and will give to a hundred more, because they understand that marriage is a covenant before it is a contract and a sanctification before it is a satisfaction. But even the best of those books assumes a husband who comes home from a job, and the pastor does not come home from a job. The pastor comes home from a calling, and a calling does not punch a clock, and a calling does not stay at the office, and a calling will follow you through the front door and sit down at your dinner table and put its hand on your shoulder while your wife is telling you about her day, and you will be nodding at her and you will not have heard a word.

This is the pressure I mean. The church can become the other lover. I am going to say that plainly at the start because the whole book depends on it, and because I have watched pastors flinch from the phrase as though it were irreverent. It is not irreverent. It is Hosea. The prophet Hosea, in the eighth century before Christ, was commanded by God to marry a woman who would be unfaithful to him, and the whole brutal point of that marriage was to show Israel what their idolatry felt like from the inside of a covenant. God spoke of himself as a betrayed husband. The language of the other lover is biblical language, and what I am telling you is that a pastor can commit a kind of marital infidelity in which the rival is not a woman but a building full of people who need him, and that this infidelity is harder to repent of than the other kind, precisely because it never feels like sin. It feels like

faithfulness. The man giving his best hours, his sharpest attention, his most tender emotional energy to the congregation, and bringing home to his wife a husband who is used up, distracted, and already thinking about Sunday, is committing something the marriage feels as abandonment even when the theology cannot name it as such.

I did this. I want to be clear that this is not a book written by a man who watched other pastors fail and took notes. I am inside the indictment. There were years when Susanna carried our home, our sons, our finances, the endless invisible labor of being a pastor's wife in a small town where everyone knew her name and no one knew her exhaustion, and she carried all of it while married to a man who was technically present and functionally absent, a man whose body sat at the table while his mind sat in the sanctuary. I gave the church my first fruits and gave her the gleanings. And the most damning part, the part I can still barely write, is that I thought I was being a good and faithful servant the entire time. I had a category for adultery. I had no category for what I was actually doing.

So this is a book of confession before it is a book of instruction, and it has to be, because the instruction will not land on a man who still believes he is innocent. I am going to name the pressures that take the parsonage marriage, and I am going to name them one at a time, slowly, because they hide. The fishbowl of congregational expectation, where your marriage is a public exhibit and your wife is a volunteer no one hired. The invisible load she carries that no one sees and no one thanks her for. The reason she cannot say what she really feels, because her honesty could cost you your job and she knows it. The mind that never leaves the church. The slow displacement of intimacy by activity, until the marriage

is a logistics company that occasionally remembers it was once a romance. The criticism that follows you home and poisons the one place that was supposed to be safe. The temptation, the subtle and disgusting temptation, to use your own marriage as a sermon illustration, to brand your wife, to make even your intimacy a ministry asset. And underneath all of it, the question that the rest of the book exists to answer. How do you protect a covenant the church is quietly trying to take.

I do not write any of this to make ministry sound like a curse. It is not a curse. It is a high and holy calling and I would not trade it. But Eugene Peterson, who pastored one congregation in Maryland for twenty-nine years and who understood the pastoral vocation more honestly than almost any man of his century, wrote in his memoir *The Pastor* in 2011 that the great temptation of the pastor is to become a busy and important religious professional and to lose, in the busyness and the importance, the very souls closest to him. He meant his own soul. He also meant, I think, the soul of his wife Jan, who was beside him for all twenty-nine years and most of whose labor no congregation ever recorded. Peterson knew that the pastor's first parish is his own household, and that a man who saves the congregation and loses his marriage has not succeeded at ministry. He has failed at it in the one place the failure does not show up in the attendance numbers.

The church will demand everything. That is not a flaw in the church. A living congregation is a hungry thing, and it will eat as much of you as you set in front of it, and it will always be hungry again by morning. The demand is not the problem. The problem is the man who has never decided in advance what he will not give, and who therefore gives it all, and

discovers too late that the part he gave away without thinking was the part that belonged to his wife. This book is about deciding in advance. It is about building a wall around the covenant, not a wall of resentment toward the people I serve, but a wall of fidelity to the woman I promised, so that when the church demands everything, as it will, there is one thing it cannot have, because that thing was given away first, at an altar, before any of these people knew my name.

*The church will eat as much of you as
you set in front of it, and it will always
be hungry again by morning.*

SUSANNA AND I ARE still married. I tell you that now so you do not read the coming chapters as a tragedy. By the mercy of God and by the slow, costly work of repentance that is not finished and never will be, the marriage that ministry nearly cost me did not die. But it nearly did, and the nearness is the point, and I will not sand the nearness down to make either of us comfortable. If you are a pastor reading this, or married to one, I am not going to tell you that loving your spouse and serving your church are the same act flowing from the same love, as the conference speakers like to say. Sometimes they are at war. Sometimes you have to choose. And the whole of this book is my attempt to tell you, from inside my own failure and from inside the grace that met me there, how to choose her, and why choosing her is not a betrayal of the call but the proof that you ever understood it.

CHAPTER ONE

The Other Woman Who Takes Your Best Hours

A MAN WHO IS having an affair gives himself away in his calendar before he gives himself away in his confession.

You can see it in the hours. The hours go somewhere, and wherever a man's best hours go, that is where his heart has gone, whatever his mouth is saying. So when I tell you that the church can become the other lover, I am not making a poetic flourish. I am talking about hours. I am talking about the specific, accountable, irrecoverable hours of a man's one life, and where they actually went, as opposed to where he would say they went if you asked him at a deacons retreat what his priorities were. He would say God first, family second, ministry third. Every pastor says it. I said it for years. And my calendar said something different, and the calendar does not lie, and Susanna could read the calendar better than I could because she was the one living in the hours the church did not want.

Here is the cruelty of it again, because we have to keep returning to the cruelty or the whole thing softens into

something forgettable. The other woman, in the ordinary affair, gives the man pleasure, and the pleasure is what the family cannot compete with. But the church gives the pastor something more dangerous than pleasure. The church gives the pastor meaning. It gives him significance, the sense that his life counts, that his hours are spent on something eternal. And a man can walk away from pleasure when he is convicted, because pleasure does not defend itself with theology. But meaning defends itself. When I gave the church my best hours, I was not chasing a thrill I could be ashamed of. I was chasing the feeling of being useful to God, and that feeling is a narcotic stronger than any affair, because no one will ever tell you that you took too much of it. The congregation will only ever ask for more, and they will praise you for giving it, and your wife, who is asking for less of you so that she can have more of you, will look in that economy like the selfish one. Think about how upside down that is. The institution asking for all of you looks holy. The woman asking for some of you looks needy. And the pastor in the middle, who genuinely wants to do right, almost always sides with the institution, because the institution speaks the language of calling and the wife speaks the language of need, and we have been trained to distrust need and to obey calling.

I remember a season at First Baptist when we were in the middle of something genuinely good. The church was growing. People were coming to faith. I was preaching better than I had ever preached, studying late, available to anyone who called, and I want to be honest that those were some of the most spiritually alive months of my ministry. And they were some of the worst months of my marriage, and the two facts sat right next to each other and I could not connect them, because I had a theology that told me a flourishing

ministry and a flourishing marriage rose and fell together, and my actual life was disproving that theology every single day. The ministry was flourishing precisely because I was starving the marriage to feed it. I was taking the hours that belonged to Susanna and laying them on the altar of the congregation, and the congregation was growing fat on the very hours that were leaving my wife hungry. There is a grim accounting in that. The church was full because the parsonage was empty.

Let me describe the best hours, because the phrase is too abstract until you name what the best hours actually are. The best hours are not the most hours. A man can spend a great quantity of time at home and still give his home nothing, because he is physically present and emotionally elsewhere, and we will come to that, the absence inside the presence, in its own chapter, because it deserves one. No, the best hours are the hours of a man's peak energy and peak attention, the hours when his mind is sharp and his heart is open and he is capable of the kind of presence that another human being can actually feel. For most of us those hours are not many. We get a handful of them a day. And the question that decides a marriage is not how many total hours you spend at home but where your handful of best hours goes. Mine went to the church. By the time I came home, the sharp hours were spent. I gave Susanna a tired man, a man running on fumes, a man whose capacity for attention had been drained dry by ten hours of giving himself to other people. She did not get the husband. She got the husk of the husband. The church got the husband. And no one in the church knew that the warm, attentive, fully-present pastor they enjoyed on a Wednesday evening was a man whose wife had not seen that version of him in weeks.

This is the displacement I want you to feel before we go further, because everything else in the book grows out of it. There is a finite amount of a particular kind of attention in a human being, a relational, emotional, present-tense attention, and it does not regenerate quickly. A pastor spends his whole working day spending it. He spends it on the grieving widow, on the couple in crisis, on the elder who is angry, on the new believer full of questions, on the staff member who needs encouragement, on the three hundred faces on Sunday morning each of whom believes, not wrongly, that the sermon was for them. By the time the pastor gets home he has been emotionally present to dozens of people, and the well is dry, and his wife, who has been waiting all day for her turn, gets the bottom of the bucket. And here is what makes it so hard to repent of. He was being kind all day. He was being patient and attentive and loving all day. He just spent all of it before he got to the one person to whom he had made a vow. He was generous with everyone who had not promised to spend their life with him, and stingy with the one who had.

*The church got the husband. Susanna
got the husk.*

KATHY KELLER, IN THE Meaning of Marriage, makes a point that took me years to understand and that I think every pastor needs to have driven into him with a hammer. She says that marriage is the most fundamental relationship, the one that all others must serve and not undermine. Not the most important compared to God, but the most fundamental

among human relationships, the relationship from which a man's other relationships should flow and to which they should defer. And what I had done, without ever deciding to do it, was invert that order. I had made the congregation the fundamental relationship and the marriage the one that had to flex around it. Susanna's needs were negotiable. The church's needs were not. If the church called during dinner, I took the call. If Susanna needed to talk during my study time, I asked her to wait. The pattern of a thousand small decisions, none of them dramatic, none of them adulterous in any way a court or a congregation would recognize, added up to a marriage in which my wife had learned that she came second to several hundred people she had not married and could not divorce.

She never said it that starkly. That is part of the trap, and we will give the whole chapter to it later, the reason the pastor's spouse cannot say what she really feels. But she said it in smaller ways, the ways a person uses when the direct way is closed to them. She stopped asking me to be home by six, because asking and being disappointed was worse than not asking. She stopped telling me the smaller things about her day, the things that are the actual substance of intimacy, because a man who is clearly somewhere else is not a safe place to put the small and tender things. She became efficient with me. Our conversations became logistics. Who was picking up which son, what was happening on Saturday, whether I had remembered the thing I had promised to remember and usually had not. The romance did not end in a fight. It ended in a series of administrative exchanges between two people running an organization called a household, and I did not even notice the romance was gone, because I was busy, and busyness is the perfect anesthetic.

You cannot feel the wound if you never stop moving long enough to feel anything.

I want to say something now to the pastor who is reading this and feeling defensive, because I know the defensiveness from the inside. You are thinking that I do not understand the demands of your particular church, that your situation is different, that you have a board that expects sixty hours, a congregation in crisis, a building campaign, a denomination breathing down your neck, that you do not have the luxury of giving your best hours to your wife because if you did the whole thing would collapse. I understand that thought because I had that thought, and I want to tell you gently that the thought is the affair talking. The other woman always has a reason you cannot leave her tonight. The reason is always urgent and always real. There is always one more meeting, one more soul, one more fire that only you can put out. And if you wait for a season when the church does not demand your best hours, you will wait until your children are grown and your wife is a stranger and the marriage is a corpse that the two of you keep dressed for Sunday. The church will never voluntarily release your best hours. You have to take them back. You have to decide, in advance, in cold blood, which hours belong to her and defend those hours against the church the way you would defend them against another woman, because functionally that is exactly what the church has become.

Bonhoeffer, writing from a prison cell in 1943, in a letter to his niece on the occasion of her wedding, said something that has hung over my study for years. He told the young couple that their love was their own private possession, but that marriage was more than something personal, that it was a status, an office, a post in the world that held the two of them

together even when their love faltered. I have thought about that word, office, in connection with the pastorate, because the pastor of all people understands what an office is. He holds one. And what Bonhoeffer was saying is that the husband holds an office too, the office of husband, and that this office has its own duties that do not bend to the duties of his other offices. The man is not only a pastor who happens to be married. He is a husband who happens to pastor, and the husband came first, at the altar, before the ordination, and the husband will remain when the ordination is gone, and the great error of the ministry marriage is to let the office that came second swallow the office that came first. I let it. For years I let the pastor swallow the husband, and I called the swallowing devotion, and Susanna sat across the table from a man who had given his best hours to a rival she could never name and could never beat, because the rival was the work of God, and how do you compete with God for your husband's heart when your husband cannot tell the difference between God and the church that is consuming him.

That is the question this whole book is trying to answer, and I do not pretend to have answered it cleanly, because it does not answer cleanly. But it begins with the hours. Look at your hours. Not your intentions, not your stated priorities, not the nice things you say about your family from the pulpit. Your hours. Where do the best ones go. And if the honest answer is that they go to the church and your wife gets the husk, then you have found the other woman, and she lives in the building with the cross on top, and the first step toward fidelity is to stop pretending the affair is devotion.

CHAPTER TWO

The Fishbowl and the Family That Lives On Display

NO ONE TELLS THE pastor's wife at the wedding that she is also being ordained.

There is no laying on of hands for her. There is no examination, no vows beyond the ones she makes to the man, no recognition that in marrying a pastor, or in marrying a man who will later become one, she has entered a public office that comes with public scrutiny and no public salary. But the congregation ordains her anyway, silently, the moment the call letter is signed. From that day forward she lives in a fishbowl, and the fishbowl is the second great pressure on the parsonage marriage, distinct from the matter of the hours, because a man can correct his hours and still be married to a woman who is slowly being suffocated by being watched. They are watching her. They are always watching her. And they are watching the marriage, and the watching itself does a kind of damage that the watchers never intend

and never see.

I did not understand the fishbowl for years because I was not in it the way she was. A pastor is watched too, but a pastor is watched at his work, and there is a dignity in being watched at your work, a sense that the scrutiny is the price of the office and the office is yours by calling. The wife is watched at her life. She is watched in the grocery store and at the school pickup and in the way she dresses and the way her children behave and whether she sang loudly enough in worship and whether she looked happy at the potluck. She did not choose this scrutiny as the price of a calling. It was simply attached to her, like a tail, the day she married me, and she has worn it every day since, and most days she wears it without complaint, and I confess that for years I mistook her not complaining for it not costing her anything. It cost her everything. It cost her the ordinary human freedom to have a bad day in public, to be cranky in the checkout line, to wear sweatpants to the gas station, to be, in a word, a private person. The pastor's wife is never off duty, because the congregation has no concept of her being off duty, because they never put her on duty in the first place, which means they can never take her off it.

Let me describe what the fishbowl actually does to a marriage, because it is subtler than just the discomfort of being observed. The fishbowl turns the marriage itself into an exhibit. A young couple in the congregation looks at the pastor and his wife as a model, and there is something right about that, the pastor's home should be a place from which others learn. But there is something that goes wrong with it almost immediately, because the moment a marriage becomes a model it is under pressure to perform, and a marriage that is performing is not resting, and a marriage

that cannot rest will eventually crack along the seam between what it is and what it is pretending to be. Susanna and I learned early to present a certain version of ourselves at church. The united front. The pastor and his lovely wife. And the more polished the presentation became, the harder it was to be honest at home, because we had built a public marriage that the private marriage could not always live up to, and the gap between them became a kind of low-grade dishonesty that poisoned both. We were performing a marriage on Sunday and then coming home too depleted to actually have one.

There is a specific moment I think about. We had a hard week, the kind every couple has, where some unresolved thing sat between us like a stone. And on Sunday we walked into the church and put on the faces, and I preached, and she smiled, and people told us after the service how much they loved seeing us together, what an encouragement our marriage was, and we drove home in a silence so total it had its own weight. The congregation had been encouraged by a marriage that was, in that hour, barely speaking. And I want to be careful here, because I am not saying we should air every grievance publicly or that there is no place for privacy and dignity in how a couple presents itself. There is. But the fishbowl pushes past dignity into pretense. It demands not that you keep your private struggles private, which is healthy, but that you appear to have no private struggles at all, which is a lie, and a marriage built to sustain a lie for the encouragement of onlookers is a marriage that has taken on a second job it was never meant to do, the job of being a billboard for the church's idea of itself.

*The congregation was encouraged by a
marriage that was, in that hour,
barely speaking.*

THE CHILDREN LIVE IN the fishbowl too, and this is where the cruelty sharpens, because the children did not even get to choose the man the way the wife did. My five sons grew up as pastor's kids in a small Michigan town, which means they grew up under a microscope they never asked for, held to a standard of behavior that the other children in the youth group were not held to, watched for any sign that the pastor's home was not what the pastor preached. A deacon's son can throw a tantrum in the foyer and it is a child being a child. The pastor's son throws the same tantrum and it is a referendum on the pastor's parenting, his fitness for office, the integrity of his message. My boys felt that. They felt the eyes. And one of the quiet costs of ministry that no one warns you about is the way the fishbowl can teach your children that the church is the thing that takes their father and then judges them for how they cope with his absence. I will give the children their own chapter, because they deserve more than a paragraph. But I name them here because the fishbowl does not just pressure the marriage. It pressures everyone the marriage produces, and the wife absorbs that pressure too, because she is the one home with the children absorbing the eyes while the father is at the church being the reason for them.

What does the fishbowl do that we have to resist, and how do we resist it without becoming bitter toward the very people

we are called to love. This is the hard part, because the watching is not malicious. Most of the people watching the pastor's family are not critics looking for a flaw. They are sheep looking for a shepherd they can trust, and they watch the marriage because they want to believe that the gospel produces something, that the man telling them how to live has a life worth imitating. There is love in much of the watching. But love that watches too closely becomes a weight, and a weight that never lifts becomes a kind of slow crushing, and the pastor's job is to protect his wife and children from being crushed by the affection of the very people he serves. That means building a private life the congregation does not own, which I will give a whole chapter to, because it is one of the central acts of protecting the covenant. But it begins here, with simply naming the fishbowl out loud, with the pastor saying to his wife, I see that you are being watched, I see that it costs you, you did not sign up for this and I will not pretend you did, and I am going to stand between you and the eyes wherever I can.

I did not say that to Susanna for a long time. For years I left her alone in the fishbowl and told myself she was handling it well, because she was handling it well, and a man can mistake his wife's competence for her contentment for a very long time if he is not paying attention. She was strong. She is strong. But strength is not the same as not being wounded, and the woman who handles the fishbowl gracefully is often the woman bleeding most quietly, because she has decided that her bleeding will not become one more burden on a husband who already has the whole congregation on his shoulders. So she bled in private, and I admired her grace in public, and the fishbowl did its slow work on her where I could not see it because I was not looking, because looking

would have required me to admit that the thing I had given my life to was hurting the person I had given my life to, and that admission was too expensive, so I did not make it, and she paid the cost of my not making it, and that is the truth of the fishbowl in my house. She lived on display so that I could be admired, and I let her, and I called it ministry.

The way out is not to leave ministry. The way out is to refuse to let the congregation set the terms of your family's exposure. You decide what is public and what is not. You decide that your wife's struggles are not sermon material, that your children's failures are not lessons for the youth group, that your home has a door and the door closes and what happens behind it belongs to God and to the people in the room and to no one else. The fishbowl has glass walls because the pastor lets it have glass walls. Put up a curtain. Not a wall of hostility, a curtain of dignity, a place where your wife can take off the costume of the pastor's wife and just be a woman married to a man, watched by no one but the God who watches in love and not in judgment. That curtain is one of the first gifts I learned to give Susanna, and I gave it late, and I am still learning to hang it, and every pastor reading this who has left his wife exposed in the fishbowl needs to go home and start sewing.

CHAPTER THREE

The Invisible Load She Carries

THERE IS A KIND of work that has no name, draws no salary, earns no applause, and holds the whole thing together, and in the parsonage marriage that work falls almost entirely on the wife, and almost no one sees it, and I did not see it for years even though I was living inside the house it kept standing.

The sociologists have a phrase for part of it, the second shift, the unpaid domestic labor that piles onto a woman after her paid work is done. But the pastor's wife carries something beyond even the second shift, because her unpaid labor is not only the running of a household. It is the running of a household that is also, unofficially, a wing of the church. She is the one who notices that the new family did not get a meal when their baby was born, and she is the one who makes it, and she is the one who remembers the name of the visitor the pastor forgot, and she is the one who fields the phone call at nine at night because a woman in the congregation will talk to her in a way she will not talk to me, and she is the one who absorbs the criticism of her husband and says nothing, and

she is the one who keeps the family running while the family's head is at the church running everyone else's. Her load is invisible because it is the kind of work that only becomes visible when it stops, and she never let it stop, so I never saw it, and a man can be married to a woman doing the labor of three people and never notice as long as she does it well enough that nothing breaks.

Let me be specific, because invisible labor stays invisible when we keep it abstract. Susanna ran our home. That sentence is too small to carry what it means. She managed the calendar of seven people. She knew which son had a dentist appointment and which one needed new cleats and which one was struggling in a way that the others were not. She handled the money, the groceries, the laundry that five boys generate, the cooking, the cleaning, the thousand decisions a day that keep a family from descending into chaos, and she did all of it while married to a man whose work could call him away at any hour, which meant she could never count on me, which meant she had to build a life that did not depend on my presence, and the cruelty of that is that the more capable she became of running our life without me, the more I was free to give myself to the church, because she had made my absence survivable. My fidelity to the congregation was subsidized by her invisible labor. The church got to have all of me because Susanna covered the gap I left at home, and the church never sent her a thank-you note, and for a long time neither did I.

And then there is the emotional labor, which is heavier than the logistical labor and even more invisible. Susanna was the person I came home to and unloaded on. When an elder wounded me, when a sermon fell flat, when a family left the church and took half a small group with them, when the

loneliness of leadership pressed down on me, I brought all of it home and laid it on her, and she received it, because she loved me and because that is what a wife does. But notice the asymmetry. I had a wife to unload on. She had no one. The pastor's wife is in a uniquely lonely position, because she cannot unload on the congregation, those are the very people she has to be careful around, and she cannot easily make close friends inside the church without the friendship becoming complicated by her position, and she cannot unload on her husband the way he unloads on her, because her husband is already carrying the whole church and she does not want to add her weight to his. So she carries her own burdens and his too, and she has nowhere to put any of it, and she becomes a reservoir that everything flows into and nothing flows out of, and a reservoir with no outlet eventually either floods or goes stagnant, and I have seen both happen in ministry marriages, and I came close to seeing both in mine.

*My fidelity to the congregation was
subsidized by her invisible labor.*

I THINK OF THE meals. For years Susanna made meals for people in crisis, and she did it gladly, and it was a genuine ministry of hers, an expression of real love. But I want you to see the full picture. She would spend an afternoon cooking for a family in the church while her own family went without her attention, and then she would deliver the meal, and the family would thank me, the pastor, for the church's care, as though I had cooked it, as though the casserole had

descended from my study. Her labor disappeared into my office. The congregation experienced her love and credited it to my leadership. That happened a thousand times, in a thousand forms, and it is one of the deep structural injustices of ministry marriage, that the wife's contribution is constantly being absorbed into the husband's reputation, that she pours herself out and the church experiences the pouring as the pastor's generosity. She made me look good for years with labor no one ever attributed to her, and I let them attribute it to me, and worse, sometimes I half believed it myself, which is the most shameful thing in this paragraph and the reason I am writing the paragraph.

What does a husband do about an invisible load. The first thing, the thing I did far too late, is to make it visible. To name it. To say to your wife, out loud, with specificity, I see what you carry. Not a vague compliment about how she holds everything together, which can actually deepen the problem by praising her for a burden you are not helping her put down. Specific naming. I see that you handle the money and it stresses you and I have left you alone in it. I see that you made three meals for grieving families this month and no one thanked you and I am thanking you. I see that you absorb the things people say about me and protect me from them and that it costs you. The naming matters because invisible labor does its damage partly through its invisibility, through the loneliness of doing essential work that no one acknowledges, and the simple act of a husband seeing it lifts part of the weight even before he picks up a single chore.

But naming is not enough, and I want to be careful not to let a chapter on invisible labor end with the husband merely saying nice things about it. He has to actually take some of it.

He has to come down off the platform and into the house and pick up the load with his own hands, and this is where the ministry husband resists, because his labor feels more important. His labor is the Lord's work. Her labor is just the house. And that distinction, that hierarchy that ranks the sermon above the laundry, is exactly the lie that has to die, because the God who became flesh and washed feet did not rank the holy work above the household work. He knelt down with a towel. The pastor who will preach about servant leadership on Sunday and will not run the dishwasher on Monday has not understood his own sermon. I preached servant leadership for years while my wife served and I led, and the gap between my preaching and my dishwasher is one of the things I have had to repent of, and I am still repenting of it, because it is easier to admire the principle than to dry a dish.

The last thing to say about the invisible load is the hardest, and it is about the part of the load that is not chores at all but is the carrying of me. Susanna held my discouragement so that the congregation never saw it. She was the container for the parts of the pastor that the pastor cannot show. And no one was the container for her. If you are a pastor, your wife is almost certainly holding things for you that she has nowhere to set down, and the most important thing you can do for her invisible load is to make sure she is not the only reservoir in her own life, to insist that she have a friend, a counselor, a sister, someone outside the church and outside the marriage to whom she can say the things she cannot say to you or to them. I resisted this for years out of a stinginess I am ashamed of, a sense that her emotional life should run through me. It was a kind of possessiveness disguised as intimacy. The healthiest thing I ever did for Susanna's

invisible load was to stop being her only outlet and to bless her having others, and the day she had a place to put down what she carried was the day I finally understood how much she had been carrying alone, in the dark, for years, while I slept beside her believing she was fine.

CHAPTER FOUR

Why She Cannot Say What She Really Feels

THE PASTOR'S WIFE KNOWS something the pastor often refuses to know, which is that her honesty has a price tag attached to it, and the price might be his job.

This is one of the most quietly poisonous features of ministry marriage, and I have rarely heard it named, so I want to name it carefully. In an ordinary marriage, when a wife is unhappy with her husband's work, she can say so. She can tell him he is working too much, that his boss is using him, that the company does not deserve the hours he gives it. Her honesty might start a fight, but it will not cost the family its livelihood, because the husband's employer does not depend on the wife's approval. The pastor's wife is in a different and worse position. The pastor's employer is the congregation, and the congregation's approval of the pastor is bound up, in ways no one admits, with their approval of his wife and his marriage. If she is seen as unhappy, as critical of the church, as unsupportive of the ministry, it can damage his standing. A pastor's wife who is known to resent the

church is a liability to the pastor. Everyone knows this, including her, especially her. So she learns to swallow her honest feelings, not because she is dishonest by nature, but because the structure she lives in has made her honesty dangerous, and she loves her husband too much to make his vocation more precarious than it already is.

Think about what this does to a marriage over time. Intimacy is built on the ability to say true things to another person and be received. A marriage in which one partner cannot safely say what she actually feels is a marriage with a wound in its center, and the wound does not heal, it just gets papered over with a politeness that looks like peace and is actually distance. Susanna had feelings about the church that she could not fully voice to me for years, and she could not voice them partly because of the structural danger I just described and partly because of something even sadder, which is that she could see I was barely holding it together, and she did not want to add the weight of her honest resentment to a man who was already drowning in the demands of the congregation. Her silence was a mercy to me. It was also a slow death for the marriage, because a mercy that requires you to hide your true self is not finally a mercy, it is a kind of starvation chosen out of love, and love should not have to choose starvation.

I remember the first time she said something genuinely honest about the church to me, something with real edge, real anger in it. We were years in. She said that she had come to feel like the church was a person who lived in our house and got everything she wanted while Susanna got the scraps. She said it and then she watched my face, and I understood, watching her watch me, that she had been afraid to say it, afraid of how I would take it, afraid I would hear it as an

attack on God or the ministry or my calling. And the fact that my wife had to be afraid to tell me how she felt in her own marriage is one of the great indictments of my early years as a husband. I had created, without meaning to, a marriage in which the truth was dangerous. I had made myself so identified with the church that to criticize the church was to criticize me, to question the hours was to question the calling, and so my wife had learned to keep her truest feelings in a locked room, and I had the only key and I never reached for it because I did not want to know what was inside.

*I had made myself so identified with
the church that to criticize the church
was to criticize me.*

WHY DOES THE PASTOR make it so hard for his wife to be honest. I can only speak from my own failure, but I think it is this. The pastor's identity and the church's wellbeing have become fused in his mind, so that any complaint about the church feels like a complaint about his very self, and few of us can receive a complaint about our very self without becoming defensive. When Susanna said the church was taking too much, I heard, in my worst moments, that I was failing, that I was not enough, that the thing I had given my life to was being attacked. I made her honest about me. And when a husband makes his wife's honest about himself, he teaches her to stop being honest, because honesty that triggers his wound becomes too costly to repeat. So she goes quiet. And the pastor mistakes her silence for support. He thinks she is

on board because she has stopped objecting, when in fact she has stopped objecting because objecting did not work and only hurt her, and the silence the pastor reads as harmony is actually the sound of his wife giving up on being heard.

There is a deeper layer here, and it has to do with the spiritualizing of the wife's submission. In many of our churches, and I have been guilty of this in my own preaching, we have taught wives a version of submission and support that functionally forbids them from honest dissent. We have told the pastor's wife that her role is to undergird the ministry, to be the wind beneath his wings, to sacrifice gladly for the work of God, and all of that contains truth, but it can curdle into a theology that makes her honest pain look like rebellion against God himself. If she says the church is taking too much, she can be made to feel that she is fighting against the Lord, that her exhaustion is a spiritual failure, that a more godly woman would carry it joyfully. I have watched this theology crush ministry wives. I have watched it teach them that their legitimate grief is sin, and so they bury the grief and call the burial holiness, and the marriage hollows out behind the holiness, and everyone praises how supportive the pastor's wife is right up until the day she leaves, or breaks, or simply goes so silent that the lights behind her eyes go out.

The husband's job is to make honesty safe again, and this is harder than it sounds, because you cannot just announce that honesty is safe and expect your wife to believe you after years of learning that it is not. Safety is rebuilt slowly, through repeated evidence, through the husband receiving the first small honest things without defensiveness, without spiritualizing, without making it about himself or his calling, so that the wife learns by experience that this time the truth

will be received and not punished. When Susanna told me the church felt like a rival living in our house, the most important thing I did was not what I said. It was that I did not defend the church. I did not explain. I did not remind her of the calling. I sat in it, and I let it be true, and I said you are right and I am sorry, and that single non-defensive reception did more to reopen the channel of honesty between us than a hundred speeches about how much I valued her input. Honesty returns to a marriage when the dangerous truth is finally spoken and the speaker is not punished for it, and the pastor has to be the one who makes the not-punishing reliable, because the structure will not do it for him. The structure rewards her silence. Only he can reward her honesty, and he has to do it over and over, until the locked room is open, and his wife can finally tell him the truth about the life they have been living, even when the truth is that he has been the problem.

CHAPTER FIVE

Absent While Present, or the Mind That Never Leaves the Church

A MAN CAN BE in the room and not be in the room, and his wife knows the difference even when he has convinced himself there is none.

This is the pressure that I think did the quietest and most sustained damage in my own marriage, because it does not show up on a calendar and cannot be measured in hours. I could be home, physically present, sitting at the dinner table, lying in bed beside Susanna, attending one of my sons' games, and be entirely somewhere else, because my mind never left the church. The sermon for Sunday was always running in the background like a process that never closed. The conflict with the elder was being re-litigated in my head while I nodded at my wife. The family that left, the budget shortfall, the woman in the hospital, the thing I said wrong, the thing someone said to me, all of it churned continuously beneath the surface of my attention, and the part of me that

was available to my family was the thin top layer that remained after the church had claimed the depths. I was a present absence. I was a man-shaped space at the table where a husband and father was supposed to be.

The technical word for what I lacked is attention, but I want to use a better word, a word Eugene Peterson used often, the word presence. Peterson understood that the pastor's deepest temptation was to be everywhere in general and nowhere in particular, to be so consumed with the abstraction of the congregation that he lost the concrete persons in front of him. And the first persons he loses are always the ones at home, because they are the ones who are always there, the ones who do not have to be courted or kept, the ones a man feels he can postpone because they will still be there tomorrow. The congregation is a moving target that demands constant attention to retain. The wife is a fixed point a man believes he can take for granted. So the mind, under pressure, gives its attention to the thing it might lose and withholds it from the thing it assumes is safe, and the tragedy is that the thing it assumes is safe is the one thing it should be most afraid of losing, and by the time a man learns this his wife has often already left in every way but the legal one.

Let me describe a specific evening, because the abstraction needs flesh. One of my sons, when he was small, was telling me about something at school. I do not remember what it was, and that is precisely the point, because I was not there. I was looking at his face and making the sounds a father makes, and inside I was preparing for a difficult meeting, running the conversation, planning my responses. My son finished his story and looked at me, and there was a question on his face, and the question was, are you here. He

was too young to say it, but I have seen that question on the faces of all my sons and on Susanna's face more times than I can count. Are you here. And the answer, for years, was no. I was not here. I was at the church even when I was at home, and my family lived with a ghost, a man who haunted his own house, present enough to be expected at dinner and absent enough to be no comfort once he arrived.

*My family lived with a ghost, a man
who haunted his own house.*

THE REASON THIS PRESSURE is so insidious is that it is invisible even to the man living it. I genuinely believed I was a present father and a present husband, because I was physically there, and I measured presence by location. But presence is not location. Presence is attention, the offering of one's actual awareness to another person, and you can be in a room for hours and offer nothing, and you can be in a room for ten minutes and offer everything, and the ten minutes of real presence will feed a marriage that the hours of haunting will starve. Susanna did not need me home more. That is what I thought she needed, and so when I did manage to be home I felt I had done my part, and I could not understand why it did not seem to help. She did not need my body in the house. She needed my mind in the marriage. And my mind was at the church, and no amount of physical presence could substitute for the attention I was withholding, because you cannot pay a debt of attention with a currency of mere location.

There is a spiritual diagnosis underneath this, and it is

uncomfortable, so I will say it plainly. The reason my mind never left the church is that my sense of myself was located at the church. My identity, my worth, my standing before God and man, all of it was bound up in how the ministry was going, and so my mind returned compulsively to the ministry the way a tongue returns to a sore tooth, because that was where my treasure was and that was where my heart followed. If your mind never leaves the church, it is worth asking why, and the answer is often that you have made the church the source of something that should come from God alone. I had made the congregation the place where I earned my worth, and so I could never set it down, because setting it down felt like setting down my own value. The cure for the mind that never leaves the church is not better time management. It is the slow, deep work of relocating your identity from your performance to your adoption, from what the church thinks of you to what the Father declared over you in Christ before you had preached a single sermon. A man whose worth is settled in Christ can leave the church at the church. A man whose worth is on trial every Sunday will carry the courtroom home in his head every night.

I learned to come home, and I mean really come home, through a discipline that felt artificial at first and became one of the most important practices of my life. I learned to stop at the threshold. Literally, at the door of my house, I learned to pause and to consciously set the church down, to pray a short prayer giving the congregation back to God for the evening, to tell myself that the church belonged to Christ and not to me and that it would survive the next several hours without my anxious supervision. Peterson wrote about the discipline of the unbusy pastor, the pastor who refuses to let busyness become a cover for the avoidance of his own life and the lives

closest to him. The threshold prayer was my small attempt at unbusyng my mind, at building a door in my own head that the church could not walk through, so that when I crossed the physical threshold I crossed a mental one too, and the man who arrived at the dinner table was actually there.

It did not work perfectly. It still does not. The mind is a hard thing to govern and the church is a strong claimant on it. But the difference between a husband who is fighting to be present and a husband who has surrendered to the haunting is the whole difference between a marriage that is healing and a marriage that is dying. Susanna can tell, instantly, whether I am present or whether I am at the church behind my eyes. She has always been able to tell. What changed is that I started fighting to be present, and she could feel the fight, and the fight itself was a kind of love, because it told her that she was worth the war I was waging in my own head against the rival that wanted all of my attention. Be present. Not perfectly, none of us can. But fight for it, visibly, so that your wife and your children know that when the church tries to follow you through the door, there is a man inside who is willing to stand in the doorway and tell it no, not now, this hour belongs to them.

CHAPTER SIX

When Intimacy Is Displaced by Activity

MARRIAGES DO NOT USUALLY die of a single wound. They die of a slow substitution, in which the living thing is replaced, one small piece at a time, by the management of the living thing, until one day the couple realizes they are not married anymore, they are co-administering an enterprise, and neither of them can remember when the romance became a roster.

This is the displacement I want to name in this chapter, the displacement of intimacy by activity, and it is epidemic in ministry marriages for a reason that is almost mathematical. The pastor's life is full of activity, godly activity, urgent activity, activity that genuinely cannot be ignored, and activity is a jealous thing that expands to fill whatever space it is given. Intimacy, by contrast, is quiet, slow, unproductive, and easily postponed. It does not announce itself with a deadline. No one calls at nine at night with an intimacy emergency. And so in any contest between the urgent activity of ministry and the unhurried work of intimacy, the activity

wins every time, not because the pastor has decided intimacy does not matter, but because intimacy never makes the kind of noise that activity makes, and the squeaky wheel gets the grease, and the marriage is the wheel that has learned not to squeak.

I watched this happen in my own marriage with a kind of horror once I finally saw it. Susanna and I had become extraordinarily efficient at the activity of our shared life and almost incapable of the intimacy of it. We could coordinate five boys, two cars, a church calendar, and a household budget like a pair of seasoned logistics officers. We were a good team. And being a good team is a real and valuable thing, but it is not the same as being lovers, and I had let the team replace the lovers without noticing the substitution, because the team was so functional that its very functionality hid the absence underneath. We were getting everything done. The trains were running on time. And somewhere in the running of the trains we had stopped looking at each other, stopped having the long unproductive conversations that have no agenda, stopped the slow useless lingering that is the actual substance of married love. We had become excellent partners and forgotten how to be a husband and a wife.

The danger of the efficient marriage is that it can run on its own competence for years, masking the death of intimacy beneath the appearance of a well-functioning life. From the outside, and even from inside on the busy days, everything looks fine. The bills are paid, the children are fed, the church is served, the calendar is coordinated. But a marriage is not a project to be completed. It is a communion to be enjoyed, and a communion that has been fully converted into a project has died even while the project thrives. Tim Keller used to say

that the goal of marriage is not to be happily married in the sense of frictionless, but to help each other become the people God is making you to be, and that work of mutual sanctification requires presence and attention and slowness, the very things that activity devours. You cannot sanctify someone you only ever coordinate logistics with. The deep work of marriage happens in the unproductive hours, and the ministry marriage is precisely the marriage that has no unproductive hours left, because it has sold them all to the church.

*We had become excellent partners and
forgotten how to be a husband and a
wife.*

I WANT TO TALK about the bedroom, because intimacy includes the sexual relationship and a chapter on intimacy that pretends otherwise would be dishonest. Activity displaces sexual intimacy as surely as it displaces emotional intimacy, and the two are bound together, because a couple that has stopped talking deeply will eventually stop touching deeply, and a couple drowning in activity has time for neither. There were seasons in our marriage when our physical intimacy became one more item that got squeezed out by exhaustion and busyness, when we were both so depleted by the day, me by the church and Susanna by the home and the children, that we fell into bed as two tired people and not as a husband and wife. And I want to say to the pastor reading this that the displacement of sexual intimacy by ministry activity

is not a small thing, it is not a phase to be waited out, it is a wound to the one-flesh union that Genesis names as the very heart of marriage, and it has to be fought for the same way the rest of intimacy has to be fought for, by guarding time and energy and presence that the church wants to consume. The pastor who gives the church his last drop of energy and brings home nothing for his wife is starving a part of the marriage that God designed to be fed, and he should not be surprised when the starvation shows.

How does a couple recover intimacy from activity. The first thing is to recognize that intimacy will never win a fair fight against activity, because activity fights dirty, it claims urgency it does not have and importance it has not earned. So intimacy has to be protected unfairly, given an advantage, defended in advance, scheduled and guarded with the same seriousness that the pastor gives to a board meeting. This feels wrong to romantics, who imagine that intimacy should be spontaneous, but spontaneity is a luxury of couples who have margin, and the ministry couple has no margin, and so they must do the unromantic work of scheduling romance, of putting on the calendar the unproductive hours that will otherwise be devoured, of treating a conversation with no agenda as an appointment that cannot be moved. Susanna and I had to learn to schedule the very things that should have been spontaneous, and we felt sheepish about it at first, as though scheduling a date proved we had failed at love. But we had not failed at love. We had simply learned that in a life this full, the only things that happen are the things you protect, and if you will not protect intimacy it will not happen, and a marriage in which intimacy does not happen is a marriage running on borrowed time.

The deeper recovery, though, is not about scheduling. It is about repenting of the lie that activity is more important than communion, and that lie is deeply embedded in the pastor, because the pastor's whole life is organized around productive activity for God. We are doers. We measure our worth by what we accomplish, by the sermons preached and the souls counseled and the programs run, and we import that doing-based worth into the marriage, where it is poison, because marriage is not finally about what you accomplish together but about who you become together, and the becoming happens in the very unproductive hours that our doing-based hearts despise. I had to learn that an evening spent doing nothing with Susanna, accomplishing nothing, producing nothing, was not a wasted evening but possibly the most important evening of my week, because it was the evening in which the marriage was actually being a marriage and not a small business. The pastor who cannot rest in unproductive love with his wife has not yet been healed of the doing-based heart that the gospel came to kill, and until that heart dies, activity will keep displacing intimacy, no matter how many dates he schedules, because the man scheduling them still secretly believes that the activity is what really matters and the intimacy is what he does once the real work is done. The intimacy is the real work. Everything else is just activity.

CHAPTER SEVEN

When Criticism Follows You Through the Front Door

EVERY PASTOR IS CRITICIZED. That is not the wound I am writing about. The wound is what the criticism does after it follows you home, when it crosses the threshold of your house and sits down in your marriage and poisons the one well that was supposed to stay clean.

The pastor is a public figure in a small world, and a public figure absorbs criticism the way a lightning rod absorbs lightning, and some of that is simply the cost of the office and I have made my peace with it. People will disagree with the sermon. People will dislike the decision. People will write the letter, send the email, corner you in the foyer, tell others what they think of you before they tell you. This is ministry, and a man who cannot bear criticism should not stand in a pulpit. But here is what no one prepares you for. The criticism does not stay at the church. You carry it home in your body, in your jaw, in the knot in your stomach, and you bring it to the

dinner table, and even when you do not speak it, your wife can feel it, and the criticism that was aimed at you lands on her, because she is the one who lives with the man the criticism wounded, and she absorbs the fallout of every blow you take, which means that in a real sense your wife is criticized too, by people who never address her and never intend to wound her and never know they have.

Let me describe how this works, because it is more mechanical than people think. A man criticizes me on a Sunday, says something cutting about a decision I made, and I carry it. I am wounded, and being wounded I am diminished, and being diminished I have less of myself to give, and the person who receives the diminished version of me that evening is Susanna. She did not criticize me. She was not even there. But she gets the man the criticism made smaller. And worse, there is a temptation, which I have given into more times than I want to admit, to come home and unload the criticism onto her, to make her my jury and my comfort, to recite the wrong that was done to me so that she will take my side and soothe my wound. And she does take my side, because she loves me, but in taking my side she takes on the criticism, she comes to resent the person who hurt me, she carries an anger on my behalf that I have handed to her, and now there are two people in my house carrying a wound that was only ever aimed at one, and the church has succeeded in injuring my wife through me without ever lifting a hand against her.

*The criticism was aimed at me, and it
landed on her.*

THIS IS A PARTICULAR kind of damage because of how it positions the wife in relation to the congregation. When I bring home the criticism and Susanna absorbs my wound, she begins, slowly, to see the congregation as the enemy. Not all at once, and not consciously, but a wife who watches her husband come home wounded week after week, who holds him while he hurts, who has no power to defend him and no way to confront the people hurting him, will begin to harbor a quiet hostility toward the very people her husband is called to love. And that hostility is corrosive, because it puts her at odds with the ministry, it makes the church an opponent in her heart, and a pastor's wife who has come to see the congregation as the enemy is a wife in deep spiritual danger, even though her hostility began as nothing but love for her husband. I did this to Susanna. I handed her my wounds so often that I taught her to resent people she was supposed to love, and the resentment I planted in her by my unloading became one more thing she had to repent of, a sin I had essentially manufactured in my own wife by using her as the dumping ground for my injured pride.

There is a deeper problem underneath the unloading, and it is about where the pastor takes his wounds. I took my wounds to Susanna because she was available and because she loved me and because it was easier than taking them where they belonged, which was to God, and to a trusted friend or counselor outside the marriage, and sometimes

back to the person who had wounded me in honest conversation. The wife should not be the pastor's primary processing site for ministry criticism. She is too close, too invested, too unable to be objective, too likely to be wounded by what wounds him. When the pastor makes his wife his only place to process criticism, he is asking her to carry a load she is not equipped to carry and that will turn her against the people he serves. He needs other places to take the wounds, and protecting his wife from the criticism means, in large part, protecting her from his own habit of bleeding onto her every cut he receives.

But there is an opposite error, and I fell into it too, so I have to name both. The opposite error is to absorb all the criticism silently and tell your wife nothing, to protect her by shutting her out, to carry the wounds alone and come home pretending everything is fine. This seems noble, but it creates a different poison, because the wife can feel that something is wrong and is now shut out of it, and a husband who is clearly hurting and will not say why is not protecting his wife, he is isolating her, he is building a wall around a part of his life and telling her it is for her own good. Susanna did not need to be either my dumping ground or shut out entirely. She needed me to find the narrow path between, to be honest with her that I had been criticized, to let her in enough that she was not shut out, but to take the actual processing of it elsewhere so that she did not have to carry and resolve a wound she could not resolve. Let her in on the fact of the pain. Do not make her the place where the pain gets worked through. That is the balance, and it is hard, and I rarely got it right.

The deepest answer to criticism that follows you home is the same as the answer to the mind that never leaves the church, and it goes back to where the pastor's identity is

anchored. Criticism only follows you home with power if it has the power to wound you that deeply, and it has that power because you have located your worth in the approval of the very people who are criticizing you. A man whose identity is settled in Christ can be criticized and grieve it and learn from it and even be wounded by it without being destroyed by it, because the criticism is not landing on the foundation of his worth, it is landing on the surface. But a man whose worth is on trial every Sunday will be devastated by every critic, because every critic is a witness in the trial of his very value as a person, and he will carry the devastation home because the devastation is total. The criticism follows you through the front door in proportion to how much you have made the congregation the judge of your soul. Settle your soul's verdict in the gospel, in the finished declaration of God over you in Christ, and the criticism loses the power to follow you home, because it is no longer a threat to your existence, just a sorrow to be borne, and a sorrow can be set down at the threshold in a way that a threat to your existence never can. I did not settle that verdict for years, and so the criticism owned my evenings and poisoned my marriage, and the healing of that wound began not with better boundaries but with a deeper rest in a worth I had not earned and could not lose, no matter what the man in the foyer said about my sermon.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Marriage as a Sermon Illustration

THERE IS A SIN so subtle that I committed it from the pulpit for years while believing I was honoring my wife, and the sin is this. I made our marriage into material. I turned Susanna into an illustration.

The pastor who preaches on marriage has a problem that other preachers do not, which is that his own marriage is the most available example in the room, and the temptation to reach for it is enormous, and the reaching for it feels like vulnerability and humility and honesty, when it is often something closer to theft. I would stand up to preach and I would tell a story about Susanna, about something she said or did, about a moment in our marriage, and the congregation would lean in, because nothing holds an audience like a preacher talking about his own home, and I would feel the room respond and mistake the response for the blessing of God on my transparency. But I had not asked her. I had taken a private moment from our marriage and spent it for the benefit of my sermon, and the moment that belonged to the

two of us now belonged to three hundred people, and Susanna, sitting in the second row, had to smile while her private life was withdrawn from the joint account of our marriage and deposited into the offering plate of my preaching.

Let me be precise about why this is theft and not generosity, because many pastors do it and most of them, like me, think they are being warm and human. A marriage is a covenant of two, and part of what makes it a covenant is that it has an inside, a set of things that belong only to the two people in it, a privacy that is constitutive of the intimacy. When I take a moment from inside the covenant and use it in a sermon, I am breaching the wall of the covenant for my own purposes, and I am doing it to a person who cannot easily object, because objecting would make her look unsupportive, would embarrass us both, would turn a sermon into a fight. So she absorbs it. She lets me spend her privacy because she has no good way to stop me, and over time she learns that nothing that happens between us is safe from becoming material, that any tender or funny or hard moment might show up on Sunday with the names changed or not changed at all, and a woman who has learned that her private life is sermon fodder will begin to guard her private life even from her husband, because the husband has proven that he cannot be trusted to keep what happens between them between them.

*She let me spend her privacy because
she had no good way to stop me.*

AND THERE IS A worse version of this, which goes beyond individual illustrations into something I will call the branding of the marriage. In our era of ministry, the pastor's marriage has become a kind of product, a part of his platform, an asset in the building of his ministry brand. The happy pastor and his lovely wife are a selling point. They appear together on the website, in the promotional video, at the conference, modeling the marriage that the ministry promises to help you build. And this is a deeper corruption than the stray illustration, because it makes the marriage itself a means to a ministry end, it instrumentalizes the covenant, it turns the one-flesh union that was supposed to be an end in itself into a tool for the growth of the platform. I have watched pastors use their marriages as ministry capital, and I have done versions of it myself, and the result is always the same. The marriage that is being used as a means is no longer being loved as an end, and the wife who is being deployed as a ministry asset is no longer being cherished as a person, and somewhere underneath the beautiful branded image of the ministry couple is a real woman who has come to feel like a prop in her husband's career.

Susanna told me once, in one of the honest conversations that came after the years of her silence, that she sometimes felt like a character in my ministry rather than a partner in my life. A character. She had become, in my use of her, a figure I deployed for effect, the wise wife, the patient wife, the

funny exchange that illustrated my point, and somewhere in all the deploying she had stopped feeling like a full person to me and started feeling like a role. That conversation shamed me more than almost any other we have had, because I could not deny it. I had cast my own wife in a part. I had reduced the most important human being in my life to her usefulness for my preaching, and I had done it while believing I was honoring her by featuring her, when in fact featuring her was the very mechanism of the reduction. You do not honor a person by making her useful. You honor a person by loving her in a way that needs no audience and seeks no return, and a love that is always being converted into sermon material is a love that has an audience and seeks a return, and is therefore not the love the covenant requires.

How does a pastor stop. The first rule I made for myself, late and after much damage, was simple and absolute. I do not use Susanna in a sermon without her permission, and her permission has to be real, freely given, with the freedom to refuse, and not the coerced permission of a wife who knows that refusing will disappoint me. This rule cost me material. There were illustrations I could not use, stories that would have landed beautifully, moments that would have made the congregation laugh or weep, and I let them go, because they were not mine to spend. They belonged to the covenant, and the covenant had a member who had not agreed to spend them, and her veto over our shared privacy is absolute, more absolute than my hunger for a good illustration. A pastor who cannot let go of a good illustration to protect his wife's privacy loves his preaching more than he loves his wife, and I had to face that I was sometimes that pastor.

The second thing, harder than the first, is to root out the deeper habit of seeing the marriage as a ministry asset at all.

This is not about a rule, it is about a disposition of the heart, and it requires the pastor to ask whether he loves his wife as a person or values her as a part of his platform, and the test is whether he would love her exactly the same if she contributed nothing to his ministry, if she never appeared in a sermon or a video or beside him at a conference, if she were, ministerially, invisible. Would you cherish her the same. If the honest answer is no, if part of your love for her is bound up in her usefulness to the work, then you have made the covenant a means, and the covenant will not forgive being made a means, because it was designed by God to be an end, a picture of Christ and the church that exists for its own sake and not for the sake of your platform. Christ did not love the church as a means to some further end. He loved her as the end, gave himself up for her with nothing to gain, and the pastor whose marriage images that love must love his wife with the same uselessness, the same refusal to convert her into capital, the same willingness to cherish her in the dark where no congregation will ever see it and no sermon will ever be improved by it. The truest moments of my marriage now are the ones I will never preach, and that is exactly why they are the truest, because they belong to us, and I have finally stopped trying to spend them.

CHAPTER NINE

Protecting a Private Life the Congregation Does Not Own

THE CONGREGATION BELIEVES, WITHOUT ever saying so, that it owns the pastor, and the pastor often believes it too, and the most important act of resistance in a ministry marriage is the building of a private life that the church cannot enter, a walled garden where the pastor is just a husband and the wife is just a woman and no one is watching and nothing is owed.

I have to be careful here, because the building of a private life can curdle into a hiddenness that is unhealthy, a pastor with secrets, a double life, and that is not what I mean at all. I am not talking about hiding sin. I am talking about the right and necessary privacy of a marriage, the inside of the covenant that I named in the last chapter, and the way the congregation, with the best intentions, will colonize every inch of the pastor's life if he does not draw a border and defend it. The church will take your evenings if you let it, your

days off if you let it, your vacations if you let it, your meals, your conversations, your bedroom, your very thoughts, not because the church is malicious but because the church is hungry and you are food, and a hungry thing does not stop eating because it loves you. It stops eating because you stop feeding it. And the pastor who will not draw a border around his private life will be consumed entirely, and his marriage will be consumed with him, because his marriage lives in the private life that he has refused to protect.

The congregation does not own your marriage. I want to say that as plainly as I can, because so much of the ministry world operates on the unspoken assumption that it does. The congregation does not own your evenings with your wife. It does not own your physical intimacy, your private conversations, your inside jokes, your fights, your reconciliations, your tender moments, your hard ones. These belong to you and to her and to God, and the church has no claim on them, no matter how much it pays you, no matter how needy it is, no matter how spiritual the demand sounds when it comes. There is a part of your life that is simply not for sale, that the church cannot buy with a salary or guilt you out of with talk of calling, and the defending of that part is not selfishness, it is faithfulness, because that part is where the covenant lives, and you swore to protect the covenant before you ever swore to serve the church.

*The church is hungry and you are
food, and a hungry thing does not stop
eating because it loves you.*

HOW DO YOU BUILD a private life the congregation does not own. It begins with the recovery of the word no, and I will give a whole chapter to no later, because it is so central, but it appears here too, because privacy is built out of a thousand small refusals. No, I cannot take that call tonight, this is my evening with my wife. No, I will not be at that event, it is my day off. No, that is not something I am willing to share. Each no is a brick in the wall around the private life, and the pastor who cannot say no will have no private life, because the church will fill every space he leaves open, and he leaves every space open who has not learned to close some of them. I could not say no for years. I treated every request from the church as a summons from God, and so I had no border, and so I had no private life, and so my marriage lived in a house with no walls where anyone could walk in at any hour, and Susanna lived in that exposure with me, and the exposure wore her down.

There is a practical architecture to a protected private life, and I will describe some of what Susanna and I built, not as a formula but as an example of what the bricks can look like. We protected certain hours absolutely, hours the church was simply not allowed to have, and we defended them the way you defend anything precious, by being willing to disappoint people. We kept some friendships entirely outside the church, people who knew us not as the pastor and his wife but as James and Susanna, people in front of whom we did not have to perform, and those friendships became a kind of pressure valve for the fishbowl. We made certain topics off limits for public consumption, parts of our life that simply were not available to the congregation no matter how curious or caring they were. And we learned, slowly and with many failures, to distinguish between the legitimate access the

congregation has to their pastor and the illegitimate access they often assume to his marriage, and to grant the first while defending against the second.

The hardest part of building a private life is the guilt, and I want to address the guilt directly, because it is the thing that keeps most pastors from building anything at all. When you say no to the church in order to protect your marriage, you will feel guilty, and the guilt will feel spiritual, it will feel like you are failing God and abandoning his people, and that guilt is the single most effective weapon the church has for taking your private life, because it works from the inside, it makes you the agent of your own consumption. You will not even need the church to demand your evening. Your guilt will hand it over before anyone asks. So you have to deal with the guilt theologically, and the theology is this. God instituted marriage before he instituted the church. The covenant of one flesh in Genesis precedes the gathered people of God by thousands of years. Your marriage is not a distraction from your ministry, it is a prior and deeper calling, and protecting it is not stealing from God, it is obeying a command God gave before he gave you a congregation. The guilt is lying to you. It is telling you that the church has first claim on your life, when in fact your wife has a claim that predates the church and outranks it in the order of creation. A man shall leave and hold fast to his wife. He shall not leave his wife and hold fast to his congregation. The guilt has the order backwards, and until you correct the order in your own conscience, you will keep handing your private life to the church and calling the surrender obedience.

I built our private life too late, and I built it badly at first, with walls that were sometimes too high in the wrong places and too low in the others. But the building of it was one of the

great turning points of our marriage, the point at which Susanna began to believe that there was a part of me, a part of us, that the church could not have, that she was not in an endless competition with the congregation for every hour of my life, that there existed a walled garden where she had me to herself and the church was not invited. A wife needs to know that such a garden exists. She needs to know that there is a place where she is not sharing her husband with three hundred people, where the door closes and the church stays outside and the two of them are simply a man and a woman who belong to each other. If your wife does not know that such a place exists in your marriage, build it, this week, and defend it with your life, because it is not a luxury. It is the place where the covenant breathes, and a covenant that cannot breathe will suffocate, no matter how faithfully you serve the people who are smothering it.

CHAPTER TEN

The Sabbath the Couple Must Take and Guard

THE PASTOR IS THE one person in the congregation who works on the Sabbath, and this fact, so obvious that no one stops to consider it, sits at the root of a deep exhaustion that wears down ministry marriages, because the day God gave for rest is the day the pastor labors hardest, and if he does not take his rest somewhere else, deliberately and stubbornly, he will never rest at all, and neither will his marriage.

I came late to a real theology of Sabbath, and I came to it partly through Eugene Peterson, who wrote with unusual seriousness about the pastor's need for a day of true ceasing, and partly through the simple desperation of a man and a woman who were running on empty and could not figure out why. Peterson observed that pastors are particularly bad at Sabbath because their work never feels finished, there is always another soul to tend, another sermon to write, another crisis to manage, and so the pastor lives in a state of perpetual non-completion that makes ceasing feel impossible and even irresponsible. But the Sabbath was

never about finishing the work. God did not rest on the seventh day because creation was a tidy completed project with nothing left to do. He rested as a declaration that the work did not own him, that he was Lord over the work and not its servant, and the pastor who takes a Sabbath is making the same declaration, that the church does not own him, that he is not the savior of the congregation, that the ministry will survive a day without his anxious supervision because the ministry belongs to Christ and not to him.

For the ministry couple, the Sabbath is not optional and it is not merely personal, it is one of the central acts of protecting the marriage, because the Sabbath is the one institution that can carve out, on a recurring basis, the unproductive time in which intimacy lives. If the marriage is being killed by activity, as I argued earlier, then the Sabbath is the weekly resurrection of the marriage from activity, the day on which the doing stops and the being resumes, the day the couple is allowed to be a couple and not a logistics company. But it does not happen by itself, and this is the hard truth that took us years to learn. The Sabbath has to be taken and guarded, deliberately, against a church that will eat it if you let it, against a culture of ministry that treats the pastor's day off as theoretical, against your own restless heart that does not know how to stop. The Sabbath is a discipline, and the discipline has to be fought for, and the fighting is itself a form of love.

*The Sabbath is the weekly resurrection
of the marriage from activity.*

SUSANNA AND I HAD to learn to guard a day, and our day could not be Sunday for obvious reasons, so we had to choose another and defend it, and I want to describe what defending it actually required, because the romantic idea of a Sabbath collapses fast against the reality of a hungry church. Defending the day meant turning off the phone, or at least refusing to answer the calls that were not genuine emergencies, and the church does not agree with the pastor about what constitutes a genuine emergency, the church thinks everything is an emergency, and so guarding the Sabbath meant repeatedly disappointing people who believed their need outranked my rest. It meant being unavailable. It meant letting things wait that could wait, which was almost everything, even though almost nothing felt like it could wait. It meant tolerating the guilt I described in the last chapter, the spiritual-feeling guilt that tells the pastor he is abandoning God's people by taking a day, and recognizing that guilt as the voice of a church that wants to consume the very day God commanded me to keep.

There is a theological depth to the marital Sabbath that I do not want to skip past, because it is more than a practical break. The Sabbath is a foretaste of the rest that is coming, the eternal rest of the people of God, and when a husband and wife rest together, ceasing from their labors, simply enjoying each other and their God and their children and their food and their home, they are practicing for heaven, they are

rehearsing the communion that the whole story is moving toward. A marriage that never rests together never rehearses heaven, it only ever rehearses work, and a marriage that only rehearses work will come to believe that work is all there is, that life is a long task to be completed and the marriage is one of the instruments for completing it. But the Sabbath interrupts that lie every week, it declares that the point of life is not the work but the communion, not the doing but the delight, and a couple that keeps the Sabbath keeps a weekly witness against the false gospel of endless productivity that the ministry world preaches with its mouth closed while its mouth open preaches grace.

I failed at Sabbath for years, and my failure had a particular flavor that I think many pastors will recognize. I would take a day off in theory, but I would not cease in practice, because my mind never left the church, and so I would spend my Sabbath physically resting and mentally laboring, present in the house and absent in the marriage, going through the motions of rest while the church ran continuously behind my eyes. A Sabbath that the body keeps and the mind breaks is not a Sabbath, it is just a different location for the same anxiety, and Susanna could tell the difference, she could always tell, she knew when I was resting and when I was merely sitting still while working internally. The recovery of a real Sabbath required the same interior work as the recovery of presence, the relocating of my identity from the church to Christ, the trusting of the congregation to God for a day, the deep belief, against all my striving instincts, that the church did not need me as much as I needed it to need me, and that it would be fine, and that God was perfectly capable of running his church for twenty-four hours without my supervision.

The Sabbath we eventually built was not perfect and is not perfect, but it became one of the load-bearing walls of our marriage, the weekly hour in which the activity stopped and we remembered that we were lovers and not just partners, that there was a delight underneath the duty, that the covenant was a joy and not only a job. If you take nothing else practical from this book, take this. Choose a day. Guard it with everything you have. Disappoint the church for the sake of the covenant on that day, every week, without apology, and let the guilt come and refuse to obey it. The marriage that keeps a Sabbath together has a fighting chance against the church that wants to consume it, because once a week it steps out of the consumption and remembers what it was for, and a marriage that remembers what it was for, even once a week, is a marriage that can survive a great deal of what the rest of the week throws at it. I learned that too late to spare Susanna years of exhaustion, but I learned it, and the day we finally began to keep was the day the marriage began, slowly, to breathe again.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Money and the Strain of a Ministry Salary

NO ONE WARNS YOU that the pastor's marriage will be tested in the place where most marriages are tested, the bank account, except that the pastor's marriage is tested there with a particular cruelty, because the pastor is paid by the very people he serves, and a salary that comes from your congregation is a salary that comes with a complicated kind of dependence, and the strain of that dependence falls heaviest on the marriage.

Let me start with the plain fact that ministry, in most places, does not pay well, and the pastor of a church like mine, a faithful but not wealthy congregation in a small Michigan town, is not a man who is getting rich. Susanna and I raised five sons on a ministry salary, and the arithmetic of that is its own kind of pressure, the constant doing of sums, the seven mouths and the one modest income, the worn shoes and the postponed repairs and the vacations that did not happen and the things the boys went without that other boys did not. Financial strain is hard on any marriage, and

the research on this is not subtle, money is one of the leading sources of marital conflict across every demographic. But the ministry couple bears the ordinary financial strain plus several extraordinary ones, and the extraordinary ones are what I want to name, because the ordinary ones are at least discussed.

The first extraordinary strain is the strange position of being paid by the people you serve. When a businessman wants a raise, he negotiates with an employer who is not also his flock, and the negotiation, however tense, is just a negotiation. When the pastor needs more, he has to go to the very people he stands before every Sunday and ask them for money, and the asking is fraught with a thousand complications. He does not want to seem greedy. He does not want to seem like he is in it for the money. He is preaching to the same people who set his salary, which means his economic wellbeing is entangled with his spiritual authority in a way that distorts both. So the pastor often does not ask. He goes without, and his family goes without, and the congregation, which would gladly pay more if it understood the need, never understands the need because the pastor is too caught in the strangeness of the arrangement to make it plain. Susanna and I went without things for years that we did not have to go without, simply because I could not bring myself to have the conversation with the people I served, and my inability to advocate for my family financially was a failure of mine that she bore, quietly, in the doing of the sums.

*My economic wellbeing was entangled
with my spiritual authority in a way
that distorted both.*

THE SECOND EXTRAORDINARY STRAIN is that the financial sacrifice of ministry gets spiritualized, and the spiritualizing of it falls hardest on the wife. The pastor is supposed to be content with little, to have taken a kind of vow of modest living, to model for the congregation a life that is not about money, and there is truth in that calling, and I embrace it. But the calling is mine. I chose ministry. Susanna married a man, and the man later became a pastor, and the financial sacrifice that I embraced as part of my calling became a sacrifice imposed on her without her ever having chosen the vocation that required it. And when she felt the strain, when she grieved the things we could not give our sons, when she carried the anxiety of a tight budget, there was always a spiritual frame ready to make her grief look like a lack of faith, as though a more godly wife would rejoice in the financial sacrifice, as though her legitimate worry about money was a failure of trust in God. I sometimes used that frame on her. I am ashamed of it. I used my calling to spiritualize a sacrifice I was imposing on my wife, and when she struggled under it I implied that her struggle was a spiritual problem, when in fact it was the entirely reasonable strain of a woman raising five boys on too little money while married to a man who would not ask for more.

There is a third strain, subtler than the others, and it has to do with the way money and ministry can become tangled

in the question of whether the pastor can ever leave. A man in an ordinary job who is being mistreated can quit and find another job, and the freedom to quit is itself a kind of dignity, a protection against being abused. But the pastor's job is also his calling, his housing is sometimes tied to it, his entire identity and social world are bound up in it, and leaving is not a simple matter of finding new employment, it can feel like leaving the ministry itself, like abandoning a vocation, like failing God. And this lack of exit makes the financial dependence more dangerous, because a couple that cannot easily leave is a couple that can be trapped, that can find itself enduring conditions it should not endure because the alternative feels like spiritual failure and economic catastrophe at once. Susanna and I felt that trap. There were seasons when the church was hard and the money was tight and leaving felt impossible, and the impossibility of leaving made the hardness harder to bear, because we could not even comfort ourselves with the thought that we could go.

What do you do about money in a ministry marriage. The first thing is to refuse to spiritualize the financial sacrifice in a way that silences your wife, and I say this to myself as much as to any reader. Her financial worry is not a lack of faith. It is the reasonable response of a person carrying a real burden, and the husband's job is to bear that burden with her, not to shame her out of feeling it. Talk about money honestly. Do the sums together. Let her grieve the sacrifices and grieve them with her rather than correcting her grief with theology. The financial strain of ministry is real, and a wife who is allowed to name it is a wife who is less alone in it, and being less alone in a burden is half of what makes a burden bearable.

The second thing is harder and more practical, and it is to advocate for your family financially even when it is awkward,

even when it complicates your role, even when it feels unspiritual. The pastor who will not ask the church for adequate support is not being humble, he is being negligent, he is sacrificing his family on the altar of his own discomfort with money, and his family pays for his squeamishness. I had to learn, late, that asking my congregation to pay me fairly was not greed, it was responsibility, that a worker is worthy of his wages as Scripture itself declares, and that by refusing to advocate for my family I was not being holy, I was being a poor steward of the people God had given me to provide for. Susanna should not have gone without the things she went without so that I could avoid an uncomfortable conversation. That was not sacrifice. That was cowardice wearing the costume of contentment, and the costume fooled me for years, and my wife paid the bill.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Children Watching the Marriage

MY FIVE SONS GREW up watching a marriage, and what they saw became their first and deepest education in what marriage is, in what a man owes a woman, in whether the gospel their father preached on Sunday was true enough to survive a Tuesday, and there were years when I am afraid of what they learned.

A child does not learn about marriage from what his parents say about marriage. He learns from what he watches, day after day, in the unguarded ordinary hours, and the pastor's child watches a particular thing. He watches his father leave, again and again, for the church. He watches his mother carry the home while his father carries the congregation. He watches the phone ring at dinner and the father rise and the family deflate. He watches the way his father speaks to his mother when he is tired, the way the marriage runs on logistics, the way the romance has been displaced by activity, and he absorbs all of it, not as doctrine but as the simple given texture of how a man and a woman

live together, and that texture becomes the template he carries into his own life, the unconscious picture of marriage against which he will measure every relationship he ever has. My sons were studying my marriage to Susanna while I was studying my commentaries, and I was a more careful student of the text than I was of the lesson I was teaching the people who shared my name.

What did they see in the worst years. They saw a father who was physically present and emotionally elsewhere, and from that they could have learned that this is what fathers are, half-there men whose real life is somewhere outside the home. They saw a mother carrying an invisible load, and from that they could have learned that this is what mothers are, women who hold everything while no one notices, and that could have shaped what they came to expect of and demand from the women they would one day marry. They saw a marriage in which the church always won, in which the wife always yielded to the congregation, and from that they could have learned that ministry is a thing that eats marriages and that a man who serves God will naturally shortchange his wife. I do not know the full extent of what my sons absorbed in those years, because the damage of a bad example does not always surface for decades, and some of it surfaces in a grandson I will never meet. But I know they were watching, and I know that what they watched was not always worthy of being watched, and that is one of the heavier griefs I carry.

*My sons were studying my marriage
while I was studying my
commentaries.*

THERE IS A SPECIFIC danger for the pastor's children that goes beyond the general danger of a poor example, and it is the danger of coming to resent the church itself, of growing up to see the congregation as the thing that stole their father, and of letting that resentment harden into a rejection of the faith their father preached. This is the well-known phenomenon of the pastor's kid who walks away, and while there are many causes, one of them, I am convinced, is the child who watched the church take his father and his mother and his home and decided he wanted nothing to do with a God whose service cost his family so much. I have lain awake over this. I have feared that in giving my best hours to the congregation I was not only wounding Susanna but teaching my sons that the gospel is a thief, that following Jesus means a father who is never quite there, that the church is a rival to be resented rather than a family to be loved. If my sons came to despise the church, I would bear a heavy share of the blame, because I showed them a version of ministry that was worth despising, a ministry that consumed their family while their father called the consumption faithfulness.

But I want to resist the temptation to leave this chapter in pure lament, because there is another thing the children can watch, and it is the most important thing of all, and it is repentance. My sons did not only watch me fail. By the grace of God, they also watched me begin, slowly and incompletely,

to repent, to come home, to fight for presence, to put down the phone, to choose Susanna over the church in moments where they could see the choosing. And I have come to believe that a child who watches his father fail and then repent learns something more valuable than a child who watches a father who never appears to fail at all. He learns that the gospel is true, that grace is real, that a man can be wrong and turn, that marriages can be wounded and healed, that the God his father preaches is a God who restores. The repentance my sons watched may have taught them more than my failures cost them, because it showed them the actual shape of the gospel lived out in a real marriage, not a marriage that was always good, but a marriage that was being redeemed, which is the only kind of marriage any of us actually have.

What I would say to the pastor whose children are watching is this. They are watching, and you cannot stop them from watching, and you cannot give them a perfect marriage to watch because no such marriage exists. But you can give them a marriage that is honestly fighting for itself, a father who visibly chooses their mother, a home where the church is loved but not worshiped, where the covenant is protected, where the children can see that the man who preaches the gospel actually believes it enough to let it govern the way he treats his wife. That is a gift that will outlast you. Your children will carry the marriage they watched into their own homes, and you have some say, not total say but real say, in what they carry. Susanna and I cannot undo what our sons watched in the worst years. But we have been able, by grace, to give them something better to watch in the years since, a marriage being healed in front of them, and I have to believe that the healing they witnessed is doing its own quiet work in

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them, an inheritance more durable than the wounds, a picture of a man who failed his wife and his God and came home and was met with mercy, which is, after all, the only story any of us have to tell, and the only one worth passing down.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Learning to Say No to the Church

THE MOST IMPORTANT WORD in the protection of a ministry marriage is the word no, and it is the word the pastor finds hardest to say, because every fiber of his training and temperament and theology has taught him that saying no to a need is saying no to God, and until he unlearns that lie his marriage will be consumed by a thousand yeses he never had the freedom to refuse.

I was a man who could not say no. I want to confess that as a character flaw and not merely a circumstance, because it would be too easy to blame the church for taking what I could not stop myself from giving. The church asked, yes, the church always asks, but the church did not force me. I gave. I said yes to the late meeting, yes to the extra event, yes to the phone call during dinner, yes to the counseling appointment on my day off, yes to the speaking engagement that took me from home, yes and yes and yes, and every yes to the church was a quiet no to Susanna, and I made a thousand of them, and not one of them felt like a refusal of my wife at the time,

because the yes was so loud and the no was so silent. The man who cannot say no to the church is not generous. He is a man who has outsourced his decisions to whoever asks last, and whoever asks last is never his wife, because his wife is the one person who has learned to stop asking.

Why could I not say no. The deepest reason is the one I keep returning to, that my worth was located in being needed, and to say no to a need was to refuse the very thing that made me feel valuable, was to risk the disappointment and disapproval of the people whose approval I had made the foundation of my identity. A man who needs to be needed cannot say no, because every no costs him a hit of the significance he is addicted to, and he will sacrifice almost anything, including his marriage, rather than take the hit. I was addicted to being needed by the church, and Susanna paid for my addiction the way the families of all addicts pay, by going without the resources the addict was spending on his habit. And I called the addiction servanthood. I dressed my compulsive yes in the language of availability and sacrifice and a shepherd's heart, and it fooled everyone, including me, for years.

*Every yes to the church was a quiet no
to Susanna, and I made a thousand of
them.*

LEARNING TO SAY NO is therefore not primarily a skill, it is a healing, because the inability to say no comes from a wound, and the wound is the location of one's worth in the

approval and need of others rather than in the finished love of God. You cannot teach a man to say no by giving him better boundary techniques. You have to heal the thing inside him that needs the yes, and that healing is the slow gospel work of coming to believe, all the way down, that you are already loved, already approved, already significant in Christ, so that you no longer need the church's need to tell you that you matter. A man who knows he is loved by God can disappoint a congregation, because the congregation's approval is not holding up his soul. A man who does not know it will say yes to everything, because every no threatens the only source of worth he has. The road to no runs through the gospel, and the pastor who cannot say no to his church has, somewhere, stopped believing the gospel he preaches, has started earning from his people what Christ has already given him for free.

But I do not want to leave this chapter in the realm of the interior, because no is also a practical discipline that has to be exercised, and the exercising of it is hard and concrete and worth describing. Saying no to the church means, in practice, deciding in advance what you will not give, before the request comes, because in the heat of the request you will not have the strength to refuse. It means choosing your protected hours, your Sabbath, your evenings, your family commitments, and treating them as fixed, so that when the church asks for them you can say no from a settled conviction rather than negotiating from scratch every time, because if you negotiate from scratch every time, the church will win, because the church's need will always feel more urgent in the moment than your wife's quiet and patient claim. Susanna and I had to build the no into the structure of our life, to make certain things simply unavailable, so that I did not have to summon the strength to refuse in the moment, because I

knew I did not have that strength, I had proven for years that I did not have it.

There is a fear that haunts the pastor who begins to say no, and the fear is that the church will be harmed, that needs will go unmet, that people will suffer because the pastor refused. And I want to address this fear honestly, because it is not entirely irrational. Sometimes when you say no, a need does go unmet, at least by you. But here is what I learned. The church is not as dependent on my yes as my ego believed. When I finally began to say no, to take my Sabbath, to guard my evenings, to refuse some of the requests, the church did not collapse. Other people stepped up. Needs got met by hands other than mine. The body of Christ turned out to be a body, with many members, and not a one-man operation that fell apart the moment the pastor protected his marriage. My inability to say no had not been keeping the church alive. It had been keeping me central, keeping me needed, keeping me addicted, and the church was actually healthier when I stepped back enough to let others step forward, and my marriage was healthier, and the only thing that suffered was my illusion that I was indispensable, an illusion that needed to die anyway, because it was a form of pride masquerading as service.

The pastor who learns to say no to the church for the sake of his wife is not loving the church less. He is loving it rightly, with a love that has a center and a limit, a love that flows from a full man and not a depleted one, a love that can be sustained for decades because it is not consuming the very marriage that is supposed to anchor it. The yes-man burns out, and his marriage burns down, and the church loses him entirely in the end. The man who can say no lasts. He pastors for the long haul, from a marriage that is fed rather than

starved, and his no to the occasional request is the price of his yes to a lifetime of faithful ministry. I learned to say no too late to spare Susanna years of my compulsive yes. But I learned it, and the learning of it was the learning of a kind of freedom I had never known, the freedom of a man who no longer needs the church's need to tell him he is worth something, and who can therefore give the church his love without giving it his soul, or his marriage, or his wife.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

When You Must Choose Your Spouse Over the Congregation

THERE COMES A MOMENT in a ministry marriage, and it comes more than once, when the pastor has to choose between his wife and his congregation, when the two cannot both be served, when one of them must be disappointed, and what the pastor does in that moment reveals what he actually believes, regardless of what he has preached.

I have to be careful in this chapter, because the conference circuit and the easy books will tell you that this choice is false, that loving your wife and loving your church are never finally in conflict, that a healthy ministry flows from a healthy marriage and the two rise together in perfect harmony. That is a comfortable thing to say and it is not true, and the pastors who most need this book know it is not true, because they have stood in the moment where the choice was real. The hospital visit or the anniversary. The board crisis or the son's game. The wounded member who needs you tonight or the

wife who has been waiting all week. Sometimes you cannot do both. Sometimes the demand of the church and the need of the spouse arrive at the same hour and point in opposite directions, and you have to choose, and the choosing is agonizing precisely because both claims are real and good, and the pretense that there is always a way to honor both is a lie that leaves pastors unprepared for the moment when there is not.

For years, when forced to choose, I chose the church, almost automatically, almost without deliberation, because the church's claim came clothed in the language of God's work and Susanna's claim came clothed in the language of mere domestic need, and I had been trained to rank God's work above domestic need. So I chose the congregation again and again, and each choice felt righteous, and the accumulation of those righteous choices was a marriage in which my wife had learned that she would always lose, that whenever it came down to her or the church, she would not be chosen, that her husband had a hierarchy and she was not at the top of it, no matter what he said about her from the pulpit. A wife learns the truth of where she stands not from your words but from your choices in the moments of conflict, and my choices told Susanna, for years, that she stood below the congregation, and she believed my choices over my words, as anyone would, as she should have.

*A wife learns where she stands not from
your words but from your choices in
the moments of conflict.*

WHEN DID THIS BEGIN to change. It began to change when I finally understood that the choice between my wife and my congregation was not a choice between a higher and a lower good, between God's work and mere domestic need, but was often a choice between two callings, and that the calling to my wife was the prior and deeper one. I keep returning to Genesis because the whole book returns to Genesis. A man shall leave his father and mother and hold fast to his wife. The holding fast to the wife is named, in the foundational text, as the defining human covenant, instituted before the fall, before the law, before the temple, before the church. When I chose the congregation over Susanna, I was not choosing a higher calling over a lower one. I was, in many cases, choosing a calling that came later over a calling that came first, breaking the prior covenant for the sake of the subsequent work, and there is no version of biblical faithfulness in which the later work is allowed to consume the prior covenant. The God who gave me the church also gave me the wife, and gave me the wife first, and a man who sacrifices the first gift to the second has not understood the order of the gifts.

I want to give a concrete example, because this chapter could float off into principle and the principle only matters when it touches a Tuesday. There was a time when Susanna was in genuine need, a hard season, a place where she required my presence and my attention and my choosing of her, and the church was also in a demanding season, and the two collided repeatedly, and I had a pattern of resolving the collision in the church's favor. And there came a particular point where I understood that if I kept choosing the church, I might keep the church and lose the marriage, and that the choice I was making was not, as I had told myself, a choice to

be faithful, but a choice to be unfaithful to the one I had promised first. And I chose her. I stepped back from things at the church that I could have done, that part of me wanted to do, that the church wanted me to do, and I gave that capacity to Susanna instead, and it cost me. It cost me standing, it cost me some of the church's approval, it cost me the feeling of indispensability that I had been addicted to. And it was the right choice, the faithful choice, the choice that the gospel actually required, even though it did not feel like the choice the ministry world would have applauded.

Here is the hard thing I have to say, and I say it knowing it will trouble some readers. Sometimes choosing your spouse over the congregation will look, to the congregation, like a failure of ministry, and you have to be willing to look like a failure for the sake of being faithful. The church may not understand why you stepped back. The board may grumble. The members may feel you have let them down. And you will have to bear their disappointment, because the alternative is to bear the destruction of your marriage, and a marriage is not a thing you can rebuild after it has been spent, the way a ministry can be rebuilt. Ministries recover from a pastor who chose his wife. Marriages often do not recover from a pastor who chose his church. The asymmetry should govern the choice. When in doubt, choose the one that cannot be rebuilt, choose the covenant that came first, choose the wife, and let the church think what it will, because you swore an oath to her at an altar and you did not swear that oath to them.

I do not mean by any of this that the pastor should neglect his church or treat every demand as a threat to be refused. The church is the bride of Christ and I love her and I have given my life to her and I will give the rest of it. Most days there is no conflict, most days you can serve the church and

love your wife without the two colliding, and most of ministry is the ordinary faithful tending of both. But the moments of true collision come, and they are decisive, and what you do in them teaches your wife what she is worth to you and teaches your own soul what you actually believe. Choose her in those moments. Not always, not in a way that abandons the church, but decisively, visibly, in the moments that count, so that your wife knows, from your choices and not just your sermons, that when it comes down to her or the congregation, she will be chosen, that she is not in an unwinnable competition with three hundred people for her own husband's loyalty, that there is one human being on this earth her husband will put above the church, and it is her, because he promised, and the promise holds even when the church demands he break it.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Counselor You Resist Seeing

THE PASTOR IS THE man everyone else comes to for counsel, and that is precisely why he is the man who will not go for it himself, and the refusal to seek help is one of the most common and most destructive features of the ministry marriage in trouble, and I refused for years, and the refusing nearly cost me everything.

There is a particular pride in the helper who cannot be helped, and it is a pride dressed so well in competence and spiritual maturity that it does not look like pride at all. I am the one who counsels couples. I have the training, the theology, the experience. I have sat across from a hundred struggling marriages and pointed the way through. How could I possibly need to sit on the other side of that desk, to become the one being helped, to admit that the expert cannot fix his own house. The pastor resists the counselor because going to the counselor is an admission that he is not what everyone believes him to be, that the man who diagnoses everyone else's marriage cannot heal his own, and that

admission feels like the collapse of his entire standing, his identity, his usefulness. So he does not go. He keeps counseling others while his own marriage quietly dies, the cobbler whose children have no shoes, the physician who will not be cured.

I resisted seeing a counselor with Susanna for an embarrassingly long time, and my resistance had several layers, and I want to name them because I suspect many pastors share them. The first layer was the pride I just described, the helper who cannot be helped. The second was the fear of exposure, the terror that if I sat in a counselor's office and told the truth about my marriage, the truth would get out, would damage my ministry, would end up known by the congregation or the denomination, because the ministry world is small and a pastor in marriage counseling is a vulnerable thing. The third layer was a kind of spiritual arrogance, a sense that I had the resources of the gospel and the Scriptures and prayer, and that needing a counselor was somehow a failure of faith, an admission that the spiritual resources were not enough, when in fact a wise counselor is one of the spiritual resources, a means of grace, a gift of God, and my refusal to use the gift was not faith, it was a faithless pride that dressed itself up as faith.

*The man who diagnoses everyone else's
marriage could not heal his own.*

WHAT FINALLY MOVED ME. It was Susanna, and it was close to the end of what she could bear, and I have to tell this part honestly even though it is hard. She told me, in one of the

honest conversations, that she did not think we could get where we needed to go on our own, that the patterns were too deep, that we had been going in circles for years, that she needed us to get help and that my refusal to get help was itself becoming a wound, a sign that I cared more about protecting my image as the competent pastor than about saving our marriage. And she was right. My refusal to see a counselor was a way of choosing my reputation over my wife, one more instance of the same idolatry that ran through everything, the location of my worth in being the capable one rather than in the love of God who is not ashamed to be associated with a pastor whose marriage needs help. When I finally agreed to go, it was not because I had overcome my pride. It was because I had finally come to the end of believing my pride was worth more than my marriage, and that coming-to-the-end was itself a kind of grace.

The counseling itself was humbling in ways I did not expect. To sit in the chair, to be the one whose patterns were being named, to hear an outside voice describe the very dynamics I had described in others a hundred times and to feel them land on me, was a profound and necessary humiliation, in the old sense of the word, the making low that is the precondition of being raised. I learned things about my marriage in that office that I had been unable to see from inside it, things Susanna had been trying to tell me for years that I could not hear from her but could finally hear from a third party, which is itself a humbling commentary on my own deafness, that I needed a stranger to tell me what my wife had been saying all along. The counselor did not give us magic. He gave us a place where the truth could be spoken safely, where the patterns could be named, where two people who had been stuck could begin to move, and the value of that

place is hard to overstate for a couple that has been going in circles in the dark.

I want to speak directly to the pastor who is resisting, because I know the resistance from the inside and I know how strong it is. You are afraid of exposure. There are ways to manage that, counselors outside your area, outside your denomination, professionals bound by confidentiality, and the fear of exposure, while real, is not a sufficient reason to let your marriage die. You are proud, you are the helper who cannot be helped, and I am telling you that the pride is a liar and the helper most needs help and there is no shame in the cobbler getting his own children shoes, there is only shame in letting them go barefoot to protect his reputation as a cobbler. You think the gospel and prayer should be enough, and I am telling you that a counselor is not a denial of the gospel but an instrument of it, a means by which the God who heals chooses to heal, and refusing the instrument is not faith, it is the same self-reliance the gospel came to break. Go. See the counselor. Sit in the chair. Be the one helped for once. It is the most pastoral thing you can do, because a pastor who has been humbled enough to receive help becomes a pastor who can offer it without the subtle condescension of the man who has never needed it himself.

The deepest thing I learned in that office was not a technique or even an insight about our patterns. It was that I was not the savior of my own marriage any more than I was the savior of my church, that the same gospel that frees a pastor from having to save his congregation frees him from having to save his marriage by his own competence, that I could bring my broken marriage to God and to the people God provides and receive help rather than having to generate the healing myself. The pastor who cannot receive help has not

understood grace, because grace is, at its root, the receiving of what you cannot produce, and a man who has built his whole life on producing, on being the capable one, on helping and never being helped, has built his life on a denial of the very grace he preaches. The counselor's office became, for me, a place where I finally practiced the gospel I had been preaching, the gospel of the helpless receiving help, and the practicing of it healed more than my marriage. It began to heal the pride that had been wounding my marriage all along.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Rebuilding Intimacy After Years of Neglect

THERE IS A PARTICULAR grief in turning, finally, toward a marriage you have neglected for years, and finding that the neglect has done its work, that the closeness you remember is gone, that you cannot simply decide to be intimate again after a decade of distance, that the years took something real and the taking has consequences that good intentions cannot instantly undo.

I came to the rebuilding of intimacy expecting it to be a matter of decision, of repentance and resolve, as though I could simply turn back toward Susanna and find her waiting, and the marriage we had lost would be there, restored by my willingness to want it again. It was not there. The years of neglect had built up a distance that my sudden attention could not dissolve, had taught Susanna a self-protective independence that did not melt the moment I became available, had created habits of separateness that we both had to unlearn slowly and painfully. You cannot starve a thing for years and then feed it once and expect it to be healthy. The

marriage I had neglected needed not a moment of repentance but a long season of rebuilding, and the rebuilding was slower and harder than the neglecting had been, because neglect is easy and rebuilding is not, neglect happens by default and rebuilding happens only by sustained intention against the grain of everything the neglect established.

The first hard truth of rebuilding is that the neglected partner does not immediately trust the turning. When I finally turned toward Susanna with real attention, she did not immediately open, because she had learned, over years, that my attention was not reliable, that it could be withdrawn the moment the church called, and so a part of her protected herself against my new attentiveness, waited to see if it was real, kept a guard up that years of disappointment had built. And I had to receive that guardedness without resentment, had to understand that I had built it, that her slowness to trust my turning was the entirely reasonable result of my years of turning away, that I had no right to demand she instantly believe in a change I had given her every reason to doubt. The neglectful husband who finally turns toward his wife and is then frustrated that she does not immediately respond has not understood what his neglect did. He taught her not to trust him, and now he must teach her, slowly, that he can be trusted again, and the teaching takes time, and the time is part of the cost of the neglect, a cost that comes due exactly when he is least patient to pay it.

*You cannot starve a thing for years
and then feed it once and expect it to be
healthy.*

THE REBUILDING OF INTIMACY happens in small things, and this surprised me, because I had imagined it would happen in grand gestures, in the big conversation, the romantic trip, the dramatic recommitment. Those have their place, but they are not where intimacy is rebuilt. Intimacy is rebuilt in the small reliable returns, the evening I am home when I said I would be, the conversation I stay present for, the day off I actually take, the hundred small fidelities that slowly accumulate into a new trust. Intimacy was lost in a thousand small neglects and it is regained in a thousand small faithfulnesses, and there is no shortcut, no single act that rebuilds in an hour what was lost over years. Susanna began to trust my turning not because of anything I said but because of the accumulating evidence of small reliable acts, the slow proof that this time the change was real, that the man turning toward her would still be turned toward her next week and the week after, and the accumulation of that evidence over months and years is what finally let her lower the guard that my neglect had built.

There is a sexual dimension to rebuilding intimacy after neglect that I want to address with care and honesty. Years of emotional distance and displaced intimacy take their toll on the physical relationship of a marriage, and the rebuilding of physical intimacy cannot be rushed or demanded, it follows the rebuilding of emotional intimacy and trust, and a

husband who has neglected his wife emotionally for years and then expects the physical relationship to be immediately restored has the order backwards and will only do more damage. Physical intimacy in marriage is not separable from the emotional and relational closeness that surrounds it, the one-flesh union is a union of whole persons, and the body will not easily give what the heart has learned to protect. I had to learn patience here that I had never needed before, had to understand that Susanna's body had learned the same self-protection her heart had learned, and that the rebuilding of our physical closeness would follow, not precede, the rebuilding of trust, and that my job was to be faithful in the small things and let the deeper restoration come in its own time, as the fruit of a trust rebuilt and not as a thing I could demand or accelerate.

What sustained the rebuilding, through the slow months and years, was a vision of marriage that went deeper than my own satisfaction, and here the gospel did its essential work. I was not rebuilding intimacy primarily to be happier, though I did become happier. I was rebuilding it because I had come to understand that my marriage was a covenant I had vowed to keep, an image of Christ and the church I was called to display, a sanctification God was working in me through the very difficulty of loving a wife I had wounded and who was slow to trust me again. The slowness of her trust was itself part of my sanctification, the painful and humbling experience of living with the consequences of my own neglect, of being unable to fix by willpower what I had broken by negligence, of having to depend on grace and time rather than on my own capacity to repair. The rebuilding of intimacy was not finally a project I completed. It was a grace I received, a restoration I could prepare for by faithfulness but could not

produce by effort, and the receiving of it, slowly, over years, was one of the deepest experiences of the gospel I have ever known, the experience of being given back something I had thrown away, of finding mercy at the bottom of a pit I had dug myself.

Susanna and I are not finished rebuilding, and I do not think we ever will be, because a marriage is not a thing that gets fixed and stays fixed, it is a living covenant that requires continual tending, and the years of neglect left a tenderness, a place where the marriage had been wounded that requires ongoing care. But the marriage that ministry nearly cost me is, by grace, a closer marriage now than it has been in many years, and the closeness is sweeter for having been lost and slowly regained, the way a thing recovered is dearer than a thing never lost. I would not wish the years of neglect on anyone, and I bear the grief of them still. But I can testify that intimacy can be rebuilt, that a neglected marriage is not a dead marriage, that the God who restores is at work even in the parsonage where the pastor woke up too late to what he had done, and that the slow rebuilding, faithful act by faithful act, is one of the truest forms of the gospel a pastor will ever live, because it is the gospel applied not to someone else's marriage from the safety of a counseling chair, but to his own, from inside the failure, where grace is not a doctrine he teaches but a mercy he desperately needs.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Loneliness No One Admits

THERE IS A LONELINESS specific to the ministry marriage that almost no one names, because to name it sounds ungrateful, sounds like complaining about a calling that is supposed to be a privilege, and so the loneliness goes unspoken, and the unspoken loneliness does its damage in the dark, and I want to bring it into the light because it nearly broke us both.

The pastor is surrounded by people and is profoundly alone, and this is one of the cruelest paradoxes of the vocation. He knows hundreds of people. He is at the center of a community. His calendar is full of human contact, of conversations and meetings and visits and meals with others. And he has, very often, no real friends, no one to whom he can say the true things, no peer who knows him as a man and not as a pastor, because everyone in his congregation is someone he must shepherd, and you cannot fully unburden yourself to the sheep you are called to lead, and the loneliness of leadership presses down on him in the midst of the crowd.

He is the loneliest man at his own potluck. And his wife is lonely in a parallel and connected way, because she cannot make close friends inside the church without the friendships becoming complicated by her position, cannot fully confide in the women of the congregation, cannot be vulnerable with the people who are watching her in the fishbowl, and so she too is surrounded and alone, and the two lonely people come home to each other and are supposed to be each other's company, and sometimes they are, and sometimes the loneliness is so deep that even together they cannot reach each other.

I felt this loneliness most acutely in the years when I was busiest, which is itself a clue to its nature, because the loneliness was not about a lack of people, it was about a lack of being known. I was known as a pastor by everyone and known as a man by almost no one. The people in my church knew the version of me that stood in the pulpit, the version that visited the hospital, the competent and caring and available version, and almost no one knew the man behind it, the man who doubted, who feared, who failed his wife, who was exhausted and discouraged and sometimes did not believe his own sermons on the hardest mornings. That man was hidden, had to be hidden, because the congregation needed the pastor and not the struggling man, and the hiding of the struggling man was a kind of loneliness so constant that I stopped noticing it, the way you stop hearing a sound that never stops. I was lonely all the time, and I had been lonely so long that I had forgotten loneliness was not the normal condition of a human being.

*I was the loneliest man at my own
potluck.*

THE LONELINESS HAS A marital dimension that is the reason it belongs in this book, and it is this. When the pastor is profoundly lonely, when he has no friends and no one who knows him, he places the entire weight of his need to be known on his wife, and the weight is too much for one person to carry. Susanna became, by default, my only friend, my only confidant, my only place to be known, and while there is a beauty in a wife being a husband's closest friend, there is a danger in her being his only one, because no single human being can be another human being's entire world without buckling under the load. I asked Susanna to be my wife and my best friend and my only confidant and my counselor and my whole social world, and that was too much, and her buckling under it was not a failure of hers but the inevitable result of my asking one person to fill a space that God designed to be filled by a community. The lonely pastor overburdens his marriage with his loneliness, and the marriage cannot bear the burden, and the very thing that was supposed to be his refuge becomes another place of strain.

The answer to the loneliness is not to demand more of the marriage, it is to address the loneliness directly, and this means the hard work of building real friendship outside the marriage, which the pastor resists for the same reasons he resists everything that protects his soul, because it takes time and admits need. The pastor needs friends who are not his congregants, peers in ministry or outside it, men who know

him as a man and not as a pastor, in front of whom he can take off the office and simply be himself. I came to friendship late, and partly through the Pastors Connection Network, which began in some sense from my own felt need for brothers who understood the particular loneliness of the vocation, who could know me as a fellow struggler and not as a leader to be impressed. The friendships I built outside my congregation took weight off my marriage, gave me places to be known that were not Susanna, and the taking of that weight off the marriage was, paradoxically, a gift to the marriage, because a marriage relieved of the impossible burden of being a man's entire world is a marriage freed to be what it was meant to be, a deep and central love but not a substitute for the whole community God designed each of us to need.

Susanna needed the same thing, and I had to learn to bless it rather than resent it. She needed friends outside the church and outside the marriage, women who knew her as a person and not as the pastor's wife, in front of whom she could be vulnerable without the vulnerability circling back into the fishbowl. And I confess that I sometimes resisted her having such friends, out of a possessiveness I described earlier, a sense that her confidences should run through me, and that resistance was a way of feeding my loneliness by isolating her into mine. The healthiest thing for both of us was to insist that each of us have a real life of friendship outside the marriage, so that we came to each other as two reasonably whole people and not as two starving people each demanding that the other be the only food. The loneliness no one admits is real, and it is dangerous, and it is one of the quiet killers of ministry marriages, and the answer to it is not to wring more from the marriage but to build the friendships that take the

impossible weight off the marriage, so that the marriage can be a marriage and not a desperate refuge for two people no one else is allowed to know.

I want to say one more thing about the loneliness, because there is a depth to it that friendship alone does not reach, and it is the loneliness before God himself. There were seasons in those years when I felt lonely even in my prayers, when God seemed distant, when the very faith I preached felt thin and far away, and that spiritual loneliness fed the marital loneliness and the marital loneliness fed it back, in a circle that pulled both of us down. I do not have a tidy answer for the loneliness before God, except to say that it is part of the life of faith, that even the Psalmist cried out from the depths, that the dark night of the soul is a thing the saints have always known, and that the presence of the loneliness is not the absence of God. But I will say that the marriage and the friendships and the faith are connected, that a man who is lonely in all three is in real danger, and that the building of human community around a ministry marriage is not a distraction from the spiritual life but a means by which God often lifts the spiritual loneliness too, because we are not meant to know God alone, we are meant to know him in the company of his people, and the pastor who has isolated himself from real human friendship has often isolated himself from one of the chief ways God intended to be known by him. Build the friendships. Bless your wife's friendships. Take the weight off the marriage. The loneliness no one admits will not survive the light, and the bringing of it into the light is one of the most important things a ministry couple can do for the covenant they are trying to protect.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Temptation Toward Another, and Why It Begins at Home

I HAVE TO WRITE a chapter that pastors do not want to read and that I did not want to write, because the great public catastrophe of ministry, the affair that ends a pastorate and shatters a family and disgraces the gospel in the eyes of watching skeptics, does not begin where everyone thinks it begins, and the failure to understand where it begins is exactly what makes so many of us vulnerable to it.

We talk about the affair as though it begins with the other person, with the attractive someone who appears and tempts the pastor away. We build our safeguards accordingly, the rules about not meeting alone, the accountability software, the careful boundaries, and those safeguards have their place and I keep them. But the affair does not begin with the other person. It begins at home, in the slow neglect of the marriage that I have been describing for seventeen chapters, in the emotional distance and the displaced intimacy and the

loneliness no one admits, because a man whose marriage has gone cold is a man with a hunger that the cold marriage is no longer feeding, and a hungry man is a vulnerable man, and the other person does not create the hunger, she merely arrives to a hunger that the neglect already created. The safeguards that guard against the other person while ignoring the state of the marriage are guarding the wrong door, because the danger came in through the marriage long before it walked up to the other person, and a man with a fed marriage is far better protected than a man with a thousand rules and a starving heart.

I want to be honest about my own vulnerability in those years, because a chapter on temptation written by a man who claims he was never tempted is a useless and dishonest chapter. In the years when my marriage was at its coldest, when the intimacy with Susanna had been displaced by activity and the distance between us had grown wide, I was vulnerable in a way I had not been when the marriage was warm, and I knew it, in the way a man knows things he does not want to look at directly. The attention of others lands differently on a man who is starving at home. The kind word, the admiring look, the woman in the congregation who seems to understand him, the counseling relationship that drifts toward the personal, all of these carry a charge for the neglected husband that they do not carry for the man whose marriage is feeding him, and the neglected husband who tells himself he is above temptation is the most vulnerable man of all, because he has stopped watching the door that the danger is actually coming through.

*The other person does not create the
hunger. She arrives to a hunger the
neglect already created.*

THE MECHANISM OF THE ministry affair, when I have seen it up close in other men and felt its early pull in myself, is almost always the same. It begins with emotional intimacy and not physical attraction, with a relationship in which the pastor feels known and understood in a way his cold marriage has stopped providing, often a counseling relationship or a ministry partnership or a friendship that meets the very hunger for being known that I described in the last chapter. The lonely pastor, starving for someone who knows him as a man, finds someone who seems to, and the relationship feels, at first, entirely innocent, even spiritual, even ministry, and that is exactly what makes it so dangerous, because the man does not recognize what is happening until he is already deep in it. The physical betrayal, when it comes, is the late and almost inevitable fruit of an emotional betrayal that began long before, and the emotional betrayal began as nothing more than the meeting of a legitimate need that the neglected marriage had stopped meeting. The road to the catastrophe is paved with legitimate needs gone unmet at home and then met elsewhere, and the pastor who wants to guard against the catastrophe must guard against the unmet needs, which means he must feed his marriage, which brings us back to everything this book has been saying.

So the deepest protection against the affair is not a rule but a marriage, a fed marriage, a marriage in which the

pastor's legitimate hungers for intimacy and for being known are being met by his wife, so that he is not walking through the world starving and vulnerable to anyone who offers a crumb. I do not say this to dismiss the rules, the boundaries, the accountability. Keep them. They are wise, they are guardrails for the moments of weakness that come to every man. But understand that they are guardrails and not the road, that a man with perfect boundaries and a dead marriage is a man waiting for the boundary to fail, and that the real work of protecting your marriage from the other person is the work of not having a starving marriage in the first place. I kept my marriage from the catastrophe not finally by my rules, though I am grateful for them, but by the grace of God in turning me back toward Susanna before the hunger of my neglected marriage made me prey, and I am sober about how close I came and how much was grace and how little was my own vigilance.

There is a self-implication here that I cannot avoid and will not soften, because the whole book has been built on refusing to soften. The years in which I gave the church my best hours and brought Susanna the husk, the years in which I let intimacy be displaced by activity and let the loneliness go unaddressed, those years were not merely a private sadness between me and my wife. They were years in which I was making myself vulnerable to the very catastrophe that would have destroyed my ministry and disgraced the gospel and shattered my sons, and I was doing it in the name of serving the church. The neglect of my marriage was not only a sin against Susanna. It was a danger to everything, a slow undermining of the very ministry I was neglecting her to serve, because a pastor whose marriage is starving is a pastor whose ministry is built over a fault line, and the same neglect

that wounds the wife endangers the work, and the man who thinks he is sacrificing his marriage for his ministry is actually placing a bomb under both. I did not see this for years. I see it now, and it terrifies me, and the terror is part of why I write, because I want some other pastor to see it before the bomb goes off, before the neglect that feels like sacrifice becomes the catastrophe that ends everything.

The way through is not vigilance against the other person, though keep your guardrails, it is the daily feeding of the marriage you have, the turning toward your wife, the closing of the distance, the addressing of the loneliness, the refusal to let your marriage go so cold that you become prey. Go home and feed your marriage. That is the truest safeguard against the affair, deeper than any rule, because it addresses the hunger rather than merely guarding the doors the hunger might escape through. A fed man is a safe man. A starving man with a thousand rules is a man waiting to fall. And the pastor who has let his marriage starve in the name of ministry has not protected his ministry, he has endangered it at the root, and the recovery of his marriage is not a distraction from his calling but the securing of its foundation, the closing of the fault line, the defusing of the bomb that his own neglect has been quietly building under the house.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

When the Church Wounds Your Wife Directly

EVERYTHING I HAVE WRITTEN so far concerns the indirect wounding, the way the church takes the husband and the wife absorbs the loss, the way criticism aimed at the pastor lands on his marriage. But there is a sharper wound, and I have to write about it, because it happens, and when it happens it tests the pastor in a way nothing else does. Sometimes the church wounds the wife directly. Sometimes the congregation, or a faction within it, turns on the pastor's wife herself, criticizes her, gossips about her, judges her, and the husband has to watch the people he serves wound the woman he vowed to protect, and what he does in that moment reveals the deepest layer of his loyalty.

I have seen this in many ministry marriages and I have felt its edge in my own. The pastor's wife is a target precisely because she is exposed and cannot easily defend herself. People who would never criticize the pastor to his face will

criticize his wife behind her back, will judge her parenting, her clothing, her warmth or lack of it, her involvement or lack of it, her hospitality, her singing, the cleanliness of her home, a thousand things that no one would dream of judging in an ordinary woman but that the fishbowl makes fair game when the woman is married to the pastor. And the criticism of the wife is often a displaced criticism of the husband, a way of getting at the pastor through the person who cannot fight back, and the wife absorbs it, and the wound is real, and the husband often does not even know it is happening because no one says it to him, they say it about her, in the spaces she cannot defend.

When I first became aware that Susanna was being wounded directly by people in the church, my instinct was a complicated and not entirely righteous one, and I want to be honest about it. Part of me wanted to defend her, to confront the critics, to stand between her and the wounding the way a husband should. But another part of me, the part that had located my worth in the approval of the congregation, was tempted to manage the situation, to smooth it over, to ask Susanna to be more careful, to win her people's approval, to fix the problem by adjusting my wife rather than confronting her critics, because confronting her critics risked my standing and adjusting my wife did not. And in my worst moments I gave in to that second instinct. When the church wounded Susanna, I sometimes turned to her and, in effect, asked her to be more pleasing to the people who were wounding her, to manage their opinion, to be a better pastor's wife, rather than turning to the church and defending the woman I had vowed to protect. I sided with her wounders against her, subtly, in the name of keeping the peace, and that is one of the betrayals I am most ashamed of.

*When the church wounded my wife, I
sometimes asked her to please the very
people who were wounding her.*

A HUSBAND IS CALLED to protect his wife, and the calling does not pause because the people wounding her are the people he is called to shepherd. This is one of the hardest collisions in ministry, because the pastor's protective duty to his wife and his pastoral duty to the congregation can point in opposite directions, and the pastor who always resolves the collision in the congregation's favor, who always asks his wife to absorb the wound for the sake of the peace, has failed at the prior covenant. There are times when the loving thing, the husbandly thing, the thing the covenant requires, is to stand between your wife and the congregation, to say to the people you serve, this is my wife, you will not speak of her this way, you will not judge her this way, she is not a public official you may criticize, she is a woman I have vowed to protect, and your wounding of her stops here. To say this costs the pastor something. It risks the very approval he is addicted to. And that is exactly why so few pastors say it, and why so many ministry wives are left undefended, absorbing the wounds of a congregation while their husbands manage the optics.

I want to be careful and not turn this into a license for the pastor to fight every critic and treat the congregation as the enemy, because that is its own error, the pastor who is so defensive of his wife that he cannot receive any feedback and treats the church as a threat to be battled. There is legitimate

feedback, and there are times when the congregation's observation about something is fair and the loving thing is to receive it. The discernment required is real. But the discernment must be governed by a clear prior commitment, which is that the wife is to be protected, that her dignity is not negotiable, that there is a line past which criticism of her becomes wounding and the husband stands in the gap. Most pastors err not on the side of over-defending their wives but on the side of under-defending them, of leaving them exposed for the sake of the peace, and the correction most of us need is in the direction of more protection, not less. I needed to defend Susanna more, not less, and my failure to defend her, my tendency to ask her to absorb and please rather than to stand between her and the wounding, was a failure of the most basic husbandly duty.

There is a theological weight here that I do not want to miss. Christ does not ask his bride to please her accusers. He stands between her and her accusers. He is her defender, her advocate, the one who answers the accusation against her with his own blood. The pastor's marriage is meant to image that love, and a pastor who leaves his wife to face her accusers alone, who asks her to win the approval of those who wound her rather than standing as her defender, has inverted the image, has made himself the manager of his wife's reputation rather than the protector of her person. When I finally learned to stand between Susanna and the congregation when the congregation wounded her, when I learned to say no, this is my wife and you will not, I was not only doing my husbandly duty, I was finally imaging the gospel I preached, the gospel of a bridegroom who defends his bride against every accusation, who does not ask her to earn the love of her accusers but covers her with his own. The

defense of my wife against the church that wounded her became one of the truest sermons I ever preached, a sermon preached not from the pulpit but in the standing of a husband in the gap, and the congregation needed that sermon more than they needed the polished one I would have given from the safety of never having to choose.

CHAPTER TWENTY

The Theology of One Flesh Against the Theology of the Cause

UNDERNEATH EVERY PRACTICAL FAILURE I have confessed in this book there is a theological failure, a wrong belief that produced the wrong life, and I want to name it directly now, because the practices will not change until the theology changes, and the theology that destroys ministry marriages is a theology so common that most of us absorbed it without ever examining it.

The theology that destroys ministry marriages is the theology of the cause. It is the belief, usually unspoken, that the cause of God, the work of the kingdom, the mission of the church, is the highest good, the thing to which everything else, including the marriage, including the wife, including the family, must be subordinated and if necessary sacrificed. It is a theology that sounds biblical, that quotes the verses about leaving everything to follow Christ, about hating father and mother for the sake of the kingdom, about the seed that must

fall into the ground and die, and it weaponizes those verses against the very covenant that God himself instituted, so that the pastor comes to believe that sacrificing his marriage for the cause is the height of discipleship, the proof of his devotion, the thing Jesus was asking for. I believed this. I believed that giving Susanna the husk while I gave the church my best was a form of cross-bearing, that my neglect of my marriage was a kind of martyrdom for the kingdom, and the theology of the cause blessed my neglect and called it holy.

Against the theology of the cause stands the theology of one flesh, and the theology of one flesh is older, deeper, and more authoritative, because it goes back to the garden, to the institution of marriage by God himself before there was any cause to serve, before there was a fall to redeem, before there was a church to build. A man shall leave his father and mother and hold fast to his wife and they shall become one flesh. This is not a concession to human weakness, a lower good to be sacrificed for the higher cause. This is a creation ordinance, a thing God built into the structure of reality before sin entered the world, a covenant that the New Testament tells us images the union of Christ and the church, the very gospel itself. The marriage is not a distraction from the cause. The marriage is a proclamation of the cause, a living image of the gospel, and a pastor who sacrifices his marriage for the cause has sacrificed one of the clearest proclamations of the gospel for the sake of a more visible but less truthful one. He has torn down a sermon God was preaching through his marriage in order to preach a louder sermon from his pulpit, and the louder sermon is undermined by the torn-down one, because the watching world reads the marriage more carefully than it reads the sermon.

*The theology of the cause blessed my
neglect and called it holy.*

LET ME ADDRESS THE hard verses directly, because the theology of the cause leans on them and they must be answered. Jesus did say that anyone who loves father or mother or wife or children more than him is not worthy of him. He did call disciples to leave their nets and their families and follow. But notice what these texts actually require, and what they do not. They require that Christ be first, above even the wife, and that is true and I affirm it, the marriage is not the highest thing, God is the highest thing, and a man who makes an idol of his marriage has his own disorder. But putting Christ first is not the same as putting the church first, and here is the deadly confusion at the heart of the theology of the cause. The pastor takes the command to put Christ above his wife and converts it into permission to put the congregation above his wife, as though the congregation were Christ, as though serving the church were identical to loving God, and it is not. The church is not Christ. The church is the bride of Christ, and a pastor can serve the bride in a way that betrays the bridegroom, can give the church what belongs to God and to his wife and call it devotion. Putting Christ first will often mean, in concrete terms, protecting your marriage against the church, because Christ instituted the marriage and Christ commands you to hold fast to your wife, and the church that demands you neglect your wife is not speaking for Christ in that demand, it is speaking for its own hunger.

This is the theological correction that took me years to

make, and making it changed everything downstream. I had to stop believing that the church and Christ were the same, that serving the congregation and loving God were identical acts, that sacrificing my marriage for the church was sacrificing it for God. They are not the same. God instituted my marriage and commands me to protect it. The church often demands that I neglect it. When those two collide, I am not choosing between God and my wife, I am choosing between God's command to hold fast to my wife and the church's demand that I let go of her, and the choice, framed correctly, is obvious, and only the theology of the cause makes it look hard. The theology of one flesh tells me that protecting my marriage is obeying God, that holding fast to Susanna is the creation ordinance, that the covenant I made with her is a covenant God himself witnessed and blessed and commands me to keep, and that no demand of the church, however urgent, however clothed in the language of the kingdom, can override the command of God to cleave to my wife.

I want to press this further, into the very meaning of the gospel the pastor preaches, because the theology of one flesh is not only a corrective to the theology of the cause, it is a positive vision that should reshape how the pastor sees his marriage. Paul, in Ephesians 5, takes the one-flesh union of Genesis and tells us it was always about Christ and the church, that the mystery of marriage is a mystery about the gospel, that when a husband loves his wife as Christ loved the church, giving himself up for her, he is preaching the gospel with his life. This means the pastor's marriage is not a private matter that runs alongside his ministry. It is part of his ministry, possibly the most important part, because it is the part where the gospel is not merely spoken but embodied.

The pastor who loves his wife sacrificially is preaching Christ's love for the church in a language the watching world cannot dismiss as mere words. The pastor who neglects his wife for the church is preaching, in that same wordless language, that the gospel does not actually produce love, that the man who proclaims Christ's sacrificial love for the bride does not himself love his own bride sacrificially, and the contradiction undermines every sermon he preaches. Your marriage is a sermon, the truest one you will ever preach, and the theology of one flesh tells you that protecting it is not stealing time from your ministry but securing the integrity of your entire witness.

So the deepest answer to the church that demands everything is not a boundary or a technique or a schedule, though all of those have their place. The deepest answer is a theology, the recovery of the theology of one flesh against the theology of the cause, the settled conviction that God instituted your marriage before he gave you your church, that holding fast to your wife is obedience and not distraction, that your marriage is a gospel proclamation and not a private indulgence, and that when the church demands you sacrifice your wife for the cause, the church is asking you to disobey the God it claims to serve. Get the theology right and the practices will follow, slowly and imperfectly, but they will follow, because a man who believes that protecting his marriage is obeying God will protect it differently than a man who believes that protecting it is stealing from God. I believed the wrong thing for years, and the wrong belief produced the wrong life, and the recovery of the right belief was the beginning of the recovery of my marriage, because I finally understood that in holding fast to Susanna against the demands of the church, I was not failing God. I was, for the

first time in years, actually obeying him.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

The Pastor's Wife Who Has No Calling of Her Own

THERE IS A QUIET violence done to many ministry wives that I have to name, the violence of having her entire identity absorbed into her husband's calling, of becoming the pastor's wife so completely that she forgets, or is never allowed to discover, who she is as a woman before God apart from the role she married into.

Susanna married a man, and the man became a pastor, and the church then proceeded to define her almost entirely by her relation to my office. She was the pastor's wife. That was her name in the congregation, her role, her function, the lens through which everything she did was interpreted. If she taught a Bible study, she was the pastor's wife teaching. If she was warm, she was a good pastor's wife. If she was reserved, she was a cold pastor's wife. Her every act was filtered through her relation to me, and over time the filtering can do something terrible, it can convince a woman that she has no

existence apart from the role, that she is a function of her husband's calling rather than a person with a calling of her own, a soul God made and loves and has purposes for that have nothing to do with whether her husband happens to pastor a church. The absorption of the wife's identity into the husband's office is one of the deep injustices of ministry life, and the church does it without thinking, and the husband often participates in it without thinking, and the wife disappears into the role without anyone, including herself, quite noticing she is gone.

I participated in this absorption of Susanna's identity, and I want to confess the specific way I did it, because it was subtle. I came to think of Susanna primarily in terms of her support for my ministry. I valued her for how she helped me, how she enabled the work, how she made my calling possible, and while there was love in that valuing, there was also a reduction, because I had stopped seeing her as a woman with a calling of her own and started seeing her as the supporting cast of mine. I did not ask what God was doing in her, what gifts he had given her, what he might be calling her to that had nothing to do with me, what she might have become if she had not spent her best years enabling my ministry at the cost of her own development. I assumed her calling was to support my calling, and that assumption, so common in the ministry world that it is rarely questioned, is a kind of theft, the theft of a woman's own vocation, her own relationship with God, her own purpose, all sacrificed to the husband's work and called a wife's faithful support.

*I had stopped seeing her as a woman
with a calling and started seeing her as
the supporting cast of mine.*

THE RECOVERY HERE IS delicate, because I do not want to swing into a different error, the error that says marriage involves no real submission, no real laying down of one's own preferences for the sake of the other, no genuine sacrifice for a shared life. Marriage does involve those things, for both husband and wife, and a wife who supports her husband's calling is not necessarily losing herself, she may be expressing a real and beautiful love, and many ministry wives find genuine calling in the shared work, and I honor that. But there is a difference between a wife who freely chooses to invest in her husband's ministry as an expression of her own calling and a wife whose identity has been so absorbed into her husband's office that she has no calling of her own left to express, who has disappeared into the role, who could no longer tell you, if you asked her, what God might be doing in her that is not about him. The first is love. The second is loss. And the husband's job is to make sure his wife has not been lost, that there remains a woman with her own walk with God, her own gifts, her own purposes, a woman the church relates to as a person and not only as a function of the pastor.

What does it look like to protect a wife's calling of her own. It looks, first, like the husband asking after it, taking it seriously, wanting to know what God is doing in his wife apart from him, treating her spiritual life and her gifts as real and not merely as fuel for his ministry. I had to learn to ask

Susanna questions I had stopped asking, what she was learning, what she sensed God doing in her, what she might want to do, give, become, that was hers and not mine. And I had to be willing to hear answers that might cost me, that might mean she invested less in my ministry in order to invest in something God was doing in her, and I had to bless that rather than resent it, because a wife's calling of her own is not a competitor to her husband's ministry, it is the flourishing of a soul God made for his own purposes, and a husband who resents his wife's flourishing because it does not serve his work has revealed that he was using her all along.

It looks, second, like refusing to let the church define her entirely by her relation to me. This means, in practice, the husband insisting that his wife be allowed to be a person in the congregation and not only a role, that she not be conscripted into duties she has no gifting or desire for simply because she is the pastor's wife, that the expectations placed on her be the expectations placed on any member with her particular gifts and not the inflated and undefined expectations placed on the office of pastor's wife that no one ever actually agreed to. Susanna is not a co-pastor. She did not take ordination vows. She is a woman in the congregation who happens to be married to me, with her own gifts and her own limits and her own calling, and the church's assumption that she is a two-for-one deal, that hiring me means acquiring her unpaid labor and her conscripted presence in every ministry, is an assumption I had to learn to resist on her behalf, because she could not resist it without seeming unsupportive, and the resisting of it was part of my protection of her as a person.

The theology underneath this is the theology of the image

of God, which the pastor preaches constantly and applies to his wife rarely. Susanna is made in the image of God. She is a soul of infinite worth, loved by God for her own sake, called by God to her own purposes, a person and not a function, an end and not a means. When the church absorbs her into the role of pastor's wife and I participate in the absorption, we are both, in a sense, denying the image of God in her, treating her as an appendage to my office rather than as a person in her own right before her Maker. The recovery of her calling of her own is the recovery of the image of God in her against the flattening of the role, and it is one of the most important and least discussed dimensions of protecting a ministry marriage, because a wife who has been allowed to remain a person, who has her own walk with God and her own gifts and her own calling, is a wife who comes to the marriage as a whole soul, and two whole souls make a marriage that two roles never could. I nearly let Susanna disappear into the role. The recovery of her as a person, a woman with a calling of her own that I was called to honor and protect rather than to absorb, was one of the great healings of our marriage, and I grieve the years I spent treating the most important person in my life as the supporting cast of my own.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

The Calendar as a Confession of Faith

I SAID EARLY IN this book that a man gives himself away in his calendar before he gives himself away in his confession, and I want to return to the calendar now and take it seriously as a spiritual document, because the calendar is where the theology of one flesh either becomes flesh or remains a doctrine, and most ministry marriages are lost not in the realm of belief but in the realm of the appointment book.

A calendar is a confession of faith. It says, more honestly than any creed, what a man actually believes is important, where he actually believes his life should go, what he actually treasures, because the calendar records not his intentions but his choices, not what he says matters but what he gives his hours to. And the ministry marriage is won or lost in the calendar, because the church's claim on the pastor is made concrete in the calendar, in the meetings and the events and the appointments that fill the hours, and the marriage's claim is made concrete or erased in the same place, in whether there is anything left in the calendar for the wife after the

church has taken its portion. I could preach the theology of one flesh perfectly and live the theology of the cause entirely, and the gap between them would show up nowhere more clearly than in my calendar, which recorded, week after week, that I believed the church's claims were fixed and my wife's claims were flexible, that the church's needs were appointments and my wife's needs were whatever happened to be left.

For years my calendar confessed a faith I would have denied with my mouth. My mouth said family second, only God above it. My calendar said the church first, the family in the margins. The church's events were entered first and defended absolutely. Time with Susanna was entered last, if at all, and surrendered first whenever a conflict arose. The calendar does not lie, and anyone who had looked at mine would have known what I treasured, regardless of what I preached, because the calendar showed the church taking the prime hours and my wife getting the leftovers, and a calendar like that is a confession of the theology of the cause no matter what the pastor says he believes. I had to learn to read my own calendar as a confession, to look at where my hours actually went and ask what that pattern was confessing, and the confession my calendar made for years was a confession I was ashamed to read, because it confessed that the church was first and Susanna was last, and my calendar was telling the truth that my theology was trying to hide.

*The calendar does not lie, and mine
confessed a faith I would have denied
with my mouth.*

THE PRACTICAL REFORM OF the calendar is one of the most concrete and powerful things a ministry couple can do, and I want to describe it without turning it into a formula, because the principle matters more than any particular method. The principle is that the marriage's claims must be entered first and defended with the same seriousness as the church's claims, that the time with the wife must go into the calendar before the church's events, not after, so that the church is built around the marriage rather than the marriage being squeezed into whatever the church leaves. This is a reversal of the normal pattern, in which the church's calendar is fixed and the marriage gets the gaps, and the reversal feels wrong to the ministry mind, feels selfish, feels like the marriage is getting priority over the kingdom. But entering the marriage first is simply the calendar finally confessing the true theology, the theology of one flesh, in which the prior covenant gets the prime hours and the subsequent work is built around it. Susanna and I learned to enter our protected time first, the Sabbath, the evenings, the dates, the unproductive hours, and to defend those entries against the church's later claims, and the changed calendar was a changed confession, a confession that the marriage came first because God instituted it first.

There is a discipline of saying no embedded in the reformed calendar, and it connects to the chapter on no, but I

want to draw out the specifically temporal dimension here. A calendar with everything in it is a calendar that confesses that you believe you are the savior, that everything depends on you, that you cannot say no to any claim on your time. A calendar with white space, with protected emptiness, with hours deliberately left unspent, confesses a different faith, the faith that the church belongs to Christ and not to you, that the work will survive your rest, that you are a man and not a machine, that your wife and your soul require hours that produce nothing. The white space in the calendar is itself a confession of faith, a confession that you trust God enough to stop, and the pastor whose calendar has no white space has a calendar that confesses he does not trust God to run the church without him, that he believes his ceaseless activity is holding the kingdom together. I had no white space for years, and the absence of white space was a confession of my functional atheism about my own indispensability, a confession that I did not really believe God was sovereign over my church, because if I had believed it I would have been able to stop.

Let me connect the calendar to the marriage as directly as I can, because this is not finally a chapter about time management. When Susanna looked at our calendar in the worst years, she saw her own value, and the value she saw was low. She saw that she came after the board meeting, after the hospital visit, after the event, after everything, that her time with me was the most negotiable thing in our shared life, the first thing surrendered and the last thing protected. And she drew the obvious and correct conclusion, that she was the least important claim on her husband's life, because the calendar told her so, and the calendar tells the truth. When I reformed the calendar, when I began entering her first and

defending her time, she saw a different value, saw that she was no longer the most negotiable thing, saw that her husband was building his life around her rather than fitting her into the gaps, and the changed calendar communicated love more powerfully than any words could, because the calendar is where love is either proven or exposed. You can tell your wife she comes first with your mouth a thousand times, and she will believe your calendar over your mouth every time, because the calendar is where you actually live.

So I say to the pastor reading this, look at your calendar, and read it as a confession of faith, and ask what it confesses. Does it confess that the church is first and your wife is last. Does it confess that you are the savior who cannot stop. Does it confess that your wife's time is the most negotiable thing in your life, the leftover, the gap-filler. If it does, then your calendar is preaching a different gospel than your pulpit, and your wife is hearing the calendar's gospel, not the pulpit's. Reform the calendar. Enter her first. Defend the white space. Build the church around the marriage rather than squeezing the marriage into the church. The calendar is where the theology of one flesh becomes flesh or stays a doctrine, and most ministry marriages die not in the realm of belief but in the realm of the appointment book, killed by a thousand small entries that confessed, week after week, a faith the pastor would have denied with his mouth but lived with his hours. Make your calendar tell the truth your theology already knows, that the covenant comes first, and let your wife finally read, in the document that does not lie, that she is treasured.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

The Seasons of a Ministry Marriage

A MARRIAGE IS NOT a static thing, and a ministry marriage moves through seasons that bring their own particular pressures, and I want to walk through some of these seasons, because the pressures of the early years are not the pressures of the middle years, and the couple that does not understand the seasons will misread the present one, will think the difficulty of a particular season is the permanent condition of the marriage when it is the temporary weather of a passing time.

The first season is the season of the young pastor and the young marriage, and it has a particular intensity, because everything is new at once, the ministry and the marriage and often the children, and the young pastor is trying to establish himself, prove himself, build something, and the proving and the building consume him at exactly the moment when the young marriage most needs his attention. This was my hardest season, and I think it is the hardest for many, because the young pastor's insecurity drives him to overwork, to say

yes to everything, to give the church his all in a desperate bid to establish that he is worthy of the call, and the young marriage, which has not yet built its reserves, its history, its deep roots, gets neglected at its most vulnerable moment. The early years of my marriage to Susanna coincided with the early years of my ministry, and the ministry won, decisively, and the marriage took wounds in those early years that we spent the later years healing. The young ministry couple must understand that the insecurity of the early years is a particular danger to the marriage, that the drive to prove oneself in ministry is exactly the drive that will starve the young marriage, and that the wounds taken in the early years are deep precisely because the marriage is young and has no reserves to absorb them.

The second season is the season of the growing family and the establishing ministry, the middle years, when the children are many and demanding and the ministry has grown and the pastor is stretched between a household full of need and a congregation full of need, and the marriage, caught between them, becomes the place where the stretching is felt most acutely. This was the season of the invisible load, the season when Susanna carried five boys and a household while I carried a growing church, and the season when the displacement of intimacy by activity was most total, because there was simply so much activity, so much need, so much to be done, that the unproductive hours of intimacy were the first casualty. The middle years are dangerous because they are so full, because the sheer volume of legitimate demand crowds out the marriage, and the couple can spend a decade or more in pure logistics, raising children and running a church, and emerge at the end of it to find that they have become strangers, that the marriage that went into

the middle years is not the marriage that came out, that something was lost in all the doing that they did not even notice losing.

*The marriage that goes into the middle
years is not always the marriage that
comes out.*

THE THIRD SEASON IS the season of the emptying nest and the maturing ministry, and it brings its own danger, which is the danger of discovering, when the children leave and the ministry steadies, that the marriage underneath has hollowed out, that the couple who spent twenty years coordinating children and church do not know how to be a couple without the children to coordinate, that they have built a partnership of logistics and have no marriage left when the logistics recede. This is why so many marriages, including ministry marriages, come apart in the empty-nest years, not because anything new went wrong but because the absence of the children revealed how much had already gone wrong, how thoroughly the marriage had been displaced by the management of the family, how little was left when the management ended. Susanna and I approached this season with fear, because we knew our marriage had been displaced by activity, and we feared what we would find when the activity receded, and the fear drove some of the rebuilding I described earlier, the deliberate turning back toward each other before the children left and exposed how far we had drifted. The couple that does not rebuild before the nest

empties will find the emptying nest a crisis, and the couple that rebuilds will find it a gift, a return to the marriage they began with, deeper now for everything they have been through.

There is a fourth season, the season of age and decline, which I have not fully entered but which I think about, the season when the ministry winds down, when the pastor's strength fails, when the roles that defined a ministry life fall away and the man and the woman are left with each other and with God and with whatever they built or failed to build across the decades. And I think about this season because it is the season that judges all the others, the season in which a couple either has a marriage to grow old in or discovers that they spent the marriage on the ministry and have nothing left to grow old with. The pastor who gives the church everything and the marriage the leftovers is building toward a lonely old age, an old age in which the church he served will have moved on to the next pastor and the wife he neglected will be a stranger beside him, and the man will sit in the wreckage of a marriage he spent on a ministry that no longer needs him. I do not want that old age. The fear of that old age is part of what drove me to repent, the sober recognition that the church would not be there at the end, that the church would have a new pastor and forget my name, and that the only human being who would be there at the end was the woman I had been neglecting, and that I had better build a marriage worth growing old in while there was still time.

The seasons teach a lesson that no single season can teach, and the lesson is that the ministry marriage must be tended across the whole arc, that the wounds of one season are healed or deepened in the next, that the neglect of the

early years compounds into the hollowness of the middle years and the crisis of the empty nest and the loneliness of old age, and that the tending of the marriage is not a thing you do once but a thing you do across decades, through changing pressures, in season and out. Susanna and I are somewhere in the later middle of our arc, with sons grown and grandchildren coming and a ministry still demanding and a marriage that has been wounded and is being healed, and what I have learned from the seasons is that it is never too late and never finished, that a marriage neglected in one season can be recovered in the next, that the God who redeems is at work across the whole arc and not only at the start, and that the couple who keeps turning back toward each other, season after season, through the changing weather of a ministry life, will arrive at the end with a marriage to grow old in, which is, in the end, one of the few things worth arriving with.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

What Susanna Carried That I Could Not See

I HAVE WRITTEN A great deal in this book about what I did, and I have tried to be honest about my failures, but there is a perspective I have been circling without fully entering, and I have to enter it now, because a book about a ministry marriage written entirely from the husband's side is only half a book, and the half I have left out is the half that suffered most.

I cannot speak for Susanna, and I will not pretend to, because one of the failures this book confesses is the failure to let her speak for herself, the years of absorbing her into my story rather than honoring hers. But I can tell you what I have come to understand, slowly and late, about what she carried in the years when I could not see it, because the seeing of it, finally, was part of my repentance, and a husband who has wounded his wife owes her, at minimum, the labor of understanding what his wounding cost. So let me try to see, now, what I refused to see then, and let me see it not from my side but from hers, as best a man can see his own failure

through the eyes of the one he failed.

She carried the loneliness of being married to a man who was always somewhere else. I have written about my loneliness, the loneliness of the pastor surrounded by people and known by none. But Susanna's loneliness was sharper, because she was married to me, was supposed to have a companion, a partner, a husband present to her, and instead she had a man whose body came home and whose self did not, and there is a particular loneliness in being married and alone, in sleeping beside a man who is at the church behind his eyes, that is worse than the loneliness of the single person, because the single person does not have the daily reminder of the companionship that is supposed to be there and is not. She was lonely inside her marriage, which is the loneliest place to be lonely, and I gave her that loneliness, day after day, and called my absence devotion to God.

*She was lonely inside her marriage,
which is the loneliest place to be lonely.*

SHE CARRIED THE EXHAUSTION of doing the work of two parents while married to one, the relentless labor of raising five boys with a husband who could be called away at any hour and frequently was, the impossibility of ever fully resting because the home depended on her in a way it did not depend on me, because I had made myself unreliable through my availability to everyone else. She carried the management of a household and a budget and a calendar and the thousand daily decisions, and she carried it while also being expected to be the gracious pastor's wife, warm and available and

hospitable, and she carried it while absorbing the criticism aimed at me and the wounds the church sometimes aimed at her directly, and she carried all of it without the one thing that might have made it bearable, a husband who saw it, who named it, who came alongside it, because I did not see it, because seeing it would have required me to admit that my ministry was being subsidized by my wife's exhaustion, and that admission was too expensive.

She carried the silencing, the inability to say what she really felt, the knowledge that her honesty could cost me my standing and so the swallowing of her honesty for my sake, the years of editing herself, of protecting me from her own true feelings, of being unable to be fully known by her own husband because her husband had made the truth dangerous. She carried the fishbowl, the constant watching, the loss of the ordinary freedom to be a private person, the performance of a marriage on Sunday that the private marriage could not always sustain. She carried the financial strain, the doing of the sums, the going without, the spiritualizing of her sacrifice that made her legitimate worry look like a failure of faith. She carried the absorption of her identity into my office, the disappearing into the role of pastor's wife, the loss of her own calling to the demands of mine. She carried all of it, and she carried it largely alone, and she carried it with a grace that I mistook for contentment, because her grace was so complete that it hid the cost, and a man can be married to a woman bleeding quietly for years and mistake her grace for the absence of a wound.

What undoes me, when I finally see it, is the combination of how much she carried and how alone she carried it and

how I praised her for carrying it. I admired her strength while that strength was being spent covering for my failure. I was grateful for her support while that support was enabling my neglect. I held her up as a model pastor's wife while she was quietly dying inside the role, and the very qualities I praised, her grace, her strength, her capability, her support, were the qualities that hid from me how badly I was failing her, because a less graceful, less strong, less capable woman would have broken visibly and forced me to see, and Susanna's strength meant she did not break visibly, she bent and bent and absorbed and absorbed, and I mistook her not-breaking for her being fine. The strongest wives suffer the longest in silence, because their strength enables their husbands to ignore the suffering, and Susanna's strength was, in a terrible irony, part of what let me fail her for so long.

I see it now, and the seeing is a grief that does not go away, and I do not think it should go away, because the grief is the proper response of a man who has finally understood what his neglect cost the person he loved most. But the seeing is also the beginning of love, because you cannot love what you do not see, and I had been failing to love Susanna partly because I had been failing to see her, failing to see what she carried, failing to see the cost, failing to see her as a suffering person rather than a capable support. The recovery of our marriage began when I began to see her, when I finally looked at what she had been carrying and let it break my heart, when I stopped admiring her strength and started grieving what her strength had been hiding. A husband who wants to love his wife must first see her, must do the labor of understanding what she carries, especially the parts she has been carrying alone and in silence, and the ministry husband, distracted by everyone else's visible needs, is in

particular danger of never seeing the invisible needs of the one closest to him. See her. Whatever else you take from this book, go home and do the hard, humbling labor of seeing what your wife has been carrying that you have not been able to see, and let the seeing break your heart, because the broken heart is where love begins again, and a marriage cannot be healed by a husband who has not yet let himself see what he broke.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

The Idol of Indispensability

I HAVE NAMED, IN chapter after chapter, a root beneath my failures, the location of my worth in the approval and need of the congregation, and I want to give that root its own chapter now and call it by its true name, because it is an idol, and it is the particular idol of the pastor, and until it is named and confronted it will keep producing the very failures this book has been describing.

The idol of the pastor is indispensability, the need to be needed, the belief that the church cannot function without him, that his constant presence and effort are holding the whole thing together, that he is, in some functional sense, the savior of his congregation. This idol does not look like an idol, because it wears the costume of devotion and sacrifice and a shepherd's heart, but it is an idol nonetheless, because it puts the pastor in the place of God, makes him the one on whom everything depends, the indispensable one, and there is only one indispensable one in the church and his name is Jesus and it is not the pastor. The idol of indispensability is the

engine that drives the workaholism, the inability to say no, the mind that never leaves the church, the calendar with no white space, the neglect of the marriage, because all of those are the natural behavior of a man who believes the church depends on him, who cannot rest because resting would mean the thing he is holding together might fall apart, who cannot leave the church at the church because the church needs his anxious supervision to survive.

I worshiped this idol for years, and I worshiped it the more fervently because it was invisible to me, because I had dressed it so completely in the language of faithfulness that I could not see it was an idol at all. I thought I was being devoted. I was being idolatrous. I thought I was sacrificing for the kingdom. I was feeding a need to be needed that had nothing to do with the kingdom and everything to do with my own insecurity, my own need to matter, my own terror that if I were not indispensable I would not be valuable. The idol of indispensability is, at root, a worship of the self, a way of securing one's own worth through being needed, and it masquerades as a worship of God, as service to the church, when it is actually the pastor using the church to feed his own hunger for significance. I used my congregation to feel important, and I called it ministry, and the using of them cost my wife everything, because a man feeding his idol of indispensability at the church has nothing left for the woman at home who needs him not as the indispensable savior but as a simple present husband.

*There is only one indispensable one in
the church, and his name is not the
pastor.*

THE CONNECTION TO THE marriage is direct and devastating. The idol of indispensability requires that the pastor be needed, and the church needs him in a way the marriage does not, or at least appears to. The church has crises that only he can manage, sheep that only he can shepherd, a Sunday that only he can fill, and all of this feeds the idol, makes the pastor feel indispensable, important, needed. The marriage, by contrast, asks the pastor to be present rather than indispensable, to be a husband rather than a savior, to give ordinary daily love rather than heroic crisis management, and the idol of indispensability finds no food in ordinary daily love, because ordinary daily love does not make a man feel like the irreplaceable hero. So the pastor who worships indispensability is drawn, magnetically, to the church and away from the marriage, because the church feeds the idol and the marriage does not, because the church lets him be the indispensable savior and the marriage asks him to be a mere husband, and the idol always pulls toward the place where it is fed. I was pulled toward the church and away from Susanna by the idol of indispensability, by my hunger to be needed in a way the church could satisfy and the marriage could not, and the satisfying of that hunger at the church was the starving of my marriage at home.

The death of the idol of indispensability is one of the hardest deaths a pastor undergoes, because the idol has

become so fused with his identity that killing it feels like killing himself, and in a sense it is, it is the killing of the false self that the pastor has built on being needed, and the killing is painful and slow and resisted at every step. The idol does not die in a moment of decision. It dies in a thousand small surrenders, each one of which feels like a small death, the saying of no when the idol screams that you are needed, the taking of the Sabbath when the idol insists the church will fall apart, the going home when the idol demands you stay, the choosing of your wife when the idol tells you the congregation needs you more. Each of these is a death of the idol, a refusal to feed it, a declaration that you are not the indispensable savior, that the church belongs to Christ, that you are a servant and not a savior, and the cumulative effect of these small deaths, over years, is the slow starving of the idol that has been starving your marriage.

The gospel is the only thing that finally kills the idol of indispensability, and it kills it by addressing the hunger underneath it, the hunger for worth, for significance, for mattering, that drove the pastor to make himself indispensable in the first place. The pastor builds his indispensability because he needs to be valuable, and he needs to be valuable because he does not yet rest in the value God has already given him in Christ, the value declared over him in his adoption, the value that does not depend on being needed by anyone. When a man comes to rest in the gospel, in the finished declaration of his worth in Christ, he no longer needs to be indispensable, because his worth is no longer on trial, no longer something he has to secure through being needed. He can be dispensable. He can take a day off and let the church survive without him, because his worth does not depend on the church needing him. He can go home and be a

mere husband, giving ordinary daily love, because he no longer needs the heroic significance of being the indispensable savior. The death of the idol of indispensability is the fruit of the gospel finally going deep, finally reaching the place where the pastor's worth is settled, and the marriage is one of the great beneficiaries of that death, because the man freed from the need to be indispensable is finally free to be present, free to be home, free to be a husband, free to give his wife the ordinary daily love that the idol had been telling him was beneath the heroic work of saving the church. I am still killing this idol. It does not die all at once. But every small death of it has been a gift to my marriage, because every refusal to be indispensable at the church has been a turning back toward the woman who needed me to be, not a savior, but simply, finally, present.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

Repentance That Is More Than Words

I HAVE USED THE word repentance many times in this book, and I want to slow down and examine it, because there is a kind of repentance that changes nothing, a repentance of words and feelings that leaves the life untouched, and the ministry husband is especially prone to it, because he is fluent in the language of repentance and can produce the words without the substance, can confess his failures eloquently and continue committing them.

I was, for years, an expert at the repentance that changes nothing. I could feel genuine sorrow over my neglect of Susanna, could confess it to God and even to her, could weep over it, could resolve to do better, and then I could continue, the very next week, giving the church my best hours and bringing her the husk, because my repentance was a repentance of feeling and not of life, a repentance that touched my emotions and left my calendar unchanged. And the repentance that leaves the calendar unchanged is not repentance at all, whatever feelings accompany it, because

repentance, in the biblical sense, is a turning, a change of direction, a different life, and a man who confesses his neglect on Saturday and repeats it on Monday has not turned, has merely felt bad, and feeling bad is not repenting. The ministry husband must beware the repentance of words, because his fluency in the language can substitute for the substance, can let him feel that he has repented when he has only spoken, and the wife who has heard a hundred eloquent confessions that changed nothing has learned to distrust the words and watch the life.

Susanna had heard my confessions for years, and she had watched my life not change, and so by a certain point my confessions had become, to her, almost worthless, because they were checks drawn on an account with no funds, words of repentance that the subsequent week always proved empty. And I could not understand, in my self-deception, why my confessions did not seem to help, why Susanna received my eloquent sorrow with a weariness rather than a relief, and the reason was obvious once I could see it. She had learned that my words of repentance predicted no change in my behavior, that I would confess and then continue, and so my confessions had stopped being good news to her and had become, if anything, another wound, the reopening of a hope that the following week would crush. The repentance of words that changes nothing is worse than no repentance at all, because it raises a hope it does not fulfill, promises a change it does not deliver, and teaches the wounded spouse that even the husband's sorrow is unreliable, that even his confessions are checks that bounce.

*My confessions were checks drawn on
an account with no funds.*

WHAT IS THE REPENTANCE that is more than words. It is a repentance that changes the calendar, that changes the choices, that produces a different life and not merely a different feeling. It is the repentance that, having confessed the neglect, actually reforms the schedule, actually says the no, actually takes the Sabbath, actually goes home, actually chooses the wife, so that the confession is followed by the changed behavior that proves the confession was real. The test of repentance is not the eloquence of the words or the depth of the feeling but the change in the life, and a repentance that does not change the life is a counterfeit, however sincere it feels in the moment. I had to learn that my sorrow over my neglect of Susanna meant nothing until it changed my calendar, that my confessions were worthless until they were followed by a different week, that the only repentance she could trust was the repentance she could see in my altered behavior, and that all my eloquent words were, until then, just noise.

There is a particular humility required here that the ministry husband resists, because the proving of repentance through changed behavior takes time, and the husband wants to be forgiven and restored on the strength of his confession, wants the words to be enough, wants his wife to trust his repentance immediately. But she cannot, and she should not, because she has learned that his words do not predict his behavior, and the only thing that can rebuild her trust is the

slow accumulation of changed behavior over time, the weeks and months and years of a different life that gradually prove the confession was real. The husband must accept this, must accept that his wife's slowness to trust his repentance is not unforgiveness but wisdom, the reasonable wisdom of a person who has been burned by empty confessions before, and he must prove his repentance by his life over time rather than demanding to be trusted on the strength of his words. I had to accept that Susanna could not simply believe my repentance, that I had to earn back her trust through a changed life sustained over years, that the very fact that my repentance required proving was itself a consequence of my years of empty confessing, a debt I had to pay by patient faithfulness rather than a wound to protest.

The gospel undergirds the repentance that is more than words, and it undergirds it in a way that frees the husband from despair, because the repentance that changes the life is itself a work of grace and not merely of willpower. I could not, by my own strength, produce the changed life that real repentance requires, because the same idolatry that drove my neglect would have driven my failure to change, and a man cannot pull himself out of his own idolatry by his own bootstraps. The changed life comes as the fruit of the gospel going deep, of the idol of indispensability dying, of the worth being relocated from the church to Christ, and so the repentance that is more than words is not a heroic act of the husband's willpower but a humble receiving of the grace that changes him, a grace that he cannot generate but can only receive, on his knees, as a man who knows he cannot change himself and is asking God to do it. The repentance that is more than words is, paradoxically, a repentance that despairs of its own power to change and casts itself entirely on grace,

and it is precisely that despairing, grace-dependent repentance that actually produces the changed life, because it is rooted not in the husband's resolve, which has failed a hundred times, but in the power of God, which does not fail. I repented with words for years and changed nothing. I began to change only when my repentance became a desperate casting of myself on grace, a confession not only of my neglect but of my inability to stop neglecting apart from God's power, and it was that grace-dependent repentance, and not my willpower, that finally began to change the calendar, and the marriage, and the man.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

The Sundays That Cost Her Most

THERE IS A DAY in the ministry marriage that deserves its own examination, because it is the day the whole vocation is organized around and the day that costs the wife the most, and that day is Sunday, the day the pastor is at his most depleted and his most absent precisely when his family is supposed to be worshiping with him.

Sunday is the pastor's hardest workday, and this fact reshapes the family's experience of the day that is supposed to be a delight. For everyone else in the congregation, Sunday is rest, gathering, worship, family. For the pastor, Sunday is performance, output, the giving of himself to hundreds of people in a concentrated few hours that drain him completely. And his family lives on the other side of that drain. They wake on Sunday to a husband and father who is already gone into himself, preoccupied with the sermon, anxious about the service, unavailable in the hours before church because he is preparing, unavailable during church because he is working, and unavailable after church because

he is spent, emptied, with nothing left for the people who share his name. Susanna and the boys experienced Sunday not as a day of worship with husband and father but as a day they shared a building with a man who was working, a day he was most physically present at the church and most emotionally absent from them, a day that was supposed to be holy and was, in our home, often one of the hardest.

I did not understand for years what Sundays cost my family, because I experienced Sunday from inside the work, as a day of demanding and meaningful labor, and I assumed my family experienced it as I told them to experience it, as a day of worship and gathering. But they experienced it as the day they lost me most completely, the day I was given entirely to the congregation, the day they sat in a pew and watched their husband and father pour himself out for everyone else and come home with nothing. There is a particular ache for the pastor's wife who watches her husband be warm and engaged and present with three hundred people on a Sunday morning and then come home and collapse into a depleted silence, because she has just watched him give to strangers the very presence he has no energy left to give her, has watched the public version of her husband, the warm and available pastor, perform for the congregation while the private version, the one she lives with, has nothing left. The contrast between the Sunday-morning pastor and the Sunday-afternoon husband is a contrast that wounds, because it shows the wife exactly what her husband is capable of and exactly who gets it, and it is not her.

*She watched me give strangers the
presence I had nothing left to give her.*

THE CHILDREN EXPERIENCE THE Sunday cost in their own way, and it deserves naming. For the pastor's children, Sunday can become the day they most resent the church, because it is the day the church most visibly takes their father, the day they are in the building but cannot have him, the day they are held to the highest standard of behavior while receiving the least of his attention. A pastor's child sits through the service watching his father be the center of everything and being unable to reach him, being shushed and managed and expected to be a model child while the one person he wants is up front giving himself to everyone else. And the children carry this into their feelings about church itself, so that Sunday, the day that is supposed to plant in them a love for the gathered people of God, can instead plant a resentment, an association of church with the loss of their father, and the pastor who does not understand the Sunday cost to his children may be unwittingly teaching them, every week, to resent the very thing he most wants them to love.

What can be done about the Sunday cost, given that Sunday cannot be moved and the pastor's work on Sunday cannot be avoided. The first thing is simply to see it, to understand that Sunday costs the family in a way it does not cost the congregation, and to stop assuming that the family experiences Sunday as a delight when for them it may be the hardest day. The seeing changes how the pastor approaches the day, makes him gentle with his family's experience of it,

makes him understand their Sunday weariness or resistance not as a spiritual failure but as the reasonable response of people who lose him most completely on the day everyone else gains the most. Susanna's occasional heaviness on Sundays, which I once interpreted as a failure of joy, I came to understand as the reasonable weight of a woman losing her husband to the congregation on the very day she most needed him beside her, and the reinterpretation changed me from her critic into her companion in the cost.

The second thing is to guard what surrounds Sunday, since Sunday itself cannot be reclaimed. If Sunday is the day the family loses the pastor most completely, then the days around Sunday must be protected to compensate, the Sabbath taken on another day and guarded fiercely, the Sunday evening reclaimed for the family if the pastor has anything left, the Monday protected as a day of recovery and presence rather than allowed to become another workday. Susanna and I learned to treat Sunday as a day of cost that had to be balanced by deliberate presence on the surrounding days, to stop pretending Sunday could be a family day and instead to build the family day elsewhere, to give the family the husband and father on Monday that the church had taken on Sunday. This is a kind of accounting, a recognition that the week has a rhythm and that Sunday's cost to the family must be repaid from the surrounding days, and the pastor who does not do this accounting, who lets Sunday cost the family and repays nothing, is running a deficit that compounds week after week into the depletion of the marriage.

There is a deeper Sunday wound that I want to name before I close this chapter, and it is the spiritual cost to the wife of watching her husband's faith become his job. For the

pastor, faith and vocation are fused, and Sunday is where the fusion is most complete, and the wife watches the man she loves turn the worship she longs to share with him into the work he is performing, and there is a loneliness in worshiping beside a husband who is working, in trying to meet God in a service that her husband is running, in longing for shared worship and receiving instead a shared workplace. Susanna sometimes grieved that she could not simply worship beside me as a fellow believer, that Sunday was my workplace and not our shared meeting with God, that the faith we shared had become, on its most public day, my profession. I did not know how to fully solve this, because Sunday is my work and cannot not be. But I learned to give her what I could, shared worship on other days, family devotions where I was not the professional but the husband and father seeking God alongside them, a faith we practiced together in the home that was not my job, so that she did not experience our entire shared spiritual life as something I was paid to perform. The Sundays cost her most, and the least I could do was to make sure that Sunday was not the whole of our life with God, that there were other days, other altars, where I came not as the pastor but as a fellow pilgrim seeking the same God beside the woman I loved.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

The Marriage as Your First Congregation

I HAVE CIRCLED THIS idea from many directions throughout the book, and now I want to make it central, because it is the truest reframe I know for the pastor who is trying to protect his marriage, and it changed everything in how I understood my own home. Your marriage is your first congregation. Your wife is the first member of the flock you are called to shepherd, and your home is the first parish God gave you, before he gave you the church with your name on the sign.

This is not a metaphor I am stretching for effect. It is, I have come to believe, a plain biblical truth that the ministry world has forgotten. When Paul lists the qualifications for an elder in his first letter to Timothy, he says that a man must manage his own household well, must care for his own family, and then he asks the pointed question, if someone does not know how to manage his own household, how will he care for God's church. The logic is unmistakable. The household is the proving ground and the training ground for the church, the

first and smaller congregation that demonstrates whether a man is fit to shepherd the larger one. Paul does not see the family as a distraction from ministry or even as merely the foundation of ministry. He sees the family as itself a ministry, a congregation, a flock the elder must shepherd, and the shepherding of that first small flock as the very qualification for shepherding the larger one. The pastor who shepherds the church and neglects the home has the order exactly backwards according to Paul, has skipped the first congregation to tend the second, has failed the qualifying flock while serving the qualified one.

When I began to think of Susanna and my sons as my first congregation, everything shifted. I had been treating my family as the people I served when the church did not need me, the recipients of my leftover time and energy and attention. But if my family is my first congregation, then they are not the recipients of my leftovers, they are the recipients of my first fruits, the flock I am most responsible to shepherd, the parish I will answer to God for most directly. I would never give the church with my name on the sign my leftover attention and call it ministry. I would never let the congregation go years without my real presence, my real shepherding, my real care, and tell myself I was being faithful. But I had done exactly that to my first congregation, to Susanna and the boys, had given them the leftovers I would never have dared give the church, and the reframe exposed the absurdity of it, the way I had been a faithful shepherd to the second flock and a negligent one to the first.

*Your wife is the first member of the
flock you are called to shepherd.*

WHAT DOES IT MEAN to shepherd your marriage as your first congregation. It means giving it the things you give the church, the attention, the care, the prayer, the time, the study, the presence, the willingness to be inconvenienced for its good. I prepared sermons for the church with great care, studying for hours to feed the congregation. Did I give any comparable care to feeding Susanna spiritually, to understanding her soul, to praying for her, to shepherding her walk with God. I visited the sick of the congregation faithfully. Was I present to Susanna in her own seasons of struggle with the same faithfulness. I prayed for the members of my church by name. Did I pray for my wife and sons with the same regularity and fervor. The reframe of the marriage as the first congregation exposes the disparity between the care I gave the second flock and the care I gave the first, and the disparity was an indictment, because the first flock had a prior claim and I had given it the lesser care.

There is a danger in this reframe that I must address, the danger of turning the marriage into a ministry in a way that makes the wife into a project rather than a partner, that puts the husband in the position of pastoring his wife in a way that is condescending or controlling. I do not mean that the husband should treat his wife as a congregant to be managed, that he should adopt a professional pastoral posture toward his own marriage, that he should be his wife's pastor in a way that places him over her spiritually as her superior. The

marriage is a partnership of equals before God, and the shepherding I am describing is not the shepherding of a superior over an inferior but the loving care of a husband for the soul of the one he loves, a mutual care in which the wife also shepherds the husband, a shared tending of each other's souls within the one-flesh union. The point of the reframe is not to make the husband his wife's pastor in a hierarchical sense but to make him take the spiritual care of his marriage as seriously as he takes the spiritual care of his church, to give his first congregation the attention and prayer and presence he gives his second, to stop treating his family as the recipients of his leftovers and start treating them as the flock he is most responsible for.

The reframe also changes how the pastor understands the relationship between his marriage and his ministry, because it dissolves the false competition between them. If the marriage is the first congregation and the church is the second, then tending the marriage is not stealing from the ministry, it is the most fundamental act of ministry, the shepherding of the first flock that qualifies the pastor for the second. The pastor who tends his marriage well is not a less devoted minister, he is a more qualified one, because he is doing the very thing Paul names as the qualification for ministry, managing his own household well. And the pastor who neglects his marriage to serve his church is not a more devoted minister, he is a disqualified one, a man who has failed the first test, who is tending the second flock while abandoning the first, who has no business shepherding God's church if he will not shepherd his own home. The reframe turns the protection of the marriage from a competitor with ministry into the foundation and qualification of ministry, so that the pastor no longer has to choose between being a good

husband and being a good minister, because being a good husband is part of being a good minister, is the first part, is the qualifying part, and the man who tends his first congregation well is on his way to being qualified to tend the second.

I came to this reframe late, but it became the organizing truth of my recovered life, the truth that let me protect my marriage without guilt, because I no longer saw the protection of my marriage as a withdrawal from ministry but as the most basic form of it. When I gave Susanna my first fruits instead of my leftovers, I was not failing my church, I was finally qualifying to lead it. When I shepherded my first congregation with the care I had been reserving for the second, I was not betraying the second, I was becoming the kind of man Paul says is fit to lead it. The marriage as the first congregation is the reframe that finally dissolved the war I had felt for years between my wife and my church, because it showed me that the war was a false one, that the God who called me to the church called me first to the marriage, and that tending the first flock well was not the enemy of tending the second but its foundation and its proof.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

Praying With the Woman You Have Wounded

THERE IS AN INTIMACY in prayer between a husband and wife that is deeper than any other, and there is a particular difficulty in that intimacy when the husband is the one who wounded the wife, when the man kneeling beside her to pray is the same man whose neglect she is still recovering from, and I want to write about that difficulty, because the prayer life of a wounded ministry marriage is its own hard and holy territory.

Praying together should be the most natural thing for a Christian couple, and for a ministry couple it should be doubly natural, because prayer is the pastor's trade, his daily work, the air he breathes professionally. And yet praying together is one of the things many ministry couples do least, and Susanna and I were among them for years, and I want to be honest about why, because the reasons are instructive. Part of it was simply the displacement of intimacy by activity

that I have described, the way prayer together, like everything unproductive and tender, got squeezed out by the busyness. But part of it was deeper and more painful, and it was this. Prayer together is a place of vulnerability, of being known before God by the person beside you, and a marriage that has been wounded is a marriage in which that vulnerability has become difficult, in which the woundedness makes the nakedness of shared prayer feel exposed and unsafe. Susanna and I struggled to pray together not only because we were busy but because we were wounded, because the intimacy of prayer required a closeness that my neglect had damaged, and you cannot easily be spiritually naked before someone you are guarding yourself against.

There is also a particular strangeness for the pastor in praying with his wife, because the pastor prays publicly, professionally, performatively, all day, and the prayer that is his trade can contaminate the prayer that should be his intimacy. I could pray a beautiful public prayer, a pastoral prayer, a prayer that moved a congregation, and I sometimes brought that same professional voice to prayer with Susanna, prayed at her rather than with her, performed a prayer rather than sharing one, and she could tell the difference, could feel when I was being the pastor rather than the husband, could hear the professional cadence where she longed for the vulnerable one. The pastor must learn to take off the professional voice when he prays with his wife, to pray not as the man who prays for a living but as a husband who needs God as desperately as she does, to be naked before God beside her rather than to lead her in a polished prayer that keeps his own soul safely covered. I had to learn to pray badly with Susanna, to pray haltingly, vulnerably, as a man and not a professional, because the polished prayer was a kind of

hiding and she needed the unpolished man.

*I could pray a beautiful public prayer,
and pray at my wife rather than with
her.*

THE HARDEST PRAYER, AND the most healing, was the prayer of confession together, the prayer in which I confessed my failures to God in Susanna's hearing, owned before God the very neglect I had committed against her, asked God's forgiveness for the wounds I had given the woman kneeling beside me. There is a power in this kind of prayer that ordinary apology does not have, because it brings the wound and the confession before God, places the marriage's pain in the presence of the One who heals, and lets the wife hear her husband own his sin not only to her but to God, which is a deeper owning, a more complete confession, a confession that cannot be a manipulation because it is made before the One who sees the heart. When I learned to confess my neglect of Susanna to God in her presence, to pray, before her, God forgive me for the years I gave her the husk, for the times I chose the church over her, for the wounds I gave the wife you gave me to cherish, something began to heal that my apologies to her alone had not healed, because the confession before God carried a weight and a reality that the confession to her alone had lacked.

Praying with a wounded spouse requires a particular patience, because the wounded spouse may not be able to pray freely at first, may guard herself in prayer as she guards

herself elsewhere, may not be able to be vulnerable before God beside the husband who wounded her until trust has been rebuilt. I had to accept that Susanna's prayers with me would be guarded for a season, that I could not demand the immediate intimacy of shared prayer from a woman I had taught not to be vulnerable with me, that the recovery of our prayer life would follow the recovery of our trust and not precede it. I could not use prayer as a shortcut to intimacy, could not bypass the rebuilding of trust by demanding spiritual closeness, because spiritual closeness is a form of intimacy and intimacy was exactly what my neglect had damaged. The prayer life of the marriage had to be rebuilt along with everything else, slowly, as trust returned, as the husband proved through changed behavior that the vulnerability of shared prayer would be safe, and the day Susanna could finally pray freely beside me again was a day that came late and came as a gift and could not have been rushed.

There is a great mercy in the fact that prayer is one of the means by which the wounded marriage heals, because it means the couple is not left to heal by their own resources, by their own willpower and technique, but can bring the marriage itself to God and ask him to do what they cannot do for themselves. I could not heal the wounds I had given Susanna by my own effort, could not rebuild by willpower the trust I had destroyed by neglect, could not generate by technique the intimacy my idolatry had displaced. But I could bring the broken marriage to God in prayer, could ask the God who heals to do the healing I could not do, could place the wounds and the failures and the slow rebuilding before the One who restores, and the prayer was not a substitute for the changed behavior, the changed behavior still had to come, but

the prayer was the acknowledgment that the changed behavior itself was a grace I needed God's help to produce, and the marriage's healing a work I needed God to do. The couple that prays together, even haltingly, even from inside the woundedness, is a couple that has acknowledged that their marriage is finally in God's hands and not their own, that they cannot save it by their own resources, that they need the God who instituted marriage in the garden to restore the one that ministry nearly destroyed, and that acknowledgment, made together on their knees, is itself a beginning of the healing it asks for.

CHAPTER THIRTY

The Vacation You Never Take and the Rest You Never Trust

BEYOND THE WEEKLY SABBATH there is a larger rhythm of rest that the ministry marriage needs and almost never gets, the rest of vacation, of extended time away, of the longer ceasing that lets a couple recover what the weekly Sabbath cannot fully restore, and the pastor's relationship to this larger rest is as broken as his relationship to the weekly one, and I want to examine it, because the vacation you never take is one more way the church consumes the marriage.

The pastor does not take vacation well. He resists it, postpones it, shortens it, interrupts it, and when he does take it he often takes his anxiety with him, lying on a beach somewhere with the church running continuously behind his eyes, physically away and mentally present at the congregation, which is not vacation at all but merely a more expensive location for the same restlessness. I was a terrible vacationer, and my terrible vacationing cost Susanna some of

the rest she most needed, because she needed extended time with a husband who was not working, not preoccupied, not anxious, and what she often got instead was a husband in a different location still tethered to the church by his phone and his mind, present in body and absent in attention, taking his idolatry on vacation with him. A vacation with a husband who cannot stop working is not rest for the wife, it is the same deprivation in a prettier setting, and Susanna sometimes returned from vacation more tired than she left, because the hope of vacation, of finally having me, had been raised and then disappointed by a husband who could not leave the church behind even at the ocean.

Why can the pastor not rest. The answer is the same idol I have named throughout this book, the idol of indispensability, the inability to believe that the church will survive without his anxious supervision, the conviction that his ceaseless attention is holding the whole thing together. The pastor cannot take a real vacation because a real vacation requires trusting the church to God for a sustained period, requires believing that the congregation belongs to Christ and not to him, requires the kind of rest from the work that is itself a confession of faith that God is sovereign over the church. And the pastor who cannot rest is a pastor confessing, with his restlessness, that he does not really believe God is sovereign over his church, that he believes his own effort is what sustains it, and that functional unbelief, that practical denial of God's sovereignty, is what keeps him from ever truly resting and keeps his marriage from ever receiving the extended rest it needs.

*A vacation with a husband who
cannot stop working is the same
deprivation in a prettier setting.*

THERE IS A THEOLOGY of rest that the pastor preaches and does not practice, and the gap between the preaching and the practice is nowhere wider than in the matter of vacation. I preached the Sabbath, preached rest, preached trust in God's provision, preached the freedom of the gospel from the tyranny of works, and then I lived a life of restless ceaseless labor that denied every word of it, a life that confessed I did not believe my own sermons, that I trusted my effort more than God's sovereignty, that I could not rest because I did not really believe the church was safe in God's hands. Susanna lived in the gap between my preaching and my practice, heard me preach rest and watched me refuse it, heard me preach trust and watched me live anxiety, and the gap was its own kind of wound, because a wife who watches her husband preach what he will not live learns to distrust both the preaching and the man. The pastor who will not rest is preaching a sermon with his restlessness that drowns out the sermon he preaches with his mouth, and his wife is in the front row hearing the louder one.

The recovery of rest, like the recovery of everything else in this book, runs through the death of the idol and the deepening of the gospel. I could not learn to rest by trying harder to relax, which is its own absurdity, the man straining to rest. I could only learn to rest as the idol of indispensability died, as I came to believe, more deeply than I had ever

believed it, that the church belonged to Christ and not to me, that it would survive without my supervision, that my worth did not depend on my ceaseless labor, that I could stop, could go away, could rest, because the One who never slumbers nor sleeps was keeping the church I had to put down. The deepest rest is theological before it is practical, it is the rest of a soul that has stopped trying to be God, that has handed the weight of the church back to the One whose church it is, that can finally cease because it no longer believes everything depends on its effort. And from that theological rest flows the practical rest, the vacation actually taken, the phone actually off, the mind actually present, the husband actually available to the wife who has been waiting for years to have him fully.

I want to make this concrete for the couple reading it, because the theology must become a practice or it changes nothing. Take the vacation. Take all of it, not a shortened version. Turn off the phone, or give it to someone else, or set genuine boundaries that let you actually leave the church behind. Tell the congregation you will be unavailable and mean it, and bear the guilt that comes, and recognize the guilt as the idol protesting its death. Give your wife not a husband in a different location still tethered to the church but a husband who has actually left the church behind, who is actually present, who is finally, for a sustained stretch, hers and not the congregation's. Susanna and I had to learn to take real rest together, extended rest, rest in which I was actually gone from the church, and the first time I managed it, the first vacation on which I was actually present rather than anxiously tethered, Susanna wept, because she had not had that version of me in years, had almost forgotten he existed, the husband who was not working, who was simply with her, who had finally trusted God enough to put the church down

and pick her up. The rest you never trust is a rest your marriage desperately needs, and the trusting of it, the real ceasing, the genuine leaving of the church in God's hands, is one of the great gifts a pastor can give his wife, the gift of himself, fully present, finally at rest, which she has been waiting for since the day the church first took him.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

When the Wife Loses Her Faith and the Pastor Cannot Fix It

THERE IS A CRISIS that visits some ministry marriages that almost no one talks about, a crisis so threatening to the pastor's whole world that he can barely allow himself to imagine it, and it is the crisis of the wife whose own faith falters, who comes to doubt, who grows weary of the church or of God himself, and who cannot say so because she is the pastor's wife, and the pastor cannot fix it because faith is not a thing that can be fixed by the man whose vocation depends on it.

I have to write about this carefully and with great tenderness, because it touches the deepest place, and because I have seen ministry marriages nearly destroyed by it, and because it can grow directly out of everything else this book has described. A wife who has been neglected by a husband consumed by the church, who has watched the church take everything and give nothing, who has carried the

invisible load and absorbed the criticism and lived in the fishbowl and disappeared into the role, may come, understandably, to a place of weariness with the whole enterprise, including God, may find her own faith strained by the very ministry that was supposed to be its expression. The neglect that wounds the marriage can wound the faith, because the wife experiences God, in part, through her experience of the church and of her husband's ministry, and if the church has been a thief and the ministry has been a rival and the husband has been absent in God's name, then God himself can become tangled up in the wound, can come to seem like the One in whose name she was abandoned.

This is a terrifying prospect for the pastor, and I want to name the terror honestly. The pastor's entire life is built on the faith, and a wife who falters in faith threatens not only his marriage but his vocation, his identity, his whole world, and the temptation, when the wife's faith falters, is to respond to the threat rather than to the wife, to try to fix her doubt because her doubt threatens him, to bring his professional spiritual resources to bear on her struggle as a problem to be solved rather than meeting her as a person to be loved. And this is exactly the wrong response, because the wife who is doubting does not need her husband to be her pastor, fixing her faith as a professional manages a problem, she needs her husband to be her husband, loving her through the doubt, staying with her in it, not abandoning her to fix her but remaining with her as she struggles. The pastor who responds to his wife's faltering faith by trying to fix it has made her doubt about himself, about the threat it poses to him, and a woman who senses that her doubt is being managed because it threatens her husband's vocation will close down further, will hide the doubt deeper, will become

more alone in it.

*The doubting wife does not need her
husband to be her pastor. She needs
him to be her husband.*

WHAT DOES THE PASTOR do when his wife's faith falters and he cannot fix it. The first thing is to refuse to panic, to refuse to treat her doubt as an emergency that threatens him, and instead to receive it as a real and human struggle that deserves his patience and his presence rather than his anxiety and his fixing. Doubt is not the opposite of faith, doubt is often a part of faith, a stage in faith, the dark night that the saints have always known, and a wife who is doubting is not necessarily a wife who is leaving God, she may be a wife whose faith is being refined in a fire, and the husband who can stay with her in the fire without panicking, without trying to pull her out before the refining is done, gives her something far more valuable than answers, he gives her the safety to doubt without being abandoned, which is exactly what doubt needs in order to find its way through to a deeper faith.

The second thing, and it is humbling, is for the pastor to examine his own role in his wife's faltering faith, to ask whether his neglect, his idolatry, his treating of the church as a rival, contributed to the weariness that strained her faith. If I have made the church a thief and the ministry a rival and lived my idolatry of indispensability in God's name, then I have given my wife reasons to be weary of God, have tangled

God up in the wound I gave her, and her faltering faith may be, in part, the fruit of my failure, the reasonable response of a woman who experienced God through a ministry that abandoned her. This is a hard thing for the pastor to consider, that his own failures may have damaged his wife's faith, but the considering of it is essential, because if his failures contributed to her struggle, then part of the healing of her faith is the healing of the marriage, the demonstration through changed behavior that the God she doubts is not the God in whose name she was abandoned, that the gospel produces a husband who turns back, who repents, who loves, who stays. The recovery of the wife's faith may run through the recovery of the marriage, because she may need to see the gospel actually work in her husband before she can believe it again herself.

There is a deep mercy in the recognition that the pastor cannot fix his wife's faith, because it frees him from a burden he was never meant to carry and returns the matter to God, where it belongs. I cannot give Susanna faith, cannot argue her into belief, cannot fix her doubt by my professional spiritual competence, and the recognition of my own helplessness here is itself a gift, because it casts both of us on God, the only One who can give and sustain faith, the only One who can meet her in the dark and lead her through. My job is not to fix her faith but to love her through whatever her faith is doing, to stay with her, to pray for her, to demonstrate the gospel by my changed life, to be a safe place for her doubt, and to trust the God who holds her faith even when it falters to do the work I cannot do. And there is a strange grace in a ministry marriage where the wife has doubted and the husband has had to learn that he cannot fix it, because it teaches the pastor, perhaps more deeply than anything else,

that faith is finally God's gift and not the pastor's product, that he cannot manufacture in the woman he loves most the very thing his vocation is built on, that he must depend on grace for his wife's soul as for his own, and that dependence, that helplessness, that casting of the most precious thing on God, is itself a form of faith, perhaps the truest form, the faith that trusts God with the soul of the one you love when you cannot save it yourself.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

The Comparison That Poisons, and the Couples You Envy

THERE IS A PARTICULAR poison that seeps into ministry marriages from a direction no one watches, and it is the poison of comparison, the comparing of your marriage to the marriages you see in the ministry world, the envying of the couples who seem to have what you do not, the slow corrosion of a marriage by the relentless measurement of it against others, and I want to name this poison because it nearly soured my gratitude for the very marriage I was trying to save.

The ministry world is full of marriages on display, and the displays are curated, polished, presented, the way all public marriages are presented, and the pastor and his wife look out at these displays and compare their real marriage, with all its wounds and struggles, to the curated marriages of others, and the comparison always loses, because a real marriage with its private struggles will always look worse than a curated marriage with its public polish. I would see other ministry

couples who seemed to have what Susanna and I lacked, the ease, the warmth, the obvious partnership, the marriage that seemed to flow effortlessly alongside a flourishing ministry, and I would compare our wounded and struggling marriage to their apparent ease and find ours wanting, and the comparison did several kinds of damage at once. It made me discontent with my own marriage, ungrateful for what we had, focused on what we lacked. It tempted me to resent Susanna for not being the wife those other wives appeared to be. And it blinded me to the reality that the curated marriages I envied were themselves, very likely, struggling in private exactly as we were, that the polish I was comparing our reality to was itself a performance, that I was measuring our backstage against everyone else's onstage and concluding that we alone were failing.

*I was measuring our backstage against
everyone else's onstage.*

THE COMPARISON IS ESPECIALLY poisonous in the age of the platform, when ministry marriages are not only displayed in the local context but broadcast widely, when the pastor and his wife can scroll through endless images of other ministry couples appearing to have the marriage and the ministry and the family all flourishing together, all radiant, all whole. The pastor scrolls through these images and compares his own struggling marriage to the curated radiance of strangers, and the comparison breeds a discontent that is entirely manufactured by the gap between everyone else's performance and his own reality. I have watched this

comparison sour ministry marriages, have felt it sour my own gratitude, have caught myself resenting Susanna for not matching some image of a ministry wife I had absorbed from the curated displays of others, and the resentment was entirely unjust, because I was resenting my real wife for not being a performance, was holding my actual marriage against an image that was itself not real, was poisoning the marriage I had with envy of marriages that very likely did not exist in the form I imagined them.

There is a deeper layer to the comparison poison, and it has to do with the way comparison is, at root, a failure to receive your own life as a gift. When I compared my marriage to others and found it wanting, I was refusing to receive Susanna, refusing to receive our particular marriage with its particular history and its particular wounds and its particular grace, as the specific gift God had given me, and was instead measuring it against a standard drawn from other lives and finding it deficient. But God did not give me a generic marriage to be measured against other marriages. He gave me Susanna, this specific woman, and this specific marriage, with its specific story, and the call is to love this marriage, to receive this gift, to be grateful for this woman, not to measure her against a curated image of someone else's wife. The comparison poison is a failure of gratitude, a refusal to receive the gift God actually gave in favor of envying the gift he gave someone else, and the antidote is the recovery of gratitude, the deliberate receiving of my own marriage as the specific and sufficient gift it is, the turning away from the curated displays of others toward the real and present woman God gave me to love.

I had to learn to stop comparing, and the learning was a

discipline, because the comparison is reflexive, automatic, constant, fed by a culture that displays marriages endlessly for comparison. I had to learn to turn away from the displays, to refuse the scrolling that fed the comparison, to discipline my eyes and my heart away from the curated marriages of others and toward the real marriage in my own home. And I had to learn to be grateful, deliberately, specifically, for Susanna, for the particular woman she is, for the particular marriage we have, wounds and all, history and all, struggle and all, because the gratitude was the antidote to the envy, the receiving of my own gift was the cure for the coveting of another's. The marriages I envied were not better than mine. They were either as struggling as mine behind the polish, or they were different gifts given to different people, and either way they were not mine to envy, and the energy I spent envying them was energy stolen from the loving of the marriage I actually had.

There is a freedom in the renunciation of comparison that I want to commend to every ministry couple, the freedom of finally receiving your own marriage as enough, as the gift it is, as the specific grace God gave you, without measuring it against the curated lives of others. When I stopped comparing my marriage to the displays of other ministry couples, I was finally free to love the marriage I had, to be grateful for Susanna as she is, to receive our particular story as the gift it is, and the gratitude transformed the marriage more than any technique could have, because a marriage received with gratitude is a different marriage than a marriage measured with envy, even if nothing about it has changed except the receiving. The couples you envy are a poison, not because they are doing anything to you, but because the envying of them is a refusal of your own gift, and

the cure is not to have a better marriage than theirs but to receive your own marriage as the sufficient grace it already is, to look away from the curated displays and toward the real woman beside you, and to be, at last, grateful, which is the beginning of all love and the end of all comparison.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

The Transition That Tests Everything

THERE COMES, IN MOST ministry lives, a transition, a moving from one church to another, a change of role, a leaving and a starting over, and these transitions test the marriage in particular ways that deserve their own examination, because the transition exposes whether the marriage is the stable center of the couple's life or whether it too has become subject to the upheavals of the vocation.

The ministry transition is uniquely disruptive because it is not merely a job change, it is the uprooting of an entire life. When a pastor moves churches, the family moves homes, the children change schools, the wife loses her community, the whole social world is dismantled and must be rebuilt from nothing in a new place where no one knows them. And the wife bears the heaviest cost of this disruption, because she is often the one most embedded in the community that is being left, the one who has built the friendships and the roots that the move tears up, the one who must rebuild the home and the children's stability in the new place while the husband

disappears into the demands of the new church. The transition that the pastor experiences as a new ministry opportunity the wife often experiences as a loss, the tearing up of a life she had built, and the pastor who does not understand this difference, who expects his wife to share his excitement about the new church while she is grieving the old community, adds a wound to the disruption, the wound of not being understood in her grief.

Susanna and I have known the disruption of transition, and I learned, not always in time, that the transition tested our marriage by revealing whether I would shepherd her through the upheaval or abandon her in it for the excitement of the new work. The temptation in transition is for the pastor to throw himself into the new church, to give the new congregation his energy and attention as he establishes himself, exactly when his wife most needs him present to help her rebuild the life that the move dismantled. The new church is demanding, the establishing of a new ministry is consuming, and the pastor can pour himself into it while his wife, alone in a new place with no community and a disrupted family, drowns in the work of rebuilding a life. The transition tests whether the pastor will see his wife's particular burden in the upheaval, will give her his presence in the disorienting season of starting over, or whether he will abandon her to the disruption while he chases the excitement of the new work, repeating in the new place the very neglect that wounded the marriage in the old.

*The transition I experienced as
opportunity, she often experienced as
loss.*

THERE IS A PARTICULAR loneliness for the wife in the transition season, because she has lost her old community and not yet built a new one, because she is in a strange place where no one knows her, because the roots she had are gone and the new roots have not yet grown. And the pastor, who has the built-in community of the new church, who is immediately embedded in a congregation that knows him and needs him, often does not understand the depth of his wife's loneliness in the new place, because his own loneliness is buffered by the instant community of the church while hers is total, the loneliness of a woman in a strange town with no one but a husband consumed by his new work. The pastor must understand that the transition is lonelier for his wife than for him, that he lands in a community and she lands in a void, and that his job in the transition is to be the community his wife has lost until she can build a new one, to be present to her in the void, to not add his absence to her loneliness in the very season when she has nothing else.

What does it look like to shepherd a wife through transition. It looks like slowing down the establishment of the new ministry enough to be present to her grief and her rebuilding, like refusing to let the demands of the new church consume the husband in exactly the season the wife most needs him, like understanding her grief over the old community rather than rushing her past it into excitement

about the new, like being patient with the disorientation and the loneliness and the loss that the transition costs her. It looks like making the marriage the stable center that the transition cannot disrupt, the one thing that does not change when everything else changes, the home that the couple carries with them through every upheaval. A marriage that is the stable center can survive any number of transitions, because the transitions disrupt everything around it but not it, but a marriage that is itself subject to the upheaval, that gets neglected in every transition as the pastor chases the new work, becomes one more casualty of the disruption, one more thing torn up in the move, and the couple arrives at the new place with their community lost and their marriage further wounded, having survived the transition with everything except the one thing that was supposed to survive it together.

The deepest lesson of transition is that the marriage must be the thing that does not move, the covenant that remains stable through every change of church and home and role, the one parish that travels with the pastor wherever he goes. The churches will change. The pastor may serve several congregations across a ministry life, may move many times, may transition through many roles. But the marriage is meant to be the constant, the first congregation that does not change pastors, the home that is carried from place to place, the covenant that remains while everything else turns over. And the pastor who understands this protects the marriage through every transition as the one stable thing, refuses to let it be disrupted by the upheavals that disrupt everything else, makes it the center that holds when the periphery is in chaos. Susanna and I learned, through our own transitions, to make our marriage the thing that did not move, the home we

carried with us, the covenant that survived every change, and the marriage that survives the transitions intact is a marriage that has discovered its own deepest nature, as the constant in a vocation of constant change, the one parish that travels, the first congregation that no transition can disband.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

The Anger She Was Not Allowed to Have

I HAVE WRITTEN ABOUT the things Susanna could not say, but there is one feeling in particular that the ministry wife is forbidden, that is spiritualized away before it can even be felt, and it is anger, and I want to write about the anger she was not allowed to have, because the forbidding of it is one of the deepest violences done to the ministry wife, and the recovery of her right to it was part of the healing of our marriage.

The ministry wife is, in many of our churches, denied anger almost entirely, because anger is read as a spiritual failure, as bitterness, as a lack of submission and grace, and the pastor's wife above all is expected to be gracious, gentle, content, free of the anger that would mark her as a difficult woman, an unsupportive wife, a poor reflection on her husband's ministry. And so when the ministry wife has reasons to be angry, and she has many, the anger of being neglected, the anger of carrying the invisible load alone, the anger of living in the fishbowl, the anger of being silenced and absorbed and used, she is not permitted to feel it, must

swallow it, must spiritualize it away, must convert her legitimate anger into a smiling contentment that the role demands, and the swallowed anger does not disappear, it goes underground, it festers, it turns into depression or numbness or a quiet hardening that no one can name because the anger that would explain it was never allowed to surface.

Susanna had anger she was not allowed to have, anger at the church that took her husband, anger at me for letting it, anger at the years of neglect and the invisible load and the silencing, and she was not permitted to feel that anger, by the role, by the theology, by me, and so she buried it, and the buried anger did its slow underground damage for years. And I participated in the forbidding of her anger, because her anger threatened me, was directed in part at me, and I did not want to receive it, did not want to acknowledge that she had every right to be angry at what I had done, and so I subtly spiritualized her anger away when it tried to surface, treated it as a spiritual problem in her rather than as the legitimate response to a real wound I had given, made her anger her failing rather than my fault, and in doing so I deepened the very wound the anger was responding to and added to it the wound of being denied the right to feel it.

*She had anger she was not allowed to
have, and I was part of what forbade it.*

THERE IS A THEOLOGY that makes this forbidding possible, and it is a distorted theology of submission and contentment that treats all anger as sin, that reads the wife's legitimate

anger as bitterness, that demands of her a contentment that is really a suppression, and I have been guilty of preaching versions of it. But the Scriptures themselves do not forbid all anger. The Psalms are full of anger, anger brought honestly to God, the anger of the wounded crying out, the anger of the betrayed naming the betrayal, and this anger is not treated as sin but as a legitimate part of the life of faith, a bringing of the real self with its real wounds before God rather than a suppression of them behind a false contentment. And there is a righteous anger, an anger at genuine wrong, that is not sin but the appropriate response to wrong, and the ministry wife who is angry at being neglected and used and silenced is not failing spiritually, she is responding rightly to a real wrong, and the forbidding of her anger is not the promotion of holiness but the suppression of a truthful response to a genuine injury.

The healing of our marriage required that I allow Susanna her anger, that I stop spiritualizing it away, that I receive it as the legitimate response to the wounds I had given rather than treating it as a spiritual failing in her. And this was hard, because her anger was directed at me, was the anger of a woman who had been neglected by her husband for years, and to receive it I had to stop defending myself, had to let her be angry at what I had actually done, had to validate rather than spiritualize the anger my own failures had earned. When Susanna was finally allowed to be angry, when I could receive her anger without defending myself or spiritualizing it away, something shifted, because the anger that had been buried for years could finally surface, could finally be spoken, could finally be received and acknowledged, and the acknowledging of it began to dissolve it, because anger that is received and validated can move through and be released,

while anger that is forbidden and buried only festers and hardens. The very thing I had feared, her anger, turned out to be a necessary part of the healing, because the buried anger had to come up before it could go away, and my receiving of it was the condition of its release.

I want to say to the pastor reading this that your wife may have anger she is not allowed to have, anger you have helped to forbid, anger at wounds you have given, and that the receiving of that anger, the permitting of it, the validating of it rather than the spiritualizing of it away, may be one of the most important and most difficult things you can do for your marriage. It will require you to stop defending yourself, to let her be angry at what you have actually done, to acknowledge that her anger is the legitimate response to real wounds and not a spiritual failing to be corrected. And it will require you to renounce the theology that forbids her anger, the distorted theology of contentment that demands she suppress a truthful response to a genuine injury, and to recover instead a theology that lets her bring her real anger to God and to you, honestly, as the Psalmists brought theirs. The anger she was not allowed to have is real, and the forbidding of it has done deep damage, and the permitting of it, the receiving of it, the validating of it, is part of the healing, because a marriage in which one partner is forbidden a legitimate feeling is a marriage with a wound that cannot close, and the closing of the wound begins when the forbidden anger is finally allowed to surface and be received by the husband who earned it.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

The Slow Return of Delight

AFTER THE CONFESSION AND the repentance, after the seeing and the receiving of anger, after the rebuilding of trust act by faithful act, there comes, if grace is at work, something I almost did not dare to hope for in the worst years, and it is the slow return of delight, the recovery not merely of a functioning marriage but of a marriage with joy in it, and I want to write about this return, because a book that ended with mere repair would be untrue to what I have actually experienced.

Delight is the thing that goes first and returns last in a wounded marriage. The function returns before the delight, the partnership before the pleasure, the working-together before the enjoying-each-other, and a couple can have a functioning marriage, a marriage that operates, that coordinates, that no longer wounds, long before they have a marriage that delights, that takes pleasure in itself, that enjoys the simple presence of the other. Susanna and I recovered function before we recovered delight, learned to

work together again before we learned to enjoy each other again, and there was a season in between, a season of repaired but not yet joyful marriage, in which I wondered whether the delight would ever return, whether the wounds had taken something that could be repaired but not restored, whether we would have a working marriage without the joy that had been displaced by all the years of activity and neglect.

But the delight did return, slowly, in small recoveries, in moments that surprised me, in the gradual reappearance of the pleasure we had lost. It returned in laughter, in the recovery of the ability to laugh together that the heavy years had taken, in the small jokes that began to surface again as the heaviness lifted. It returned in conversation, in the slow reappearance of the unproductive talk that has no agenda, the lingering over coffee, the conversations that go nowhere and are the substance of intimacy. It returned in the physical relationship, as trust rebuilt and the body relearned what the heart had relearned. And it returned in a thousand small ordinary moments that I had stopped noticing in the years of activity, the simple pleasure of Susanna's presence, the delight of being known by her, the joy of a shared life that I had been too busy and too distracted to enjoy for years.

*The function returns before the delight,
the partnership before the pleasure.*

THE RETURN OF DELIGHT cannot be manufactured, and this is important, because the doing-based heart of the pastor wants to produce the delight by effort, wants to schedule it

and engineer it and make it happen. But delight is not made, it is received, it grows in the soil of a marriage that has been tended and trusted and made safe again, it returns as the fruit of the faithfulness rather than as a thing the faithfulness can directly produce. I could not make Susanna delight in me again, could not engineer the return of joy, could only tend the marriage faithfully, rebuild the trust, make it safe, be present, and wait, and receive the delight as it slowly returned, as a gift and not an achievement. The return of delight followed the rebuilding of trust the way fruit follows the patient tending of a tree, not as a thing the gardener makes but as a thing the gardener prepares the soil for and then receives in its season.

There is a particular sweetness to delight recovered that delight never lost would not have, and I want to name it, because it is one of the strange mercies of a redeemed marriage. A couple whose delight has never been threatened takes it for granted, holds it lightly, does not know its value because they have never lost it. But a couple who lost their delight and slowly recovered it holds it as the precious and fragile thing it is, treasures it, does not take it for granted, because they know now how easily it can be lost and how hard it is to recover. The delight Susanna and I have now is sweeter for having been lost, more treasured for having been recovered, held more carefully for our knowing how nearly we lost it forever. The marriage that ministry nearly destroyed has a delight in it now that I do not think it would have had if it had never been threatened, because the delight is the delight of a thing recovered from the edge of loss, and a thing recovered from the edge of loss is dearer than a thing that was never at risk.

I do not want to oversell this, because the delight is not constant and the marriage is not perfect and the wounds have left tenderness that remains. There are still hard days, still moments when the old patterns threaten, still the ongoing work of a marriage that is healed but not invulnerable. But the delight has returned, really returned, and its return is the thing I most want the despairing reader to hear, the pastor or the wife who is in the worst of it, who cannot imagine that joy will ever return to a marriage this wounded. It can return. It did return for us. The God who instituted marriage as a delight in the garden is in the business of restoring delight to marriages that have lost it, and the slow return of joy to a marriage that ministry nearly destroyed is one of the truest gospels I know, the gospel of a God who does not merely repair what was broken but restores what was lost, who gives back the delight that the years of neglect displaced, who takes a marriage that had become a partnership of logistics and makes it, again, a delight, a pleasure, a joy, the thing it was created to be in the garden before any of us learned to neglect the very gift God gave us to enjoy.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

What I Would Tell the Young Pastor at His Wedding

IF I COULD STAND at the wedding of a young pastor, or a young man who will become one, and say to him the things I most wish someone had said to me before I learned them at such cost, I would set aside the usual wedding sentiments and tell him the truths that took me decades and nearly a marriage to learn, and I want to write that wedding charge here, because the young pastor reading this still has time to avoid the worst of what I did not avoid.

I would tell him, first, that the woman standing beside him is his first congregation, and that he must shepherd her before and beneath all his shepherding of any church, and that on the day he stands before a congregation and neglects her to serve them, he will have failed at the very ministry that qualifies him for the other. I would tell him that the vows he is making to her this day take precedence over the ordination vows he has made or will make, that the covenant of marriage

was instituted in the garden before the church existed, that holding fast to his wife is the creation ordinance and the prior command, and that no demand of any church, however urgent, however clothed in the language of the kingdom, can override the command of God to cleave to the woman beside him. I would tell him that the church will demand everything, that this is not a flaw in the church but the nature of a living congregation, and that he must decide now, on his wedding day, before the demands begin, what he will not give, because the demands will come and he will not have the strength to refuse them in the moment if he has not decided in advance.

I would tell him to watch his calendar, because the calendar is a confession of faith, and to enter his wife first and defend her time the way he will defend the church's time, to build the church around the marriage rather than squeezing the marriage into the gaps the church leaves. I would tell him to take a Sabbath and guard it, to disappoint the church for the sake of the covenant on one day every week, to take his vacations fully and leave the church behind, to build white space into his life as a confession that the church belongs to Christ and not to him. I would tell him to learn the word no, and to understand that his inability to say it will not be generosity but idolatry, the worship of his own indispensability, the using of the church to feed his need to be needed at the cost of the woman he is marrying today.

*The vows you make to her today take
precedence over the ordination vows
you will make.*

I WOULD TELL HIM about the things he cannot yet imagine, because he is young and in love and cannot conceive that this radiant day could lead to the wounds I am warning him against. I would tell him about the fishbowl, that the woman beside him is being ordained today without anyone laying hands on her, that she is entering a public office with no salary and no recognition, and that he must protect her from the eyes, must build a private life the congregation does not own, must stand between her and the watching when the watching becomes a weight. I would tell him about the invisible load she will carry, the labor no one will see or thank, and that he must see it and name it and pick it up with his own hands rather than admiring her strength while it covers for his neglect. I would tell him about the silencing, that the structure he is entering will make her honesty dangerous, and that he must work to keep honesty safe, must receive her hard truths without defending himself, must never make her honesty about him.

I would tell him about the mind that never leaves the church, the absence inside the presence, and that the great danger is not that he will be away too much but that he will be home and not home, present in body and absent in attention, and that he must fight to be present, must learn to set the church down at the threshold, must give her not just his location but his mind. I would tell him about the displacement of intimacy by activity, that the marriage will slowly become a logistics company if he lets it, and that he must protect the unproductive hours, the slow useless lingering that is the actual substance of married love. I would tell him about the criticism that will follow him home and that he must not unload it on her or shut her out of it but find the narrow path between, taking the processing of it elsewhere

while letting her in on the fact of it.

I would tell him, above all, that he will fail, that despite every warning he will fail her in ways he cannot yet imagine, that he is not strong enough or wise enough to avoid all of this by willpower, and that his hope is not in his own resolve but in the grace of God, the same grace that met me at the bottom of my failure and began, slowly, to restore what I had broken. I would tell him that when he fails, and he will, his repentance must be more than words, must change his calendar and his choices and his life and not merely his feelings, and that he must cast himself on the grace that can change him because he cannot change himself. And I would tell him that there is hope, real hope, that even a marriage badly wounded by ministry can be healed, that the God who instituted marriage in the garden is in the business of restoring it, that the delight can return, that the worst is not inevitable and the wounds are not final, and that the same gospel he will preach to his congregation is the gospel that can save his marriage, if he will believe it enough to let it govern the way he treats the woman standing beside him today. That is the charge I would give the young pastor at his wedding, the charge no one gave me, the charge I learned at the cost of years I cannot get back, and I give it now to whatever young pastor is reading this with his marriage still ahead of him, in the hope that he will learn from my confession what I had to learn from my failure.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

The Witness of a Healed Marriage

I HAVE WRITTEN THIS book as a confession and a warning, but there is a final dimension I have not yet developed, and it is the dimension of witness, the way a healed ministry marriage becomes itself a proclamation of the gospel, a sermon more powerful than any preached from a pulpit, and I want to develop it now, because it changes the whole meaning of the work of protecting the covenant.

The watching world, and especially the skeptic, the hardest case, the one I most want to reach, does not finally believe the gospel because of arguments, though arguments have their place. The skeptic believes, when he believes at all, because he sees the gospel produce something, sees it change a life, sees it do in a human being or a human relationship what nothing else could do, and the skeptic watches the pastor's marriage with a particular attention, because the pastor is the professional Christian, the man who proclaims the gospel for a living, and if the gospel cannot produce love in his marriage, the skeptic concludes, rightly,

that the proclamation is empty. The pastor's marriage is one of the most closely watched arguments for or against the gospel in the eyes of the watching world, and a pastor whose marriage is cold and functional and joyless is preaching, in a language louder than his sermons, that the gospel does not work, that the man who proclaims Christ's sacrificial love for the church does not himself love his own bride, and the contradiction undermines everything he says.

But a healed marriage preaches the opposite, and it preaches it with a power that no sermon can match. A marriage that was wounded and is being restored, a husband who failed and repented and turned back, a love that was nearly lost and was recovered by grace, is a living demonstration that the gospel does what it claims, that it produces love, that it heals what is broken, that it restores what was lost, and the watching world reads this demonstration more carefully than it reads any sermon. When the skeptic sees a pastor who genuinely loves his wife, who has clearly turned back from failure, whose marriage has a delight in it that has obviously been recovered from the edge of loss, he sees an argument for the gospel that he cannot easily dismiss, because it is not an argument made of words but of a life, a relationship, a love that the gospel evidently produced. The healed marriage is apologetics, is evidence, is the gospel made visible, and the pastor who protects and heals his marriage is not withdrawing from his ministry but engaging in its most powerful form, the form that proclaims the gospel not in words the skeptic can dismiss but in a love he cannot.

*The pastor's marriage is one of the
most closely watched arguments for or
against the gospel.*

THIS REFRAMES THE ENTIRE project of protecting the covenant. I have written throughout this book as though protecting the marriage were in tension with serving the church, as though the pastor had to choose between them, and at the level of the daily collision of demands that tension is real and the choice must often be made. But at a deeper level there is no tension at all, because the healed marriage is itself the most powerful ministry the pastor has, the clearest proclamation of the gospel he will ever make, and so protecting the marriage is not stealing from the ministry but engaging in its highest form. The pastor who heals his marriage is not a less effective minister but a more effective one, because his healed marriage preaches the gospel to the watching world with a power his sermons alone could never have, demonstrates in a love the skeptic cannot dismiss that the gospel does what it claims. The protection of the covenant turns out to be, in the end, one of the great works of ministry, not its rival.

There is a particular witness that the healed marriage offers to other ministry couples, and it is the witness of hope, the demonstration that the worst is not inevitable and the wounds are not final. The ministry world is full of marriages in trouble, full of pastors neglecting their wives in God's name and wives quietly dying in the role, and these couples need to see that there is hope, that a marriage badly wounded by

ministry can be healed, that the patterns can be broken, that the delight can return. Susanna and I have become, in our healed and still-healing marriage, a witness to other ministry couples that the worst is not the end, that grace can restore what neglect nearly destroyed, and that witness is one of the most valuable ministries we have, because it offers hope to couples who can imagine no way out of the very trap we were caught in. The healed marriage preaches to the wounded marriage that healing is possible, and that preaching, offered not from a pulpit but from a recovered life, reaches places that no sermon can reach.

I want to close this chapter by saying that the witness of a healed marriage is not the witness of a perfect marriage, and this matters, because a perfect marriage, if such a thing existed, would witness only to the couple's success and not to God's grace. The marriage that witnesses most powerfully to the gospel is not the marriage that never failed but the marriage that failed and was redeemed, because it is the redemption that displays the gospel, the grace that meets the failure that proclaims the God who restores. Susanna and I do not witness to the gospel by having a flawless marriage. We witness to it by having a marriage that was nearly destroyed and was rescued, a husband who failed and was forgiven, a love that was lost and was recovered, because that story is the gospel story, the story of grace meeting failure and restoring what was broken, and a marriage that lives that story preaches the gospel more powerfully than a marriage that never needed grace ever could. The witness of a healed marriage is the witness of redemption, and redemption is the heart of the gospel, and the pastor whose marriage displays redemption is preaching the truest sermon of his life, the sermon of a God who restores, written not in words but in a

love recovered from the edge of loss.

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

The Daily Disciplines That Hold a Covenant

I HAVE WRITTEN MUCH about theology and confession and the deep work of the heart, and I do not want to end without coming down to the level of the daily, the ordinary, the practical, because a covenant is not finally held by grand insights but by small disciplines repeated over years, and the ministry marriage that survives is the one held together by a thousand small faithfulnesses that no one sees.

The first discipline is the daily turning toward, the small repeated act of choosing presence over absence in the ordinary moments, and it is more important than any grand gesture. A marriage is not held together by the anniversary trip or the dramatic recommitment but by the daily ten minutes of real attention, the conversation at the end of the day in which the husband is actually present, the question asked and the answer actually heard, the small repeated turning toward the wife rather than toward the phone or the next task or the church behind the eyes. Susanna and I learned that the marriage was held not by the big things but

by the small daily turnings, the ordinary moments in which I chose, again, to be present, to attend, to turn toward her rather than away, and the accumulation of these small turnings over years is what actually holds a covenant, far more than any grand gesture that compensates for daily absence. The pastor who gives his wife a dramatic anniversary and daily neglect has the proportions exactly wrong, because the marriage lives in the daily, not the dramatic, and the daily turning toward is the discipline that holds it.

The second discipline is the guarding of the protected times, the Sabbath and the evenings and the dates, the deliberate carving out and defending of time against the church that wants to consume it. I have written about these, but I name them here as daily and weekly disciplines, things that must be done repeatedly, defended repeatedly, chosen repeatedly against the constant pressure to surrender them. The protected times are not protected once, they are protected every week, against every new demand, and the discipline of guarding them is a discipline that never ends, because the church's hunger never ends, and the moment the pastor stops guarding the protected times they will be consumed. The marriage is held together by the weekly discipline of guarding the Sabbath, the daily discipline of guarding the evening, the regular discipline of the date that is defended against the church's claims, and these disciplines must be repeated forever, because the pressure they resist is forever.

*A covenant is held not by grand
insights but by small disciplines
repeated over years.*

THE THIRD DISCIPLINE IS the practice of confession and forgiveness, the daily keeping of short accounts, the refusal to let wounds accumulate unaddressed. A marriage accumulates small wounds daily, small failures, small neglects, small irritations, and a marriage in which these are not regularly confessed and forgiven becomes a marriage in which they accumulate into a wall, and the discipline that prevents the wall is the daily practice of confession and forgiveness, the keeping of short accounts, the addressing of the small wounds before they harden. Susanna and I learned to confess and forgive daily, to address the small failures before they accumulated, to keep short accounts so that the wounds did not pile up into the wall that nearly divided us in the worst years. This is a discipline, a practice, a daily turning toward each other in honesty and grace, and it holds the covenant by preventing the accumulation of unaddressed wounds that would otherwise harden into distance.

The fourth discipline is the practice of prayer together, the bringing of the marriage to God daily or regularly, the shared seeking of the God who instituted the covenant and sustains it. I have written about the difficulty of prayer in a wounded marriage, but I name it here as a discipline that holds the covenant, the regular practice of praying together, of bringing the marriage and its struggles and its joys before God, of acknowledging together that the marriage is finally in God's

hands and depends on his grace. The couple that prays together regularly is a couple that has built into their daily life the acknowledgment that they cannot hold the covenant by their own resources, that they need the God who instituted it to sustain it, and that acknowledgment, made regularly in shared prayer, is itself a discipline that holds the marriage by keeping it dependent on the grace that alone can keep it.

The fifth discipline, and the one that undergirds all the others, is the daily preaching of the gospel to oneself, the regular returning to the finished work of Christ, the daily relocating of one's worth from the church to the Savior, because all the other disciplines flow from this one and fail without it. The daily turning toward, the guarding of protected times, the confession and forgiveness, the prayer together, all of these depend on a heart that has been freed by the gospel from the idolatry of indispensability, from the location of worth in the church's approval, from the doing-based striving that displaces intimacy with activity. And that freedom is not won once but maintained daily, by the daily preaching of the gospel to oneself, the daily returning to the truth that one is already loved, already approved, already significant in Christ, so that one no longer needs the church's need to feel valuable and is therefore free to turn toward one's wife, to guard the protected times, to confess and forgive, to pray. The daily preaching of the gospel to oneself is the discipline beneath the disciplines, the practice that makes the other practices possible, and the pastor who neglects it will find all the other disciplines failing, because they flow from the freedom that the gospel gives and that must be renewed daily against the constant pull of the idolatry that displaced the marriage in the first place.

These disciplines are not glamorous, and that is the point,

because a covenant is held by the unglamorous, the daily, the repeated, the small faithfulnesses that no one sees and no one applauds. The marriage that survives ministry is not the marriage held together by grand gestures but the marriage held together by the daily turning toward, the weekly guarding of protected times, the regular confession and forgiveness, the shared prayer, and the daily preaching of the gospel to oneself, repeated over years, in season and out, through every pressure the church brings. Susanna and I hold our recovered marriage by these daily disciplines, and we will hold it by them for the rest of our lives, because the pressures that nearly destroyed it have not gone away and the disciplines that protect it must be repeated forever. The covenant is held by the daily, and the pastor who wants to protect his marriage must commit not to a grand gesture but to a lifetime of small faithfulnesses, repeated day after day, that hold the covenant against the church that would consume it, one ordinary faithful day at a time.

CHAPTER THIRTY-NINE

To the Wife Who Is Reading This

I HAVE WRITTEN MOST of this book to the pastor, because the pastor is most often the one whose failures wound the ministry marriage, and because I am a pastor and can speak most honestly from inside my own failure. But I know that wives are reading this too, ministry wives carrying the very burdens I have been describing, and I cannot end without turning to them, because much of this book has been about the wounds done to them, and a book that names a person's wounds without speaking to her directly has not finished its work.

To the wife who is reading this, I want to say first that I see you, or at least I have tried to see, through the seeing of Susanna that came too late, what you carry. I have tried to name the invisible load, the silencing, the fishbowl, the loneliness, the anger you are not allowed to have, the absorption of your identity into a role you never chose, the years of being given the husk while the church got your husband. I have tried to name these honestly, not to stir up

bitterness, but because I believe that the naming of a wound is the beginning of its healing, and that you have carried these wounds in silence for too long, often without anyone naming them, often half-believing that your exhaustion and your grief and your anger were your own spiritual failures rather than the legitimate response to real injuries. They are not your spiritual failures. They are the real cost of a real situation, and you are allowed to feel them, and the feeling of them is not a lack of faith but an honest response to a genuine burden.

I want to say to you that your worth is not in the role. The church may have absorbed you into the role of pastor's wife, may relate to you only as a function of your husband's office, may have forgotten that you are a person, and your husband may have participated in the forgetting. But you are a person, made in the image of God, loved by God for your own sake, called by God to your own purposes, a soul of infinite worth whose value does not depend on being the perfect pastor's wife or on supporting your husband's ministry or on carrying the load gracefully. You are not a function of his office. You are a woman before God, and your relationship with God is your own, not a department of your husband's ministry, and the recovery of yourself as a person, with your own walk and your own gifts and your own calling, is not a betrayal of your husband's ministry but the recovery of the image of God in you that the role has been flattening.

*Your worth is not in the role. You are a
woman before God, and that
relationship is your own.*

I WANT TO SAY to you that you are allowed to be honest, that the structure which has made your honesty dangerous is not the voice of God, that the God who made you does not require you to swallow your true feelings to protect your husband's standing. Your honesty about the cost of ministry, your anger at the years of neglect, your weariness with the church that has taken so much, these are not rebellions against God, they are the truthful response of a wounded person, and the God of the Psalms welcomes the truthful cry of the wounded. You do not have to keep performing a contentment you do not feel. You are allowed to bring your real self, with its real wounds and its real anger, before God and before your husband, and a husband who cannot receive your honest pain has a problem that is his and not yours, and you are not required to suppress what is true in you to manage his defensiveness.

And I want to say to you, gently, that there is hope, even if your situation is as hard as Susanna's was in the worst years, even if you cannot imagine your husband changing, even if you have given up on the eloquent confessions that change nothing. I cannot promise you that your husband will change, because I cannot speak for him, and the changing of him is finally between him and God. But I can tell you that change is possible, that Susanna lived for years married to a man she had every reason to believe would never change, and that

man did change, slowly, by grace, and the marriage she had nearly given up on was restored. I do not tell you this to burden you with the responsibility for fixing your husband, which is not yours and never was, but to offer you the hope that the worst is not necessarily the end, that grace can reach even the most idolatrous pastor, that the God who restores is at work even in the marriages that seem most lost. Your hope is not finally in your husband's change but in the God who can change him, and even if he does not change, that God is your refuge, your portion, the One who sees what no one else sees and loves you with a love that does not depend on your husband's attention.

I want to say, finally, that you are not alone, even though the loneliness of the ministry wife is real and deep and largely invisible. There is a God who sees you, who has counted every burden you have carried in silence, who knows the cost of the years you have given, who has not forgotten you the way the church forgot to thank you, who holds your invisible load in his own hands and will not let it be forgotten. And there are other women who understand, other ministry wives carrying the same burdens, and the building of friendship with them, the breaking of the isolation, the finding of others who know, is one of the great mercies available to you. You do not have to carry this alone. You were never meant to. The God who made you made you for community, and the recovery of community, of friendship, of others who see and understand, is part of the lifting of the load that the role has made so heavy. You are seen. You are loved. Your worth is not in the role. And there is hope, even now, even in the hardest place, because the God who instituted marriage in the garden has not abandoned the marriages that ministry has wounded, and he has not

TO THE WIFE WHO IS READING THIS

abandoned you.

CHAPTER FORTY

The Ministry That Flows From a Tended Marriage

I HAVE SPENT THIS book naming the war between the marriage and the church, the way the congregation becomes the rival, the demands that consume the covenant, and all of that is true and had to be said. But I do not want to leave the impression that the marriage and the ministry are permanent enemies, that the pastor must choose between a good marriage and a fruitful ministry, because the deepest truth I have learned is the opposite, that the most fruitful ministry flows from a tended marriage, that the protection of the covenant is not the enemy of the work but its source.

For years I believed, in practice if not in theory, that my ministry and my marriage were in a zero-sum competition, that every hour given to one was an hour stolen from the other, that I could have a flourishing ministry or a flourishing marriage but not both, and that faithfulness required sacrificing the marriage to the ministry. And the strange

thing I discovered, when I finally began to tend the marriage, was that my ministry did not suffer, it deepened, because the ministry that flows from a tended marriage is a different and better ministry than the ministry that flows from a neglected one. The man who is tending his marriage, who is rooted in a healthy covenant, who is loved and known at home, who has dealt with his idolatry of indispensability, brings to his ministry a wholeness, a freedom, a non-anxious presence that the depleted, idolatrous, marriage-neglecting pastor cannot bring. I was a worse pastor when I was neglecting my marriage than I became when I tended it, because the neglecting flowed from the same idolatry that distorted my whole ministry, and the tending flowed from the same gospel-rooted freedom that healed it.

The pastor who neglects his marriage to serve the church is not actually serving the church better, he is serving it worse, because he is serving it out of a depleted and idolatrous heart, out of a need to be needed, out of a striving for significance, and the ministry that flows from that heart is distorted by the very idolatry that drives the neglect. The congregation served by a pastor neglecting his marriage is being served by a man who is using them to feed his own idol, who needs their need, who cannot say no, who has made them the source of his worth, and that man's ministry, however busy and impressive, is built over the fault line of his idolatry and his neglected marriage, and it will eventually crack. The congregation served by a pastor who tends his marriage is being served by a man who is free, who does not need their need, who serves them out of fullness rather than emptiness, whose ministry flows from a heart at rest in the gospel rather than striving for significance, and that man's ministry is built on a solid foundation and can last.

*The most fruitful ministry flows from
a tended marriage, not from a
sacrificed one.*

THERE IS A FREEDOM in the pastor who has tended his marriage that transforms his entire ministry, and it is the freedom of a man who is not serving the church to meet his own needs, who is not using the congregation to feel valuable, who can therefore love them rather than need them, can serve them rather than feed on them, can lead them rather than be enslaved to their approval. This freedom is the fruit of the same work that heals the marriage, the death of the idol of indispensability, the relocating of worth from the church to Christ, the recovery of the gospel-rooted rest that lets a man stop striving for significance, and it heals the ministry at the same time that it heals the marriage, because the marriage and the ministry were both distorted by the same idolatry, and the healing of the idolatry heals them both. The tended marriage and the freed ministry are not in competition, they are two fruits of the same gospel, two results of the same death of the idol, and the pastor who tends his marriage finds that his ministry is freed by the very work that heals his home.

I want to be careful and not promise that tending the marriage will make the ministry easier or more successful in worldly terms, because that would be its own subtle idolatry, the using of the marriage to improve the ministry, which inverts everything I have been saying. The marriage is not finally a means to a better ministry, it is an end in itself, a

covenant to be cherished for its own sake, a gospel proclamation in its own right, and to tend it merely in order to improve the ministry would be to commit the very instrumentalizing I warned against in the chapter on the marriage as a ministry brand. I tend my marriage because Susanna is worth tending, because the covenant is worth protecting, because God commands me to hold fast to my wife, not because it will make me a more successful pastor. But the fact remains, as a kind of grace, that the tending of the marriage for its own sake also frees the ministry, that the two flourish together when both flow from a heart freed by the gospel, and that the pastor who tends his marriage finds, often to his surprise, that his ministry is healthier too, not because he tended the marriage to help the ministry, but because the same gospel-rooted freedom that lets him tend the marriage also frees the ministry from the idolatry that was distorting it.

So I want to release the pastor reading this from the false choice that haunted me for years, the choice between a good marriage and a fruitful ministry, because it is a false choice, a lie of the theology of the cause, a distortion that flows from the very idolatry that wounds both the marriage and the ministry. You do not have to choose between tending your marriage and serving your church, because the tended marriage is the source of the truest service, the foundation of the freest ministry, the fault line repaired beneath the whole work. Tend your marriage, for its own sake, because your wife is worth it and the covenant is worth it and God commands it, and discover, as I discovered, that the ministry that flows from a tended marriage is deeper and freer and more lasting than the ministry that flows from a sacrificed one, because both finally flow from the same heart, and a heart freed by the

gospel to love its wife is a heart freed by the gospel to serve its church, and the war between them was never real, it was only the shadow cast by an idolatry that the gospel came to kill.

CHAPTER FORTY-ONE

The Long Obedience of Staying

EUGENE PETERSON TOOK A phrase from Nietzsche, of all people, and made it the title of a book in 1980, a long obedience in the same direction, and he meant it as a description of the Christian life against the impatience and the spectacle of the age. I want to take the phrase and apply it to marriage, because the protection of a covenant is, in the end, a long obedience in the same direction, the unspectacular faithfulness of staying, of turning back, of choosing again, day after day, year after year, the same person, the same covenant, against every pressure to drift.

The ministry marriage is tested not finally by the dramatic crisis but by the long erosion, the slow drift, the years of accumulating neglect that wear it down a grain at a time. And the protection of it is therefore not finally a dramatic rescue but a long obedience, the unspectacular discipline of staying, of returning, of choosing the covenant again and again across decades, through the changing seasons and the shifting pressures and the wounds given and forgiven. Susanna and I

did not save our marriage in a single dramatic moment of recommitment, though there were such moments. We saved it, by grace, in the long obedience of staying, the years of turning back toward each other, the daily disciplines repeated, the slow rebuilding act by faithful act, the unglamorous persistence of two people who kept choosing the covenant when it would have been easier to drift. The long obedience of staying is the truest form of the protection of the covenant, more important than any insight or technique, because the covenant is finally held not by what you understand but by your willingness to stay, to keep turning back, to choose again.

*The covenant is held not by what you
understand but by your willingness to
keep turning back.*

THERE IS A CULTURAL lie that works against the long obedience, and it is the lie that love is a feeling that comes and goes and that a marriage which has lost the feeling has lost the love and should be released. The ministry world is not immune to this lie, and the pastor whose marriage has gone cold can be tempted by it, can come to believe that the loss of feeling means the death of love, can be drawn toward the exit by the conviction that a loveless marriage is no marriage. But the long obedience of staying knows a deeper truth, that love is finally not a feeling but a covenant, a commitment that holds when the feeling fails, a fidelity that persists through the seasons when the delight is gone, and

that the feeling, the delight, returns to those who stay, who keep the covenant when the feeling has failed, who practice the long obedience until the delight grows back in the soil of the faithfulness. Susanna and I lost the feeling in the worst years, and if we had believed the lie that the loss of feeling was the death of love, we would have released a marriage that grace was about to restore. We stayed, in the long obedience, through the seasons when the feeling was gone, and the feeling returned, the delight grew back, because we had stayed long enough for the restoration to come.

The long obedience of staying is itself a proclamation of the gospel, because it images the faithfulness of God, the God who keeps covenant when his people break it, who stays when they wander, who does not release the covenant when the feeling fails but holds it through every season of his people's unfaithfulness. The whole story of Scripture is the story of a God in a long obedience toward an unfaithful people, a God who stays, who keeps turning back toward the bride who keeps wandering, who holds the covenant against every reason to release it, and the marriage that practices the long obedience of staying images that divine faithfulness, proclaims with its persistence the God who does not let go. When Hosea was commanded to stay with his unfaithful wife, to keep loving her, to keep turning back toward her, he was commanded to image the staying of God, and the ministry marriage that practices the long obedience of staying preaches the same sermon, the sermon of a faithfulness that does not release the covenant when the feeling fails or the season darkens, a faithfulness that stays, that holds, that keeps turning back, because that is what God does, and the marriage that images God's staying preaches God's gospel.

I am still in the long obedience, and so is Susanna, because the long obedience does not end, it continues for the whole of a marriage, the lifelong discipline of staying and turning back and choosing again. We have not arrived. We are not finished. The marriage is not a problem we solved but a covenant we keep, day after day, in the long obedience that has no end this side of death. And I have come to see the long obedience not as a burden but as a grace, because it is in the long obedience, in the staying and the turning back and the choosing again, that the marriage becomes what God designed it to be, a school of fidelity, a training ground in the faithfulness of God, a covenant that teaches two people, over a lifetime, how to love the way God loves, with a love that stays. The protection of the covenant, in the end, is the long obedience of staying, and I commend it to every ministry couple, not as a heroic achievement but as a daily grace, the unspectacular faithfulness of two people who keep turning back toward each other and toward the God who taught them how to stay.

CHAPTER FORTY-TWO

The Things I Cannot Get Back, and the Grace That Meets Me There

THERE IS A GRIEF in this book that I have carried beneath every chapter, and I want to bring it fully into the light before I close, because a confession that does not name the irrecoverable cost is not a complete confession, and I owe Susanna and I owe the truth a clear accounting of what cannot be undone.

I cannot get back the years. The early years of our marriage, the years when our sons were small, the years when Susanna most needed a present husband and got a ghost, those years are gone, and no repentance recovers them. I can change the present and I can hope for the future, but the past is fixed, and the past contains years of neglect that Susanna lived through and that cannot be relived, cannot be redone, cannot be given back to her in their proper form. There were birthdays I missed in spirit while present in body, seasons of her loneliness that I cannot retroactively

accompany, moments of her need that went unmet and will always have gone unmet, because they are in the past and the past does not change. The most painful truth of a repented neglect is that the repentance does not undo the neglect, that the wounds were real and were suffered and cannot be unsuffered, that Susanna carries in her history years that I gave to the church and cannot give back to her, and that grief is mine to carry for the rest of my life, the grief of the irrecoverable cost of my idolatry.

I cannot get back the things my sons watched in the worst years, the example of a father neglecting their mother in God's name, the template of marriage they absorbed from a marriage that was not worthy of being a template. I have tried to give them a better example since, the example of a father turning back, repenting, learning to love their mother, and I have to believe that the better example has done its own work. But I cannot erase what they saw in the early years, cannot reach back into their childhood and give them the present father they did not have, and whatever they carry from those years, I gave them, and I cannot take it back. The irrecoverable cost extends beyond Susanna to my sons and possibly beyond my sons to grandchildren I will never meet, because the patterns we set ripple forward in ways we cannot trace, and the neglect I practiced in the early years may echo in places I will never see.

*Repentance does not undo the neglect.
The wounds were real and cannot be
unsuffered.*

AND YET. I HAVE to write the and yet, because it is the truest thing in this book and the thing that keeps the grief from becoming despair. And yet there is a grace that meets me precisely here, in the place of the irrecoverable cost, a grace that does not undo the past but redeems it, that does not give back the years the locusts ate but does something stranger and deeper, restores, the prophet Joel says, the years the locusts have eaten, not by giving them back but by bringing out of the loss a fruit that the loss itself could not have produced. The grace that meets me in the place of the irrecoverable cost does not pretend the cost was not real, does not minimize the wounds, does not give back the lost years. It does something harder to believe, it takes the very failure and the very loss and weaves them into a redemption, makes the repented neglect the soil of a deeper marriage than we might have had without it, brings out of the wound a witness, out of the failure a testimony, out of the loss a love that is dearer for having been nearly lost.

I do not understand fully how this works, the way grace redeems what it does not undo, and I am suspicious of any account that makes it too neat, because the cost was real and the redemption does not erase it. But I have lived it, the strange grace that meets a man in the place of his irrecoverable failure and does not give him back what he lost but gives him something he could not have had without the losing, a humility, a tenderness, a dependence on grace, a marriage recovered from the edge of loss that holds its recovered delight more dearly than a marriage never lost could hold it. The grace does not justify the failure, does not make the neglect a good thing, does not mean I should be glad I wounded Susanna because look what grace did with it. That would be a monstrous theology, the using of grace to

excuse the sin. But the grace does meet me in the failure, does redeem what it does not undo, does bring out of the genuine loss a genuine fruit, and the holding of both truths at once, the real cost and the real redemption, is the closest I can come to the truth of where Susanna and I have arrived.

So I end this chapter, and nearly this book, in the place where the grief and the grace meet, in the honest naming of what I cannot get back and the honest testimony of the grace that meets me there. I cannot get back the years I gave the church that belonged to Susanna. The wounds were real and remain. And the God who restores the years the locusts have eaten has met me in the place of my irrecoverable failure and is making, out of a marriage I nearly destroyed, something I could not have built and do not deserve, a redeemed covenant that holds its recovered delight as the precious and undeserved grace it is. The cost is real. The grace is realer. And the marriage that ministry nearly cost me stands, by mercy, as a witness to the God who does not give back the lost years but redeems them, who meets the failed pastor in the place of his failure and does not excuse it but does not abandon him to it either, who is, in the end, the only hope any of us have, in marriage or in ministry or in the long obedience of staying, the God whose grace meets us exactly where we cannot get back what we lost.

CHAPTER FORTY-THREE

The Covenant That Outlasts the Church

I BEGAN THIS BOOK with a confession, that I almost lost Susanna to the church, and I want to end it with the truth that confession was always moving toward, the truth that is meant to leave weight and not relief, because relief would be a lie and weight is the only honest ending.

The church I serve will outlast me. That is as it should be. First Baptist Church of Fenton existed before I came and will exist after I am gone, will have other pastors, will forget my name in time the way every congregation forgets the names of the men who served it and moved on or died. I have given my life to this church and I do not regret it and I would give it again. But I have no illusions anymore about what the church will be to me at the end. The church will be served by my successor. The congregation that once needed me so desperately, that consumed my best hours and demanded everything, will transfer its need to the next man and will scarcely remember the one who came before. This is not a complaint. It is the nature of the church, which belongs to

Christ and not to its pastors, and which moves on, as it should, when its pastors are gone. But it means something for the question this book has been asking, because it means that the thing I nearly sacrificed my marriage to serve is a thing that will not finally be there for me, that will let me go, that will forget me, that was never mine to begin with.

And the covenant. The covenant will outlast the church, at least the church I serve, because when I am no longer the pastor of First Baptist, when the congregation has moved on to the next man, when my name is forgotten in the church I gave my life to, Susanna will still be my wife. The covenant I made with her at an altar, the covenant I nearly broke for the sake of the congregation that will forget me, is the covenant that will remain when the pastorate is gone, the relationship that will still be there when the church I sacrificed it to has transferred its need elsewhere. I nearly gave the permanent thing to the temporary thing. I nearly spent the covenant that will outlast my ministry on the congregation that will forget me. And the folly of that, the sheer folly of giving the lasting thing to the passing thing, is the folly this whole book has been confessing, the folly of a man who could not tell the difference between the church that would let him go and the wife who would not.

*I nearly gave the permanent thing to
the temporary thing.*

THERE IS A DEEPER sense, of course, in which the church does outlast everything, because the church is the bride of Christ and the bride of Christ is eternal, and in the new

creation there will be no marriage as we know it now, because the thing our marriages have been pointing to all along, the union of Christ and his church, will have arrived, and the sign will give way to the reality it signified. I know this. Marriage is a temporary institution in the deepest sense, a sign of the eternal marriage of Christ and the church, and in the resurrection the sign will be fulfilled and surpassed. But this truth, rightly understood, does not diminish the marriage covenant, it dignifies it, because it means that my marriage to Susanna is a sign of the most permanent thing of all, the eternal covenant of Christ and his bride, and that to neglect the sign for the sake of the institutional church is to neglect the very thing the sign was pointing to. My marriage points to Christ's love for the church more truly than my pastorate does, because my marriage is the living image God designed to display that love, and a man who destroys the image to serve the institution has things exactly backward.

So I leave you with the weight, and not with relief. The weight is this. The church will demand everything, and the church will, in the end, let you go, and the covenant you are tempted to sacrifice to the church is the covenant that will remain when the church has moved on, the relationship that images the eternal thing more truly than your ministry does, the first congregation God gave you and the last one who will still be there at the end. Do not give the lasting thing to the passing thing. Do not spend the covenant on the congregation that will forget you. Do not wake up, as I nearly did, at the end of a ministry, in the wreckage of a marriage you sacrificed to a church that has already transferred its need to your successor, holding nothing, having given the permanent thing to the temporary thing and lost them both. I nearly did this. By grace I did not. And the grace that spared me is

available to you, but the folly that nearly destroyed me is available to you too, and which one you live is being decided right now, in your calendar, in your hours, in whether you can tell the difference between the church that will let you go and the wife who will not.

Susanna is asleep in the next room as I write this last page, and she does not know I am writing about her, about us, about the years I nearly lost her and the grace that gave her back. She is asleep, and she is my wife, and she will be my wife when I am no longer anyone's pastor, when the church I gave my life to has forgotten my name, when everything I built in ministry has passed to other hands. She is the covenant that outlasts the church. She is the first congregation and the last. And the great work of my life, greater than any sermon I have preached or any church I have built, is the protecting of that covenant against the church that nearly took it, the long obedience of staying, the daily turning back toward the woman who will still be there at the end. I almost lost her to the church. I did not lose her. And the not-losing of her, by grace, against the demand of the church for everything, is the truest thing I have ever done, and the weight I leave you with is the weight of the choice that is still yours to make, in your own marriage, in your own ministry, tonight, while there is still time, while she is still in the next room, while the covenant can still be protected from the church that is quietly trying to take it. Go to her. The church will still be there in the morning. It always is. And one day it will be there without you. But tonight, she is yours, and you are hers, and the covenant is waiting to be chosen, again, in the long obedience of a love that stays.

CHAPTER FORTY-FOUR

A Benediction for the Marriage and the Ministry

I HAVE SPOKEN PLAINLY and at length about failure, and I do not want the last word of this book to be failure, because the last word of the gospel is never failure, it is grace, and so I want to end with a benediction, a word of blessing spoken over the ministry couple who has read this far, a word that gathers up everything and sends you back to your own home and your own marriage with a blessing rather than a burden.

May you see your wife. May you do the hard and humbling labor of seeing what she carries, the invisible load, the silenced honesty, the loneliness inside the marriage, the anger she was not allowed to have, and may the seeing break your heart, and may the broken heart be the beginning of a love that turns back. May you tend your first congregation before and beneath all your tending of the second, and may you discover that the tending of the marriage is not the enemy of the ministry but its source, that the church you

serve is served best by a man whose covenant is protected and whose home is whole. May you learn the word no, and may you say it to the church for the sake of the wife, and may the saying of it be the death of the idol of indispensability and the birth of a freedom you have never known.

May you keep a Sabbath and guard it, may you take the rest you have never trusted, may you build a private life the church does not own and defend it against the hunger that would consume it. May your calendar become a confession of the true faith, the faith that the covenant comes first, and may your wife read in the document that does not lie that she is treasured. May your repentance be more than words, may it change your life and not merely your feelings, and may you cast yourself on the grace that can change you because you cannot change yourself. May the delight return to your marriage, slowly, as the fruit of your faithfulness, and may you hold the recovered delight as the precious and undeserved grace it is.

*The last word of the gospel is never
failure. It is grace.*

AND MAY THE GOD who instituted marriage in the garden, before there was a temple or a congregation or a single soul to pastor, the God who commanded the man to leave and to hold fast to his wife and to become one flesh, the God who spoke of himself as a betrayed husband through the prophet Hosea and who stays in covenant with an unfaithful people, the God who in Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her, may that God meet you in your marriage and in your

ministry, may he heal what you have wounded and restore what you have lost, may he give you the long obedience of staying and the grace to keep turning back, and may he make your marriage a witness to the gospel more powerful than any sermon you will ever preach.

I have written this book from inside my own failure, and I have written it for you, the pastor whose marriage is being consumed by the church, the wife who is dying quietly in the role, the couple who cannot imagine a way out of the trap I was caught in. I have told you the truth about the pressures, and I have told you the truth about the grace, and I have tried not to soften either one. The church will demand everything. The covenant can be protected. The marriage that ministry nearly destroys can be, by grace, redeemed. And the choice is yours, tonight, in your own home, while there is still time. Go and protect the covenant. Go and tend your first congregation. Go and choose, again, in the long obedience of a love that stays, the woman God gave you before he gave you the church. And may the grace that met me at the bottom of my failure meet you wherever you are, and may it be enough, as it has been enough for me, as it is enough for all of us who have nearly lost the thing that mattered most and been given it back by a mercy we did not earn and cannot lose. Amen.